

If You Want to Be Remembered, Write

The Life and Journal of Roscoe D. Cunningham (1923–2020)

Assembled from his own columns, the tribute edition of The Sumner Press, the court reports of Illinois, the Illinois Blue Book, and the memories of the people of Lawrence County.

"We would remind of Bacon's major truth, 'To be remembered, write.'" — Roscoe's Journal, February 22, 2018

Contents

Prologue — Room 600

Chapter 1 — Lukin (1923–1941)

Chapter 2 — Forward Observer (1942–1946)

Chapter 3 — Counselor (1948–1970)

Chapter 4 — Springfield (1971–1979)

Chapter 5 — The Loss (1978)

Chapter 6 — The Hutton School (1981–1989)

Chapter 7 — The Rescue (1987)

Chapter 8 — The Journal (the voice)

Chapter 9 — A Churchgoing Skeptic

Chapter 10 — The Long Twilight (2018–2020)

Chapter 11 — We Remember (December 2020)

Epilogue — The Footprint (2026)

Prologue — Room 600

In February 1946 the most closely watched room in Europe was a courtroom. Room 600 of the Palace of Justice in Nuremberg was famously too small for the event it held — the victorious Allies trying the surviving leadership of the Third Reich before the International Military Tribunal, under floodlights, before the world press, behind rings of armed military police. The trial had opened the previous November. By February the prosecution was deep into its case, and in the dock, front row, sat Hermann Göring, Rudolf Hess, and Field Marshal Wilhelm Keitel.

Into that room, without a pass, without orders, without any business being there at all, walked a twenty-two-year-old artillery first lieutenant from Lawrence County, Illinois, on a supply run for bed cots.

We know this happened for one reason: he wrote it down.



He wrote it down late. Roscoe D. Cunningham was ninety-five years old when he set the story in type, on page 3 of *The Sumner Press*, the weekly paper he had owned since 1987 and filled, three columns at a time, every Tuesday evening for thirty-three years. The column was called Roscoe's Journal, and its March 14, 2019 installment did not begin with Nuremberg. It began, in the way of his columns, with whatever was in front of him — that week, daylight saving time, which had just returned to "County Lawrence" and which he was prepared to defend against all comers. He works through an Indian-chief cartoon about cutting a piece off one end of a blanket, threatens a Press crusade for year-round daylight time, and then, with no transition beyond his usual triple-x section break, drops into the real subject:

Audacity is a quality of conduct that will serve one well, lifetime. It should be taught to children as they leave the cradle with refresher courses along life's path.

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

And then the credential for the claim:

Looking back, we realized how fortunate we were to be reared in an enlightened family in the tough east end of Sumner. Audacity was included in our educational curriculum.

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

The "we," it should be said once here, is not royal exactly — it is the editorial "we" of the small-town publisher, and he used it even about his own boyhood. When the story turns most personal,

the "we" sometimes slips to "I," and you can watch it happen in this very column.

He warms up with a lesser heist first. Forty years earlier — this would be the late 1970s, when he was an Illinois state legislator — he found himself in an Atlanta hotel where President Carter's embattled budget director was holding a news conference:

40 years ago we were in a hotel in Atlanta when Burt Lence, President Carter's embattled budget director, was holding a news conference. We observed that each male reporter grasped the lapel of his coat, flipped it open and quickly back in position as he marched through the check point.

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

The name as printed is "Burt Lence" — the man was Bert Lance, and the misspelling is preserved here as it ran, because this book quotes him as he wrote, misprints and all. What matters is what the state representative from Lawrenceville did with his observation:

We duplicated those movements and found ourselves welcomed inside the checkpoint, sans any credential except audacity.

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

It was delightful. We met the lovely Mrs. Lence. She said, "Burt, I want you to meet Roscoe."

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

Sans any credential except audacity. He had been saving that phrase, one suspects, for a long time. And having established the method on a budget director, he reaches back to the biggest door he ever talked his way through:

Years earlier, February 1946, the colonel sent us, with trucks, cheap and three soldiers from Salzburg, Austria, to near Bonm, Germany, for steel bed cots for the soldiers in our battalion. We had met a Major Hamm, Luxembourg, at the University of Nancy, France. He mentioned the Nuremberg War Criminal Trials would start shortly, that he would get us in the small courtroom. It seemed the right moment to drive a few unauthorized kilometers for a quick inspection of that historic event.

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

The line is garbled in the printing — "with trucks, cheap and three soldiers" almost certainly left his typewriter as "trucks, a jeep, and three soldiers," and "Bonm" is surely Bonn. The column survives only as a scan of the printed page, and the print itself was set by a man in his mid-nineties. The book keeps the errata; the reader can hear through them. Nuremberg, as it happens, sits close by the road north from Salzburg toward the Rhineland — "a few unauthorized kilometers" is the joke of a man who knew exactly how many kilometers, and how unauthorized.

Then the plan fell apart, and the column arrives at its center:

Hamm had vanished. We chose to march past the armed M.P.'s with other military tribunal officials. Within three minutes we were standing eyeball to eyeball with the seated Herman Goering, Rudolf Hess, Marshal Keitel and the other alleged war criminals. Then, audacity failed us. We didn't ask Goering for his autograph though we were close enough to touch him.

(*Journal, March 14, 2019*)

Note what the sentence does not do. It does not describe the room, the light, or how he felt — no trembling, no awe, none of the upholstery a lesser storyteller would add. It reports a distance ("eyeball to eyeball," "close enough to touch him"), an elapsed time ("within three minutes"), and a failure. Seventy-three years of retelling had sanded the story down to its load-bearing facts, and the fact he kept was the one against himself: *audacity failed us*. He had marched past the armed guards of the most secure trial in human history, and then lost his nerve at the autograph.

He knew, even at ninety-five, exactly what he had left on the table:

What a souvenir it would have been. Court martial would have surely followed, "conduct unbecoming an American officer." If we had had a smart phone with us, we would have made an instant "selfie". It would have been priceless, and probably defensible as meaning, subservient vanquished.

(*Journal, March 14, 2019*)

A ninety-five-year-old man imagining the selfie he would have taken with Hermann Göring in February 1946 — and then, prosecutor to the end, drafting the legal defense for it. The column's final item begins:

Now I realize that the phone was unborn at time. That marvelous It opens the world for audacity unlim[ited]

(*Journal, March 14, 2019*)

That is where the surviving text stops — not where he stopped, but where the scan does. The column ran to the edge of its printed box and the digitized page cuts off mid-word: *audacity unlim* —. There may be no fitter place for the record of Roscoe Cunningham's life to fray.



A story like this one, told once, by its hero, at ninety-five, deserves a skeptic's look. So let us give it one, because the record — thin as it is in places — holds up better than it has any right to.

Start with where he was. His obituary records that he "proudly served in the United States Army, Rainbow Division 4th Operations as a forward Observer with the artillery division" in the European Theater, and was "honorably discharged from active duty in 1946, with the rank of 1st Lieutenant" (Obituary). The Rainbow Division is the 42nd Infantry Division, which fought through Alsace, took part in the liberation of Dachau, and ended the war in Austria — where it stayed on occupation duty, headquartered in and around Salzburg, into 1946 [web-findings: NARA/42nd Div ETO record]. A first lieutenant of divisional artillery, in Salzburg, in February 1946, sent north with trucks to scrounge cots for his battalion: every element of the frame is exactly where the 42nd Division actually was.

The University of Nancy detail — the unlikeliest-sounding part — is the best-attested part. His official biography in the Illinois Blue Book, printed while he served in the state House, lists his education as including the Université de Nancy, France [BB 1971-72 p.282]. And he had already told the story of how he got there, four years before the Nuremberg column, in a Veterans Day issue:

Before the war, I worked 35 hours a week at 35 cents an hour to attend the University of Illinois. After the war, the taxpayers paid to attend to finish my education. I would feel as resided above even if not a bird colonel from Brown County, Ohio told me at Salzburg, October 19,'45 "Lt. You've been kicked around in the Army enough. I'm sending you to the University of Nancy for a semester."

(Journal, November 12, 2015)

October 19, 1945, at Salzburg — a date he still carried, quoted with the colonel's county of origin attached. The Army ran soldier-student detachments at European universities in that idle winter between victory and demobilization; that is where a lieutenant from Sumner, Illinois would plausibly meet a Major Hamm of Luxembourg, and that is what he says happened. Of Major Hamm himself the record shows nothing further — a name, a country, a promise, a vanishing. He is beyond checking, and this book will not pretend otherwise.

Then there is the dock. He names three men: "the seated Herman Goering, Rudolf Hess, Marshal Keitel." In the famous photographs of Room 600, the front row of the defendants' dock runs, left to right: Göring, Hess, Ribbentrop, Keitel. An old man inventing a scene from newsreels might name the famous ones too — but he would be as likely to say Speer, or Ribbentrop, or "the Nazis." What Roscoe names is the front row, the three faces nearest a man standing at the rail. It proves nothing. It is simply what the view from that spot contained.

And the timing is right. The tribunal sat from November 1945 to October 1946; in February 1946 the prosecution was presenting its case, the defendants were produced in the dock daily, and visitors' passes to the small gallery were a prized commodity among Allied officers. That an officer

without one might simply fall in behind "other military tribunal officials" and walk past the MPs is the kind of thing that is impossible until someone with sufficient audacity does it.



But the strongest corroboration is not documentary at all. It is that he had been telling this story, the same story, for sixty-seven years before he printed it — and a witness to the telling survives.

In December 2020, ten days after Roscoe died at ninety-seven, The Sumner Press published a tribute edition. Among the twenty-six remembrances was one from Allen Johnson, reaching back to 1952, when Roscoe was a young lawyer with an office over a gas station in Lawrenceville:

In 1952, I was a high school student working at Paul Leach's Texaco gas station at State and 10th Street in Lawrenceville. Roscoe's law office was on the second floor over Leach's station office. Roscoe used to come down and shoot the breeze with us grease monkeys when he wasn't busy. He would regale us with stories of his heroic exploits in Germany during World War II, like sneaking into the Nuremberg War Trials.

(Allen Johnson, tribute, December 3, 2020)

There it is. Not a story minted for a late-life column, but a story already in circulation in 1952 — six years after the fact, told downstairs at the Texaco to boys pumping gas, by a twenty-nine-year-old lawyer between clients. The teenage grease monkey remembered it for sixty-eight years and, when the teller died, sent it back to the paper the teller owned. Sneaking into the Nuremberg War Trials, plural exploits, Germany, World War II: the 2019 column and the 1952 barbershop-radius legend are the same tale, and the half-century between the two tellings is exactly what a true story looks like when it lives in one man's repertoire that long.



Honesty requires the other side of the ledger, so here it is. No pass, no orders, no photograph, no diary from February 1946 has been found. His military personnel file has not yet been requested from the national records center. The Illinois Veterans History Project holds a single slim document under his name, dated 1943–1951, contributed in 2008 — likely by Roscoe himself, at eighty-four [IVHP 5341]. Which of the 42nd Division's field artillery battalions he served in is not yet established; the colonel who sent him for cots, like the colonel who sent him to Nancy, goes unnamed in every telling; Major Hamm of Luxembourg has left no other trace. The story rests, finally, on the word of the man it flatters.

But consider the man's relationship to that kind of word. He spent four terms as a county prosecutor and seventy-two years at the bar; he understood evidence, and he understood the

difference between a story and a sworn statement. And in the same Veterans Day column that preserved the bird colonel, he filed his own disclaimer against war-hero inflation, in words that ought to hang over every page of this prologue:

Of Salute to Veterans, well meaning citizens are saluting the wrong group. Only heroes are the dead, from battle injury: and those who have serious injury. Rest of us are lucky stiffes who savored life's grand adventure.

(Journal, November 12, 2015)

A man building a legend does not call himself a lucky stiff. The Nuremberg story as Roscoe tells it is not a war story at all — no combat, no danger except to his commission, and a punch line at his own expense. He is not the hero of it. Audacity is. He is merely its witness, and its beneficiary, and once — at the moment of the autograph — its disappointment.



Here is the thing to hold onto, because it is the argument of this entire book.

Roscoe Cunningham stood close enough to touch Hermann Göring in February 1946, and for seventy-three years that fact existed nowhere but in the air — in stories told to grease monkeys at Leach's Texaco, to five children, to courthouse hallways and Rotary lunches and anyone who would listen across three-quarters of a century. Spoken words, every one of them now gone. If that had remained the story's only medium, it would have died on November 28, 2020, in Lawrenceville, Illinois, with the last man who was in the room.

It did not die, because on a Tuesday evening in March 2019, a ninety-five-year-old publisher sat down at The Sumner Press, as he had on some seventeen hundred Tuesday evenings before, and typed it — between a defense of daylight saving time and a joke about selfies — into a column read by a few thousand people in Lawrence County, Illinois. The paper was scanned. The scan survived. A grandson found it.

A year before the Nuremberg column, facing the possibility that no one would take the paper off his hands, Roscoe told his readers exactly why this mattered, citing his authority as he so often did — a great man, slightly misquoted, wholly understood:

We would remind of Bacon's major truth, "To be remembered, write."

(Journal, February 22, 2018)

He wrote. This is what he wrote, and what it made of him. The offices he held — prosecutor, legislator, litigator, publisher — left records; the writing left *him*: the lapel flip in Atlanta, the

vanished Major Hamm, the three minutes eyeball to eyeball, the autograph he was too careful to ask for and never stopped regretting. Every chapter that follows exists because a man in a small town believed that the writing was the remembering, and acted on the belief three times a week until three weeks before he died.

The column about the greatest audacity of his life is cut off by the edge of a scanned box, mid-word, reaching for *unlimited*.

This book is the rest of the sentence.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal, March 14, 2019 — the audacity column (daylight saving time; Bert Lance checkpoint, printed "Burt Lence"; Nuremberg infiltration; the truncated final item). Quoted verbatim from the corpus transcription (roscoe-journal-complete.md); column truncated at scanned box edge.

Roscoe's Journal, November 12, 2015 — Veterans Day column: Salzburg, October 19, 1945; the "bird colonel from Brown County, Ohio"; University of Nancy; "lucky stiffs" passage.

Roscoe's Journal, February 22, 2018 — Bacon's maxim, "To be remembered, write."

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 — obituary (Rainbow Division, forward observer, European Theater, discharge as 1st Lieutenant, 1946) and Allen Johnson's tribute (1952 Texaco corroboration).

Illinois Blue Book 1971–72, pp. 282–283 — official member biography listing Université de Nancy, France, and WWII Field Artillery Forward Observer, ETO [BB 1971-72 p.282], via Illinois Digital Archives (book/sources/web-findings.json).

Illinois Veterans History Project, Illinois Digital Archives record 5341 — single digitized document, "Cunningham, Roscoe D.," dated 1943–1951, contributed 2008 [IVHP 5341] (book/sources/web-findings.json).

42nd (Rainbow) Infantry Division ETO/occupation context (Alsace, Dachau, Austria; Salzburg occupation; candidate FA battalions 232nd/392nd/402nd/542nd) — book/sources/web-findings.json (NARA AAD; Rainbow Division Veterans Memorial Foundation).

International Military Tribunal general history (Room 600, Palace of Justice; trial dates November 20, 1945–October 1, 1946; dock seating) — common historical record; no claim herein depends on more than its broadest outline.

Known gaps stated in text: NPRC military personnel file not yet requested; FA battalion unidentified; Major Hamm and both colonels unverified beyond Roscoe's account (see GAPS.md).

Chapter 1 — Lukin (1923–1941)

He was born twice-named before he could object to either. Roscoe David Cunningham arrived on September 15, 1923, in Lukin, Lawrence County, Illinois, the son of Roscoe and Bessie Cooper Cunningham — a boy given his father's name in a place where the father's name already meant something. He did not arrive alone. His twin sister Ruth came with him, and she would outlive him: when he died ninety-seven years later, the obituary listed among his survivors "one twin sister - Ruth Simms, Bridgeport, Illinois" (Obituary). Whatever else the century did to Roscoe Cunningham, it never separated the twins by more than a county road.

The records disagree gently about where, exactly, "Lukin" was. The obituary says he was born "in Lukin" (Obituary). His official biography in the Illinois Blue Book, written when he entered the legislature, says he was born in Lukin Township and reared in Sumner [BB 1971-72 p.282]. The census found the family in Lukin Township in both 1930 and 1940, a child and then a teenager in the enumerator's columns [web-findings: 1930/1940 census, FamilySearch]. The likeliest reconciliation is the ordinary one — Lukin is the township, Sumner the town within its reach — but I flag it rather than smooth it: this book prefers a visible seam to an invented certainty. What is certain is the county. Lawrence County, in the oil-and-corn flatlands of southeastern Illinois against the Wabash River, was where he was born, and — with the exception of a war and eight years of legislative sessions — it is where every chapter of this book takes place.

The household he was born into was not small. Besides the twins there were Mary Ellen, Martha, and Joseph Cooper Cunningham, all of whom he would outlive (Obituary). The father, Roscoe Sr. of Lukin, shows up in the county's newspapers as far back as the 1910s — the digitized archive's hits on the name "Roscoe Cunningham" before 1948 belong mostly to him, not to his son [web-findings: Lawrence Public Library archive survey]. The son would eventually generate over a thousand pages of his own coverage, but in 1923 the name in the paper still meant the farmer, not the infant.

Of Bessie Cooper Cunningham the surviving record says almost nothing beyond her name, and I will not pretend otherwise. No letters, no interviews, no column devoted to her has yet been recovered. What we have instead is her son's single, deliberate sentence about the family she ran — written when he was ninety-five, looking back across the whole distance:

"Looking back, we realized how fortunate we were to be reared in an enlightened family in the tough east end of Sumner. Audacity was included in our educational curriculum."

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

"Enlightened" and "tough" in the same breath — that is as close to a portrait of the household as he ever gave. The column that sentence comes from is the same one in which he tells the story of sneaking into the Nuremberg trials, and the architecture of it is worth noticing: he does not present audacity as something the Army taught him, or the law, or politics. He presents it as a homegrown crop, planted in the east end of Sumner before he was old enough to shave. In the same column he turns it into doctrine:

"Audacity is a quality of conduct that will serve one well, lifetime. It should be taught to children as they leave the cradle with refresher courses along life's path."

(Journal, March 14, 2019)

That is the thesis of his childhood, stated by the only surviving witness. Everything else in this chapter is corroborating detail.



The Sumner he grew up in was a Depression town, and he knew it. He rarely wrote about the 1930s directly — the columns we have begin in 2013, when he was ninety, and he was always more interested in next week than in 1934 — but when the subject of hardship came up, he claimed his decade with something close to pride:

"Children reared in poverty often succeed because of the ingrained appreciation acquired from that poverty. Especially those raised in Sumner in the 1930's."

(Journal, November 6, 2014)

He writes that sentence, characteristically, not as memoir but as ammunition — he is scolding the local high school band for turning down ten-dollar bills, and the Sumner of the 1930s is his exhibit A. But it is the only time in the recovered columns that he sets his own childhood explicitly in its economic decade, and the phrase "ingrained appreciation acquired from that poverty" is the closest he comes to admitting the family was poor. A word of caution belongs here: the broader Depression story of Lawrence County — what the oil fields did, what the farms lost, who left — is not yet in this book's sources. The pre-1972 run of The Sumner Press is digitized and searchable, and a future edition can draw the county's 1930s from its own pages. For now the honest statement is that Roscoe grew up in a poor town in a poor decade, said so once, and considered it an asset.



Religion arrived in Sumner under canvas. In a 2017 column, prompted by nothing more than a stray thought about atheism, he reaches back to the traveling preachers of his boyhood:

"Early in the 20th Century, Judge J. F. Rutherford said in a sermon 'millions now living will never die.'"

(Journal, July 20, 2017)

"The thought hit a responsive chord and spread widely about the nation. Writer remembers tent revivals in Sumner while an early teen in which the ministers stressed that the end of time was near. One never hears such predictions now. It were as though time of the Second Coming was faith's Achilles heel."

(Journal, July 20, 2017)

"While an early teen" puts those tents in the mid-1930s, and the passage is pure Roscoe: the memory is warm, the analysis is cold, and the two live comfortably in one paragraph. He remembers the urgency of the preaching — the end of time was near — and then, eighty years on, files the failed prediction as a structural weakness in the product. This is the churchgoing skeptic of Chapter 9 already fully formed, or rather forming: a boy in a revival tent who believed enough to remember and doubted enough to keep score.

The permanent version of that religion, the one that stuck, came from scripture learned early. His obituary records that one of his favorite Bible verses was Luke 9:62 — "No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God" — and adds: "Instilled since childhood, this verse inspired him to rescue his hometown newspaper, The Sumner Press in 1987" (Obituary). Take the family's word for the chronology: the verse was planted in Lukin, and it germinated sixty-some years later at a newspaper auction. A plow verse, for a farm township. It is hard to invent a more fitting catechism, which is exactly why this book didn't have to.



The county he grew up in was written on. Its barns and roadsides carried text, and the boy who would spend thirty-three years filling a page-3 column started life reading his landscape in passing. He set the memory down in January 2018:

"Sixty years ago, in a gentler, happier time highway travel was slow enough that road signs were feasible. The signs were informational, commercial and/or amusement."

(Journal, January 11, 2018)

A dating note, in the interest of honesty: "sixty years ago" from 2018 lands in the late 1950s, when he was a young lawyer, not a boy — though the Burma-Shave signs he goes on to quote had lined American highways since the 1920s. Whether he first read this one at ten or at thirty-five, the record doesn't say; what the record preserves is that he could still recite it at ninety-four:

"I asked Ida Ida refused Ida won my Ida If Ida used Burma-Shave"

(Journal, January 11, 2018)

"Another memorable sign, 'There is nothing like money in the bank.' First National Bank of Salem"

(Journal, January 11, 2018)

And then the sign that outlasted the jingles:

"Shortly there after a sign appeared on the barn at Clement Buchanan farm, 5 miles south Lawrenceville, Route I. It read 'Where will you spend eternity?'"

(Journal, January 11, 2018)

"We thought the sign unusual, even too religious."

(Journal, January 11, 2018)

Too religious — from the man who taught Sunday School for decades and attended First Christian Church for sixty-six years (Obituary). But he was not finished with the Buchanan barn. The column closes the distance between the young driver and the old publisher in a single sentence:

"As we approach the end of life's trail we recognize that the sign on the Buchanan Barn is more significant for us, and for all users of the public way than any other."

(Journal, January 11, 2018)

He was ninety-four when he wrote that, and he had two years left. The shape of the thought — a shaving-cream jingle and an eternity question sharing the same roadside, remembered together, ranked at the end — is the shape of the man. Wit and eternity rode the same highway his whole life. He quoted both verbatim.



Sumner High School is the one institution of his childhood he wrote about repeatedly, and always in the same key: mock-heroic on the surface, dead serious underneath. The obituary states the family's understanding plainly: "Cunningham always attributed his love of learning, and his ability to eloquently quote poetry to his education at 'Sumner High'" (Obituary). The columns supply the faculty roster. When a national news anchor excused himself with the word "conflation," Roscoe filed a dissent on behalf of his English teachers:

"Those of us blessed by four years of English under the stern Fern Henry and Bess Boley at Sumner High never heard that word."

(Journal, April 9, 2015)

He had made the same point two months earlier, with the curriculum attached:

"We were intrigued by 'conflated.' Those who attended Sumner High, Fern Henry and Bess Boley English classes, believe they know all the words. Graduates of Miss Henry's Latin courses are doubly fortified."

(Journal, February 12, 2015)

Four years of English under stern women, plus Latin. That is the entire documented syllabus of Sumner High as he recorded it, and it is enough to explain a great deal — the "nonpareil"s and "condition precedent"s that salt his columns, the poetry the obituary mentions, the lifelong conviction that he owned the language. He kept auditing the old coursework into his last year. In April 2020, quarantined at ninety-six, he opens a column:

"Eighty years ago, students at Sumner High were taught that the Gettysburg Address and the Lord's Prayer were splendid examples of succinctly stating the message sought to be conveyed."

(Journal, April 30, 2020)

— and then, being Roscoe, spends the rest of the item proposing amendments to both Lincoln and the Lord. Six months later, three weeks before his final column, the school appears one last time:

"When we graduated from Sumner High School, 1941, we thought we knew every word we would ever need in life."

(Journal, October 8, 2020)

He was not above noting the gaps in the curriculum. Called outside by a grandson one night in 2015 to see a red moon, he confessed himself baffled and resolved to consult Wikipedia: "Sumner High was deficient in astrology." (Journal, October 1, 2015) He meant astronomy, almost certainly; the errata stay in, per this book's rules, because the slip is part of the voice.

The class of 1941 was twenty students. We know this because seventy-four years later he was still irritated about the senior trip:

"In 1941, Sumner High School sent the 20 members of its graduating class to Giant City State Park."

(Journal, April 30, 2015)

Grayville's seniors, he notes in the same column, had just been sent to Washington, Philadelphia, and New York, and the comparison stung across three-quarters of a century: "What the SHS children needed least was more exposure to rural America. How we envy GSH students, to savor big city America in one magnificent week." (Journal, April 30, 2015) Then the verdict, teachers exempted, in his own compressed grammar: "Our Class was blessed with several extraordinary teachers: The curse of small townints did not infect us, but the trip to Giant City State Park was a waste of time--life's most valuable component." (Journal, April 30, 2015)

Read that item again and you can see the whole later career in embryo. A boy from the tough east end, armed with Fern Henry's English and a certainty that he deserved the big rooms, gets bused to a state park an hour from home and never forgets it. Within five years of that trip he would talk his way past armed military police into the courtroom at Nuremberg. Within forty he would be arguing in Springfield. The audacity curriculum worked; the field-trip budget just never caught up to the student.



And always, there was Ruth. The twins turned everything into a two-person institution, including arithmetic. In 2016, after a filling-station philosopher named Jim Lockhart observed that people born on February 29 "never grow old," Roscoe saw the loophole and filed a joint claim:

"In the interim my twin sister and I shall not await the study; we are persuaded that if ignored, these years will pass away without harm to the carrier. Do not expect an invitation from us for a birthday party on September 15. Do not send presents either. Let us find the fountain of youth together."

(Journal, March 3, 2016)

Together — the word doing quiet work at the end of the joke. They were ninety-two when he wrote it. Three years earlier, the week they turned ninety, his Journal column of September 5, 2013 says nothing about the birthday at all; it is busy with Labor Day, the marching band, and Syria (Journal, September 5, 2013). That silence is in character — family news belonged in his Countywide column on the back page, not in the Journal — and the project's survey of the editions places the twins' ninetieth-birthday announcement in Countywide that September. But Countywide is not yet transcribed, and that survey note could not be re-verified against the page for this draft, so it stands here flagged rather than quoted [Countywide, 2013-09-05 edition — untranscribed; unverified survey note]. When the back-page columns are recovered, the ninetieth birthday of Roscoe and Ruth will be told in his own words. Until then, honesty requires the blank.

The blank is worth sitting with for a moment, because it is the shape of this whole chapter. Of his first eighteen years we hold: an obituary paragraph, a Blue Book line, two census placements, and

perhaps a dozen backward glances scattered through columns written in his tenth decade. No diaries, no report cards, no photographs yet recovered, no interview in which anyone asked him what Bessie's kitchen smelled like. The man who preserved his county's record for thirty-three years left his own childhood mostly unrecorded — or recorded it the only way he ever recorded anything, sideways, in service of a point about band students or Brian Williams or the Lord's Prayer. This book quotes what he wrote and refuses to fill the gaps with scenery. Where the tent revival stood, what the east end actually looked like in 1935, which teacher he feared and which he loved — the columns don't say, so the book doesn't either.



In the fall of 1941 he left for the University of Illinois (Obituary). He was eighteen, one of twenty in his class, carrying the east-end curriculum: four years of stern English, Miss Henry's Latin, a plow verse, a memorized shaving-cream jingle, an eternity question read from a barn, and audacity — taught from the cradle, refresher courses to follow. The obituary compresses what happened next into a subordinate clause: "his education was temporarily put on hold as he served his country in World War II European Operations" (Obituary). December came, and the war reached even Lukin Township.

He would come back. That is the thing to hold at the end of this chapter, because it is the least obvious fact of his biography. The pattern of his generation's ambitious small-town boys — the pattern he grumbled about for decades in print, luring "worthwhile citizens back to the land of their childhood" — was to leave for the university, the war, the city, and not return. Roscoe Cunningham saw Nancy, Salzburg, and Nuremberg before he was twenty-three, and then he came home to Lawrence County and stayed for the next seventy-four years. Lukin was not what he escaped. It was what he defended — in court, in Springfield, and finally, three columns a week, in print.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal columns (verbatim from `roscoe-journal-complete.md`, cited inline by date): September 5, 2013; November 6, 2014; February 12, 2015; April 9, 2015; April 30, 2015; October 1, 2015; March 3, 2016; July 20, 2017; January 11, 2018; March 14, 2019; April 30, 2020; October 8, 2020.

Obituary, The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`): birth date and place, parents, siblings, twin sister Ruth Simms, Sumner High class of 1941, love of learning and poetry, Luke 9:62 "instilled since childhood," First Christian Church membership, University of Illinois attendance interrupted by WWII.

Illinois Blue Book 1971–72, pp. 282–283 — "born Lukin Township, reared in Sumner" [BB 1971-72 p.282], via `book/sources/web-findings.json` (idaillinois.org, confirmed).

Census traces, 1930 and 1940, Lukin Township, Lawrence County (FamilySearch), via `book/sources/web-findings.json`.

Lawrence Public Library digital archive survey (pre-1948 "Roscoe Cunningham" hits are mostly his father, Roscoe Sr. of Lukin), via `book/sources/web-findings.json`.

Flagged, not verified: the Countywide announcement of his and Ruth's 90th birthday (2013-09-05 edition) — column untranscribed; the survey note could not be re-checked against the page for this draft. Broader Depression-era Lawrence County context is deliberately thin pending the 1882–1972 digitized Sumner Press run (see `FOOTPRINT.md`, Tier 1 item 13).

Chapter 2 — Forward Observer (1942–1946)

When Roscoe Cunningham graduated from Sumner High School in the spring of 1941, the war was already two years old everywhere but here. He went up to the University of Illinois that fall, a farm-country freshman paying his own way. He never forgot the arithmetic of it. "Before the war, I worked 35 hours a week at 35 cents an hour to attend the University of Illinois," he writes, seventy-four years later, in a Veterans Day column. "After the war, the taxpayers paid to attend to finish my education" (Journal, November 12, 2015). Between those two sentences — before the war, after the war — sit the four years this chapter has to account for, and it must be said at the outset that they are the thinnest-documented years of his life.

Here is what the record firmly gives us. The obituary: "Attending the University of Illinois after high school, his education was temporarily put on hold as he served his country in World War II European Operations. Cunningham proudly served in the United States Army, Rainbow Division 4th Operations as a forward Observer with the artillery division. Assignments often involved aeronautical observation of the dropping of bombs on enemy locations. He was honorably discharged from active duty in 1946, with the rank of 1st Lieutenant" (Obituary). The Illinois State Bar Association's memorial notice condenses it the same way: Rainbow Division, first lieutenant, "aerial bomb-drop observation," European theater [ISBA Bar News, Dec. 2020]. His official Illinois Blue Book biography, printed when he entered the legislature a quarter century after the fact, states it in the state's own shorthand: World War II Field Artillery Forward Observer, European Theater of Operations; University of Nancy, France [BB 1971–72 p.282]. And the Illinois State Library holds a record he contributed himself, at eighty-four, to the Illinois Veterans History Project — a single digitized document whose date range reads 1943–1951 [IVHP record 5341, Illinois Digital Archives]. The 1943 start suggests he entered the Army the year he turned twenty; the 1951 end date suggests reserve service that outlasted his 1946 discharge from active duty by five years. His full military personnel file has not yet been requested from the National Personnel Records Center in St. Louis, and until it is, that date range is the closest thing we have to official bookends.

That is the skeleton. The flesh — as with everything in this book — comes from the columns. He did not write a war memoir. He wrote three columns a week about highway funding and presidential politics and the price of soybeans, and every so often, without warning, a paragraph would open onto 1945.



Start with Fort Sill. In the summer of 2014, when the Associated Press described the Oklahoma artillery post as "an outpost in hot dusty south Oklahoma," the ninety-year-old publisher of The Sumner Press took it personally. "Several Lawrence Countians have served at Ft. Sill. We know none who does not have an affection for the post. We recall the first sergeant advising 19 year old artillery recruits in June-August, 'You will find the ranges very warm, but a wind comes off Medicine Mountain in the evening. You will sleep under a blanket'" (Journal, July 17, 2014).

He was nineteen in the summer of 1943 — the arithmetic fits the Veterans History Project's start date exactly. So we can place him, with reasonable confidence, on the gunnery ranges of Fort Sill in the hot months of that year, a Lukin township boy learning the trade of field artillery under Medicine Mountain. The post stayed with him in stranger details too. In another column he recalls the Army's obsession with serial numbers — "beginning on Day 1 in the Army we were taught, 'Under the Geneva Convention if you are taken prisoner you are required only to give your name, rank and serial number.. Say no more, lest you give away military intelligence" (Journal, November 12, 2015) — and then, in the same column, delivers one of the oddest and most Roscoe stories in the whole archive. The serial number was stamped on clothing sent to the post laundry, which was staffed by German prisoners of war, and the laundry did not always send back what you sent in:

"Imprinted on clothes sent to the laundry the serial number was believed to increase the odds that one would receive same garments after cleaning. During basic training I received the smoothest blue silk girls' panties one can imagine. I did not send them to the laundry. Did wear a few times to wash hall in middle of the night. Decided that they might send wrong message. Returned them to management: well fed German POWs at Ftg. Sill, OK. Have often wondered how many of those POWs returned to the USA as immigrants, after the madness of war shalged" (Journal, November 12, 2015).

The last word is garbled — his columns, set in hot type by a very small staff and scanned decades later, carry their share of typographical scars, and this book preserves them rather than guessing at repairs. But the voice underneath is unmistakable: the deadpan, the self-mockery, the sudden widening of the lens at the end, from a laundry mix-up to the fates of enemy prisoners after "the madness of war." He was ninety-two when he wrote that paragraph about being nineteen.



A word about what a forward observer was, because the job title explains something about the man.

Field artillery in the Second World War killed at ranges of miles, over hills and through forests, at targets the gun crews never saw. Somebody had to see for them. The forward observer went ahead

— with the infantry, on a ridgeline, sometimes aloft in a light observation plane — found the target, called the first ranging round by radio or field telephone, watched where it landed, and talked the battery onto the mark: correction by correction, until fire for effect. It was a lieutenant's job, it required steadiness and arithmetic and a good pair of eyes, and it put the artilleryman in more danger than his guns ever faced, because the enemy understood perfectly well what a man on a hilltop with binoculars and a radio was doing there. The obituary's phrase — "aeronautical observation of the dropping of bombs on enemy locations" — points to the airborne version of the work, spotting from the little liaison aircraft the artillery used as flying observation posts. Its other phrase, "Rainbow Division 4th Operations," is not standard Army nomenclature, and no surviving family document explains it; it is preserved here as printed, one more small mystery for the service file to resolve.

The Rainbow itself — the 42nd Infantry Division — carried the most storied name in the National Guard, Douglas MacArthur's division of the First World War, drawn from so many states that it stretched across the country like a rainbow. In the second war it fought in the European theater in 1944 and 1945: the winter fighting in Alsace, the drive into Bavaria, the liberation of the Dachau concentration camp in the last days of April 1945, and the war's end in Austria, where the division settled into occupation duty [web-findings: 42nd Division ETO service; unit context via rainbowvets.org]. Its artillery comprised four field artillery battalions, and a forward observer would have belonged to one of them — which one, in Roscoe's case, we do not know. The honest position is this: the record proves he was a Rainbow Division artillery forward observer in the European theater, and the division's path is well documented, but no surviving document yet places Roscoe himself at any particular point on that path. He never wrote a combat column. In three hundred forty recovered columns there is no battle scene, no Alsace winter, no crossing of the Rhine — and no mention, not once, of Dachau. Whether that silence was reticence, or whether his duties kept him elsewhere, is exactly the kind of question the personnel file, or the full Veterans History Project folder, may someday answer. This book will not answer it for him.

What he did write about — repeatedly, vividly, and with obvious pleasure — was the summer the shooting stopped.



In the recovered columns, Roscoe's war begins in August 1945, which is to say it begins at the moment it ended. He was in southern France, at the staging grounds near Marseille where divisions were being processed for redeployment — because the Rainbow, like much of the Army in Europe, was slated for the Pacific and the invasion of Japan. Three separate columns, written across five years in his nineties, give us that summer almost week by week.

August 8: "August 8, 1945, Marseilles. A well intentioned colonel casually remarked, 'the joyride flight to Cairo is not authorized. If the plane should crash your mother would receive no insurance.' Another occupied the seat we had carefully wrangled for that trip. Loss was not as great as it could have been. Our admiration of the pyramids has long been diminished by comparison between the Wonders of the Ancient World" (Journal, November 22, 2018). Two days after Hiroshima, with the world pivoting on its hinge, Lieutenant Cunningham was trying to wangle a seat on an unauthorized sightseeing flight to Egypt. He never got over missing it, and never quite forgave the pyramids for it either.

Mid-August: "Mid-August, 1945, in the company of a group of Polish Army chaplains I was ushered into the Sistine Chapel, Vatican. Suddenly Pope Pius XII was being carried amongst us. He sprinkled holy water and pronounced a blessing" (Journal, October 1, 2015). He told this one, characteristically, not as a brush with history but as a complaint about technology: he had no camera, and seventy years later he watched pilgrims photographing Pope Francis and wished, he writes in the same column, that "I had had an I-phone that I might share the experience with you."

Late August, Rome: "It was late August, 1945. In carefree mood we had flown from Arles Staging Area, France, to Rome. Japan had given up, after Nagasaki. No longer would we dread the boat which was scheduled to take our division to Bombay, and the battle for the Japanese homeland" (Journal, November 9, 2017). That sentence about dread is the closest thing to a confession of fear anywhere in the recovered columns — and even here it arrives in a comic frame, because the column is really about a girl. In Rome he met Paula, "an older girl, maybe 26," an embassy employee with flawless English, and took her to dinner at the Hotel Excelsior — "where Goering had stayed when he was in Rome," he notes, unable to resist the detail. On a park bench near the hotel they were surrounded by a half dozen young Italian men, self-appointed enforcers against local girls fraternizing with American soldiers. Two of them pinned the lieutenant's arms. Paula talked calmly with the rest until they left, then explained: "I persuaded them that I am British." When he apologized for not putting up an impossible fight, she forgave him with the best line of the evening: "I knew that you would have confidence in my ability to outwit those thugs" (Journal, November 9, 2017).

The dread of Bombay dissolved with the atomic bomb, and Roscoe's gratitude for that fact hardened over the decades into settled doctrine. He returned to it in one of his final summers, on the seventy-fifth anniversary: "While the Press periodically rails against too many holidays in the U.S.A., one event does not receive the annual notice that its importance to mankind earned--dropping of the A-bomb on Hiroshima," he writes, going on to quote General MacArthur that "war has become too terrible to be an acceptable arbiter of national differences" (Journal, August 6,

2020). Whatever one makes of the argument, its origin is not abstract. He was a twenty-one-year-old with a berth on a boat to the invasion.



With Japan's surrender the Rainbow settled into occupation, and Roscoe's battalion settled into Salzburg, Austria. Occupation duty suited him about as well as one would expect audacity to suit garrison life, and the Army seems to have noticed. He preserved the moment of his deliverance with a dateline, as if filing a story: a full colonel — "a bird colonel from Brown County, Ohio" — took him aside at Salzburg on October 19, 1945, and said: "Lt. You've been kicked around in the Army enough. I'm sending you to the University of Nancy for a semester" (Journal, November 12, 2015).

What "kicked around" covered, he never explained. But the University of Nancy, in the old capital of Lorraine, was one of the schools where the Army parked bright soldiers awaiting shipment home, and it mattered enough to Roscoe that a quarter century later he listed it in his official legislative biography alongside the University of Illinois [BB 1971–72 p.282] — a Lukin township farm boy claiming, accurately, a French university education. It was at Nancy that he met a Major Hamm of Luxembourg, who mentioned that the war crimes trials at Nuremberg would be starting shortly and promised he could get Roscoe into the small courtroom (Journal, March 14, 2019).

The reader already knows how that turned out, because this book opened with it: the February 1946 truck detail from Salzburg to fetch steel cots for the battalion, the unauthorized kilometers to Nuremberg, the vanished Major Hamm, the march past the armed military police with no credential except audacity, and the three minutes spent standing eyeball to eyeball with Hermann Göring. What belongs in this chapter is not the story again but its residue — the way Nuremberg kept surfacing in his newspaper columns for the rest of his life, a private touchstone his readers could not have known was firsthand. When Vladimir Putin blinked over Ukraine in 2014, Roscoe reached for it: "we suspect that Vladimir also saw the spectre of the hangman's work after the Nuremberg War Crimes trial'. Perhaps that effort to establish the rule of law worldwide, so roundly criticized for almost 70 years, has been vindicated by rescuing civilization from its guaranteed destruction?" (Journal, March 6, 2014). A year later, arguing with the ghost of the man he had stood beside in the dock, he writes: "Though Hitler's #1 henchman, Herman Goering, delighted to remind the world that Americans, 'murdered the redskins' difference between Nazi behavior and ours is total" (Journal, April 30, 2015) — a column whose defense of the Indian reservations has aged as badly as anything he ever printed, and which is quoted here because the record of a man is the record of a man. The lawyer who spent seventy-two years in Illinois courtrooms had watched, at twenty-two, the twentieth century's most consequential attempt to put power itself on trial. He counted it vindicated.



He came home in 1946 with silver bars and the G.I. Bill, and went back to Champaign to finish what the war had interrupted — this time, as he liked to say, at the taxpayers' expense (Journal, November 12, 2015). The reserve obligation implied by the Veterans History Project's 1943–1951 date range apparently ran on quietly in the background of law school and the early law practice; no document yet found says what it involved, and no column mentions it. In 2008, at eighty-four, he sat down and contributed his service record to the Illinois Veterans History Project himself [IVHP record 5341] — which is, when you think about it, the same instinct that built everything else in this book: if you want to be remembered, write it down and file it somewhere public.

How did the war live in him afterward? Not as trauma, on any evidence we have, and not as glory either. His considered position on military heroism was severe and self-excluding: "Of Salute to Veterans, well meaning citizens are saluting the wrong group. Only heroes are the dead, from battle injury: and those who have serious injury. Rest of us are lucky stiff who savored life's grand adventure" (Journal, November 12, 2015). A lucky stiff who savored life's grand adventure — that is as close to a summary of Roscoe's war as Roscoe ever offered, and it should be weighed against the fact that he was a lifetime member of V.F.W. Post 2244 and the American Legion (Obituary), turned up at the courthouse-lawn Veterans Day observance into his nineties, and closed his 2015 Veterans Day column, girls'-panties story and all, with "God Bless the U.S. Armed Forces" (Journal, November 12, 2015).

The war also left him some of his worst reflexes. In the panicked weeks after the November 2015 Paris attacks, he reached back to it for a precedent and produced the single most jarring item in the recovered archive: "In WWII, Japanese Americans were put in con centration camps by FDR. Maybe time to ban from planes and large public gatherings women wearing clothes or hair style suggesting she thinks differently than we" (Journal, November 19, 2015). He states the internment plainly — camps, FDR's doing, no euphemism — and then, instead of drawing the obvious lesson, entertains its sequel. A grandson would prefer to skip that paragraph. It stays, because the thesis of this book is that the writing preserved the man, and the man it preserved was an eighty-year-old small-town editor of his time and place: capable of standing three feet from Göring and understanding exactly what unchecked power did, and capable, in a frightened season, of forgetting it in a single sentence.

Mostly, though, the war became stories — and the stories became currency, spent freely for seventy-five years on anyone within earshot. The earliest independent witness we have dates from 1952, only six years after his discharge, when a high schooler named Allen Johnson was pumping gas at Paul Leach's Texaco station in Lawrenceville, below the second-floor law office of the young attorney upstairs. "Roscoe used to come down and shoot the breeze with us grease monkeys when

he wasn't busy," Johnson remembered in the tribute edition, sixty-eight years later. "He would regale us with stories of his heroic exploits in Germany during World War II, like sneaking into the Nuremberg War Trials" (Allen Johnson, The Sumner Press, December 3, 2020).

That is the whole arc in one image: the forward observer's job was to go ahead, see what others could not see, and report back so the battery could find the range. He held the position for the rest of his life. Only the medium changed.



Sources

Roscoe's Journal columns, quoted verbatim from `roscoe-journal-complete.md`: July 17, 2014 (Fort Sill, Medicine Mountain); November 12, 2015 (35 cents an hour; Geneva Convention/serial numbers; German POWs at Ft. Sill; "Only heroes are the dead"; the Salzburg colonel and the University of Nancy; "God Bless the U.S. Armed Forces"); November 19, 2015 (Japanese internment item); October 1, 2015 (Sistine Chapel, Pius XII); November 9, 2017 (Arles to Rome, Bombay dread, Paula); November 22, 2018 (Marseilles, the Cairo joyride); March 6, 2014 (Nuremberg vindicated); April 30, 2015 (Göring "murdered the redskins"); August 6, 2020 (Hiroshima 75th anniversary, MacArthur); March 14, 2019 (Major Hamm, the February 1946 cot run — retold in full in the Prologue).

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`): obituary (service facts, discharge 1946 as 1st Lieutenant, "Rainbow Division 4th Operations," aeronautical observation, V.F.W./American Legion membership); Allen Johnson tribute (1952 Texaco stories).

ISBA Bar News memorial, "Roscoe D. Cunningham 1923–2020," December 2020 (Rainbow Division, 1st Lt., aerial bomb-drop observation) — via `book/sources/web-findings.json`.

Illinois Blue Book 1971–72, p. 282 (member biography: Field Artillery Forward Observer, ETO; University of Nancy, France), Illinois Digital Archives — via `book/sources/web-findings.json`.

Illinois Veterans History Project, record 5341 (document date range 1943–1951; contributed 2008), Illinois State Library / Illinois Digital Archives — via `book/sources/web-findings.json`.

42nd (Rainbow) Infantry Division ETO context (Alsace, Dachau, Austria; four field artillery battalions) — unit-history context recorded in `book/sources/web-findings.json` (NARA AAD and rainbowvets.org leads); Roscoe's individual path within the division is undocumented pending his NPRC personnel file and the full IVHP folder, both flagged in `GAPS.md`-style open items.

Chapter 3 — Counselor (1948–1970)

On May 17, 1948, the Supreme Court of Illinois admitted Roscoe David Cunningham to the practice of law. The record of that admission still exists, and it is worth pausing over, because it is one of the very few documents that measure his whole professional life in a single glance. The Illinois Attorney Registration and Disciplinary Commission — the body that licenses and, when necessary, punishes every lawyer in the state — keeps a public card on every attorney who ever practiced. His reads: Full Licensed Name, Roscoe David Cunningham. Date Admitted, May 17, 1948. Status, Deceased — Last Registered Year: 2020. Public Record of Discipline and Pending Proceedings: none [IARDC, adm. May 17, 1948].

Read that last line again. He was a lawyer for seventy-two years — through four terms as a county prosecutor, eight years in the legislature, a nineteen-year deed fight that landed in the law-school casebooks, a federal appeal argued at eighty, a criminal trial defended in his mid-eighties — and in all that time no client, no judge, no opposing counsel ever put a mark on his record. He was registered and authorized to practice in the year he died at ninety-seven. The license outlasted the man by thirty-four days.

The obituary compresses the start of it into two sentences: "Cunningham returned to U of I after WWII, earned a JD from the School of Law and was admitted to the Illinois Bar in 1948. He returned to Lawrence County and practiced law for over 72 years" (Obituary). The University of Illinois College of Law, class of 1948, on the GI Bill — the taxpayers finishing the education the war had interrupted, as he liked to acknowledge. And then the decision that shaped everything after: he went home. Not to Chicago, not to Springfield, not even to Evansville across the Wabash. To Lawrence County, population then around twenty thousand, county seat Lawrenceville, hometown Sumner nine miles up the road — the tough east end of which had already taught him audacity. Every door that opened for him for the next seven decades opened off a Lawrence County street.

This chapter covers the twenty-two years between the bar and the Statehouse: the years in which he became a prosecutor, a husband, a father of five, and the founder of a seniors' club he would count among the great joys of his life. It must be said at the outset that these are the thinnest-documented decades of his adult life. His own columns date from 2013 to 2020; they reach back to this era only in flashes of recollection. The local papers that covered him week by week — the Lawrenceville Daily Record logged 123 pages mentioning him in the 1950s and 215 in the 1960s — sit digitized but unharvested in the Lawrence Public Library's archive [web-findings: Lawrence PL archive]. What follows is built from the case reporters, the Illinois Blue Books, the obituary, one

tribute, and his own late retrospections, and where those run out, this book stops rather than embroiders.



The best picture of the young lawyer comes from a boy who pumped gas underneath him.

In December 2020, among the twenty-six tributes The Sumner Press printed after his death, Allen Johnson set the scene:

In 1952, I was a high school student working at Paul Leach's Texaco gas station at State and 10th Street in Lawrenceville. Roscoe's law office was on the second floor over Leach's station office. Roscoe used to come down and shoot the breeze with us grease monkeys when he wasn't busy. He would regale us with stories of his heroic exploits in Germany during World War II, like sneaking into the Nuremberg War Trials.

(Allen Johnson, tribute, December 3, 2020)

There is the whole practice, four years in: a second-floor office over a Texaco station at State and 10th, close enough to the pumps that when business was slow — and in a town of five thousand, business was sometimes slow — the attorney came downstairs to talk to the high-school help. The prologue of this book leaned on that tribute for its corroboration of Nuremberg. Here it earns its keep a second way, as the only surviving description of where Roscoe Cunningham's law practice physically was in 1952.

Johnson kept one more story, and it deserves printing in full, because almost nothing else survives of what this man was like at twenty-nine:

One day, my dad, Red Johnson, and I were in Porter's barber shop across State Street from Leach's station. Dad was in the barber's chair and Roscoe was there reading the paper. When the barber, Don Porter, had to run next door for something, Roscoe picked up the clipper and acted like he was cutting Red's hair. When Don came back in and saw Roscoe clipping Dad's hair, I thought he was going to have a heart attack.

(Allen Johnson, tribute, December 3, 2020)

A young lawyer, waiting his turn in the barber's chair, sees the barber step out and picks up the clippers over a customer's head purely for the look on Don Porter's face when he walks back in. Sixty-eight years later the boy who watched it happen sent the story to the man's own newspaper as a eulogy. It is the Nuremberg audacity again, in miniature and in peacetime — the man could not see an unattended post without manning it.

Of his actual caseload in those first years the record on disk holds almost nothing. The paper files of a country practice — the wills, the deeds, the fender-lawsuits — sit, if they sit anywhere, with the Lawrence County Circuit Clerk and the regional archives depository, unexamined by this project so far. What survives in print is the moment his name first entered the permanent law reports: *Hershey v. Hershey*, decided by the Illinois Appellate Court in 1954, six years into practice, "Roscoe D. Cunningham, of Lawrenceville, for appellee" [Hershey, 122 N.E.2d 69]. He won — the appellee is the party defending the judgment below — and the reporter misspelled his town. Readers of the prologue will recognize the pattern; the printed record of this man's life is strewn with small typographical injuries, from "Burt Lence" to "Lawrenceville" to, in a 1969 volume of the Illinois Reports, "Roscos D. Cunningham" [Pulliam, 253 N.E.2d 448]. He spent his last thirty-three years setting type himself, imperfectly. There is a rough justice in it.



By the time Allen Johnson was pumping gas below his office, Roscoe was running for his first public office. In November 1952 — the Eisenhower landslide year — Lawrence County elected him State's Attorney, and the Illinois Blue Book began carrying his name in its county-officers roster: "Roscoe D. Cunningham, State's Attorney...Rep." The rosters track him through six volumes — 1953–54, 1957–58, 1959–60, 1961–62, 1963–64, and, after a gap, 1969–70 [BB 1953-54 p.707; BB 1969-70 p.804] — and his own official biography, printed when he reached the legislature, sums the arithmetic: State's Attorney of Lawrence County, four terms, 1952–1964 and 1968–1971 [BB 1971-72 p.282].

A State's Attorney in a county like Lawrence was not a district attorney with a staff and a press office. He was one lawyer — the People's lawyer — responsible for every criminal prosecution in the county, from Saturday-night battery to murder, and for the county's civil legal business besides, all while keeping a private practice alive, because the county paid part-time money for what was in principle a full-time obligation. The office made a young attorney into a courtroom generalist fast, and it made him known in every township by the next election.

What did he actually do with it? The reported cases give three fixed points, and his own columns give two windows.

The first fixed point is the case he was proudest of, because he told the story himself at ninety-four, in a column arguing — of course — for the county's economic revival. George Field was a wartime Army airfield south of Lawrenceville whose three thousand acres of farmland had slipped off the tax rolls:

In 1953, as States Attorney of Lawrence County, we commenced proceedings to force taxation of George Field Farmlands. We agreed with Lawrence County Treasurer Kenneth Maxwell that 3,000 acres of the most fertile land on earth should be taxed. The Trial Court for it held for the Airport/Lawrenceville that lands were exempt because used for a civic purpose. We filed an appeal to the Illinois Supreme Court seeking reversal of that ruling.

(Journal, February 8, 2018)

In 1955 the Appellate Court reversed the trial court and ordered the property assessed, excepting only about 100 acres for runways and taxes.

(Journal, February 8, 2018)

The case exists, and it is the one he means: City of Lawrenceville v. Maxwell, decided by the Illinois Supreme Court in 1955, with "Roscoe D. Cunningham, State's Attorney, of Lawrenceville, for appellees" in the counsel line [Maxwell, 126 N.E.2d 671]. But the reader deserves the same skeptic's note this book gave Nuremberg: the column and the reporter do not agree on the procedural details. He remembers appealing a loss; the caption has him defending as appellee, with the City of Lawrenceville as the named appellant, and the deciding court was the Supreme Court of Illinois, not "the Appellate Court." Sixty-three years is a long time to carry a docket sheet in your head, and this book has not yet pulled the opinion's full text to sort out who appealed what. What is not in doubt is the outcome he claimed and the fact that he, as State's Attorney, stood on the taxing side and won. His own coda, written when the case was old enough to draw a pension:

This decision has never been reversed and taxes have been paid in the intervening 63 years. Problem is that the large income from the farming operations is spent on George Field and does not benefit the rest of the county.

(Journal, February 8, 2018)

A ninety-four-year-old man still litigating, in print, the disposition of the proceeds of a case he won in 1955. The war with George Field's account books ran, one way and another, for the rest of his life.

The second window his columns open on the office is quieter and stranger. In 2014, writing about mental health, he reached back sixty years:

Sixty years ago, Ruth Garrett, Lawrence County Public Aid Supervisor, (now euphemistically called "Human Resources") to conceal any stigma from being society's burden chaired periodic luncheon meetings of county officials. Purpose was to identify county problems and seek solutions.

(Journal, August 28, 2014)

As State's Attorney, I participated in such meetings and was startled how unanimous the group's finding that mental health was the greatest health problem confronting Lawrence County.

(Journal, August 28, 2014)

Note the pronoun — the editorial "we" drops to "I," as it tended to when the memory was personal. And note what startled him. Not crime, not the oil economy: the county's officials, at lunch in the mid-1950s, agreed that their biggest problem was mental illness. He carried the finding for sixty years and reported that his opinion had not changed: "it remains my belief that mental health irregularities restrict more Lawrence County citizens than the next two maladies combined" (Journal, August 28, 2014). A prosecutor sees the county's pain at closer range than almost anyone; this is one of the few places he ever said what he saw.

The other two fixed points are captions in the Illinois Supreme Court's reports, and they bracket the office like bookends. *People v. Milligan*, 1963: Roscoe D. Cunningham for the People, alongside Attorney General William G. Clark — the third term [Milligan, 190 N.E.2d 753]. And *People v. Lawrence*, 1971: for the People again, now alongside Attorney General William J. Scott — the fourth and final term [Lawrence, 268 N.E.2d 15]. That last caption is almost too neat: The People against Lawrence, argued by the State's Attorney of Lawrence County, of Lawrenceville. Somewhere in the case name, the county name, and the counsel line, the typesetter must have felt he was setting the same word in a hall of mirrors.

Between the 1963 caption and the 1971 caption falls a silence the record on disk does not explain: his Blue Book biography shows the four terms split 1952–1964 and 1968–1971, which means that for one four-year term in the middle — 1964 to 1968 — he was out of the office. Whether he lost in the Johnson landslide year of 1964, or stood aside, or ran for something else, none of the sources gathered so far says. The ISBA memorial credits him with "more than 20 election campaigns" across his life [ISBA memorial], which arithmetic suggests included defeats nobody memorialized. The Lawrenceville Daily Record's 1960s pages, when they are finally harvested, will say. Until then: a gap, flagged.



On May 1, 1954 — the same year his name first appeared in the law reports, the second year of his first term as State's Attorney — the thirty-year-old prosecutor got married.

He married his beloved Katheryn Suzanne (Ramsey) Cunningham on May 01, 1954 at the First Christian Church in Lawrenceville. Together they shared 64 years of joyful marriage and raised five children.

(Obituary)

Katheryn Suzanne Ramsey — Kay, always Kay — was born June 25, 1934, in Petersburg, Indiana, across the Wabash [web-findings: Katheryn Cunningham obituary]. She was nineteen on her wedding day; he was thirty. They married in the church he would belong to for sixty-six years, the church whose pews he was still apologizing for reaching late in the last column he ever wrote. Her own obituary remembers her as the founder of the Lawrenceville Swim Team and a Village Gardener; the Daily Record's social columns of the 1960s track her as "Mrs. Roscoe Cunningham" through garden-club seasons [web-findings: Lawrence PL archive].

Of the courtship, the wedding, the early married years, his 340 surviving columns preserve almost nothing — he was not a man who wrote about his wife while she could read it, and by the time he was writing these columns she had less than five years left. But one glimpse of the young couple survives, dropped into a 2020 remembrance of a Bridgeport neighbor:

Kay and I were at the Saturday night dance, Bridgeport at the American Legion sixty years ago. The specialty was a snake dance. Dick and the beautiful Pat were on the end. His animated motion was the envy of every male in the room.

(Journal, June 18, 2020)

That is the marriage's whole documentary record from inside this era: one Saturday night around 1960, the State's Attorney and his wife at an American Legion dance, watching a friend cut loose at the end of a snake dance. It will have to stand for a thousand nights like it.

The children came across the next decade and a half: R.D., Jan, Jonathan Edward, Michael A., and Lorie (Obituary). And in 1968, the family built the house the rest of the story happens in — he fixed the date himself in a column: "when we built our home, 1968" (Journal, June 11, 2015; the sentence around the phrase is mangled in the scan, but the date stands plain). The house was 904 State Street, Lawrenceville, under an enormous elm he spent the rest of his life defending in print — "The Mighty Elm which has ruled majestically over 904 State for at least 150 years" (Journal, April 23, 2020). Around 1970, wanting the tree certified as a rare American elm rather than a common one, he did a characteristic thing: "Fifty years ago we summoned a dear friend, the late Phil Stansfield, a Lawrenceville native, U of I Graduate, Farm Adviser in Indiana, and requested he certify that our noble tree was American" (Journal, April 23, 2020). Stansfield declined to perjure himself, botanically speaking, and their friendship survived it. The elm, the house, Kay, and the practice: the fixed coordinates of the next fifty years, all in place by the end of 1968.



In between the prosecuting and the family-building, on January 1, 1958, he founded the thing that — by his own accounting, made near the end — mattered more to him than any office he ever held.

Cunningham's Golden Age Club #1 was a club for the county's old people, four decades before anyone said "senior citizens" without euphemism. The obituary gives the shape of it:

From 1958 through 1998 Members of GAC #1 participated in bus trips, parades and enjoyed regular social gatherings held weekly at the Lawrenceville Courthouse. In its heyday GAC #1 had more than 100 members.

(Obituary)

A thirty-four-year-old State's Attorney, with a law practice, a young wife, and a growing family, started a weekly social club for the elderly at the courthouse and ran it for forty years. When he ranked his life's joys at ninety-five, he put it second only to his family — and he put it above every office in this book:

Except for dear Kay and our family, our greatest joy has been Lawrence County Golden Age Club #1. From January 1, 1958 to January 1, 1998 numerous compassionate older Lawrence Countians enriched our life, and we theirs. Except for the government involvement in the problems of senior citizens, with the meals attached thereto, we would still be sponsoring and working with Lawrence County's finest. Every meeting, and especially every summer trip was a memorable delight.

(Journal, February 14, 2019)

Note the dates — forty years to the day, January 1 to January 1, the term limits self-imposed and exactly kept. Note the grievance — even in the club's eulogy he found room to blame government meal programs for crowding out the volunteers. And note "enriched our life, and we theirs," which the obituary writer lifted verbatim, correctly judging it unimprovable. The summer trips surfaced in his columns now and then across the years; a 2016 item recalls "stopping at Churchill Downs 20 years ago while on the summer trip with Lawrence County Golden Age Club #1" (Journal, May 12, 2016) — a busload of Lawrence County retirees inspecting the statue of Man o' War because Roscoe Cunningham thought they ought to see Kentucky.

The impulse behind the club shows up in one more memory from these years, this one with teeth. Writing in 2017 about poverty and pride, he reached back to roughly 1952:

Sixty-five years ago, as a member of the Lawrence County Shrine Club, the writer delivered oranges to poor families at Xmas time.

(Journal, May 4, 2017)

Will never forget one home in which man of the house was able bodied, shiftless, prideless. He continued watching television as he commanded, "put that bag over in the corner." We didn't have a television set in our home.

(Journal, May 4, 2017)

Sixty-five years of remembering the man who didn't get up. The last sentence is the sting, and it is aimed at himself as much as the reader: the young lawyer delivering charity oranges owned less entertainment than the family receiving them. His politics — the bootstrap convictions, the suspicion of dependency, the reflex generosity that coexisted with both — are all present in that one bag of oranges, set over in the corner.



The second State's Attorney term ended the era, but the 1960s private practice deserves its record first, because the case reporters preserve it with unusual clarity. In the late sixties his name begins appearing in appellate captions in a cluster: *Adams v. Ford Motor Co.* in 1968, for the appellee, "alongside Gosnell, Benecki & Quindry of Lawrenceville" [Adams, 243 N.E.2d 843]; *Cunningham v. Central & Southern Truck Lines* the same year — the plaintiffs were named Cunningham, and whether they were kin the record does not say [C&S Truck Lines, 244 N.E.2d 412]; *Hinkle v. Creek* in 1969 [Hinkle, 251 N.E.2d 111]; *Pulliam v. Industrial Commission*, a workers' compensation appeal argued in the Illinois Supreme Court in 1969, where the reporter rechristened him "Roscos" [Pulliam, 253 N.E.2d 448]; and *Zimmerly Construction Co. v. Industrial Commission* in 1972, where he is listed as "Roscoe D. Cunningham of Gosnell, Benecki & Quindry, Ltd." — plain evidence that he practiced with the Lawrenceville firm in these years, before the eponymous firms of his later career [Zimmerly, 278 N.E.2d 789]. Car cases, comp cases, a truck-line suit: the docket of a country lawyer, argued to the top of the state when the client's case required it.

The office itself acquired, at some point, the name he used for it ever after in print: the Law Factory. The columns of his publisher years are full of it — parties at the Law Factory, papers picked up at the Law Factory after 1 p.m. Wednesdays — and one 2014 item reaches back to date its longest-serving employee: "During 45 years never were there two consecutive work days that farlene failed to come to the Law Factory on account of the weather" (Journal, January 9, 2014). The scan has garbled her name — Marlene or Darlene, most likely — but the arithmetic says she joined him around 1969, at the close of this chapter's window, and was still coming to work through every weather forty-five years later. Her full name is on a payroll record somewhere in Lawrenceville, and a future edition of this book owes it to her to find it.

In November 1968 the county returned him to the State's Attorney's office for the fourth time, and in November 1970 — mid-term — Lawrence County's voters promoted him again, electing him to the Illinois House of Representatives from the three-member 54th District [BB 1971-72 p.282]. The Blue Book gives his final State's Attorney years as 1968–1971, which implies he wound down the county office as he took up the state one; the exact mechanics — resignation, appointment of a successor — are another item for the Daily Record's unharvested pages. The 1971 caption in

People v. Lawrence stands as his last appearance in the Supreme Court reports as the People's lawyer [Lawrence, 268 N.E.2d 15].

Looking back at the whole span from the far end of his life, he rendered his own verdict on the trade he had learned in these years, and it is characteristically double-edged:

For more than forty years we have successfully practiced law in the country. It was more financial rewarding but far less exciting than public service.

(Journal, February 14, 2019)

And on the campaigning that carried him from the Texaco office to the courthouse to Springfield — five county-wide races in this chapter alone — he left the working politician's summary of door-to-door democracy:

We enjoyed going door to door to ask the voter for his support. Enjoyable except for the dog bites, even when the one solicited said, "we'll think about it". That phrase meant that they would usually vote against us.

(Journal, February 14, 2019)

Dog bites, and the polite lie of "we'll think about it," decoded by a man who had knocked on enough Lawrence County doors to know. Bill Richardson, the local sportswriter who knew him for thirty years, put the era's result simply in his tribute: "Roscoe's status at the local level came from his work as our State's Attorney, an attorney in the private sector and as a businessman and community leader. He was naturally outspoken, often controversial and frequently in the news" (Bill Richardson, tribute, December 3, 2020).

By January 1971 the counselor had a wife, five children, a brick house under a giant elm, a law practice, a seniors' club entering its fourteenth year, four terms of prosecuting behind him, and a seat in the Illinois House of Representatives ahead of him. He was forty-seven. The quietest chapters of his life were over, and he had never really been quiet.

Sources

IARDC official attorney record, Roscoe David Cunningham — admitted May 17, 1948; last registered year 2020; no public record of discipline [IARDC] ([book/sources/web-findings.json](#), [iardc.org](#) printable record).

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 — obituary (bar 1948, 72+ years of practice, four State's Attorney terms, marriage to Katheryn Suzanne Ramsey May 1, 1954 at First Christian Church, five children, Golden Age Club #1 1958–1998, courthouse gatherings, 100+ members); Allen Johnson tribute (Leach's Texaco office 1952; Porter's barber shop prank on Red Johnson); Bill Richardson tribute.

ISBA Bar News memorial, December 2020 — Golden Age Club 1958–1998; First Christian member 66 years; "more than 20 election campaigns" (book/sources/web-findings.json).

Illinois Blue Book 1971–72, pp. 282–283 — member biography: State's Attorney of Lawrence County, four terms, 1952–1964 and 1968–1971 [BB 1971-72 p.282]; county-officer rosters in BB 1953-54 p.707, 1957-58 p.780, 1959-60 p.784, 1961-62 p.821, 1963-64 p.817, 1969-70 p.804 (Illinois Digital Archives, via book/sources/web-findings.json).

Reported cases (CourtListener, via book/sources/web-findings.json): *Hershey v. Hershey*, 3 Ill. App. 2d 307, 122 N.E.2d 69 (1954) ("Lawreeneville" misprint); *City of Lawrenceville v. Maxwell*, 6 Ill. 2d 42, 126 N.E.2d 671 (1955); *People v. Milligan*, 28 Ill. 2d 203, 190 N.E.2d 753 (1963); *People v. Lawrence*, 48 Ill. 2d 368, 268 N.E.2d 15 (1971); *Adams v. Ford Motor Co.*, 103 Ill. App. 2d 356, 243 N.E.2d 843 (1968); *Cunningham v. Central & Southern Truck Lines*, 104 Ill. App. 2d 247, 244 N.E.2d 412 (1968); *Hinkle v. Creek*, 113 Ill. App. 2d 454, 251 N.E.2d 111 (1969); *Pulliam v. Industrial Commission*, 43 Ill. 2d 364, 253 N.E.2d 448 (1969) ("Roscos" misprint); *Zimmerly Construction Co. v. Industrial Commission*, 50 Ill. 2d 342, 278 N.E.2d 789 (1972) (Gosnell, Benecki & Quindry, Ltd. affiliation).

Roscoe's Journal columns, quoted verbatim from *roscoe-journal-complete.md*: February 8, 2018 (George Field taxation); August 28, 2014 (Ruth Garrett luncheons; mental health); February 14, 2019 (Golden Age Club; public office; door-to-door; forty years of country practice); June 18, 2020 (Kay at the Bridgeport American Legion dance; Richard Poppe); May 4, 2017 (Shrine Club oranges); May 12, 2016 (Churchill Downs GAC trip); April 23, 2020 (the Mighty Elm; 904 State; Phil Stansfield); June 11, 2015 ("when we built our home, 1968"); January 9, 2014 (the Law Factory; the 45-year employee).

Katheryn Suzanne (Ramsey) Cunningham obituary — b. June 25, 1934, Petersburg, Indiana; Lawrenceville Swim Team founder; Village Gardeners (Cunningham Funeral Homes, via book/sources/web-findings.json).

Lawrence Public Library District Community History Archive — decade histogram of "Roscoe Cunningham" newspaper hits (1950s: 123 pages; 1960s: 215 pages), unharvested as of this draft (book/sources/web-findings.json).

Known gaps stated in text: the 1964–1968 out-of-office interval unexplained; Maxwell procedural posture unresolved pending the full opinion; circuit-court case files unexamined; the Law Factory secretary's name garbled in the scan; Daily Record 1950s–60s coverage not yet pulled (see GAPS.md).

Chapter 4 — Springfield (1971-1979)

In January 1971, a forty-seven-year-old State's Attorney from Lawrenceville drove the hundred and fifty miles northwest to Springfield and was sworn in as a member of the Illinois House of Representatives for the 54th District. He had won the seat the previous November while still holding the county prosecutor's office — his Blue Book biography for that first term lists his State's Attorney service as "1952-1964 and 1968-1971," the second span ending only when the new job began [BB 1971-72 pp.282-283]. He would serve exactly four terms, in the 77th, 78th, 79th, and 80th General Assemblies, and never lose the seat. When he left it, in January 1979, it was because he had bet it on something bigger — but that is the next chapter's story.

The family obituary, written half a century later, preserved the two sentences that best explain what Springfield meant to the record of his life. "He spoke eloquently from the House Floor and when he spoke everyone listened," it says, and then: "It was reported, 'The only time the AP Wire Press Box picked up their pencils for quotes from the Illinois Legislature was when Representative Cunningham got up to speak.'" (Obituary). Whether the wire reporters would have put it exactly that way, we cannot yet check — but a man who watched him from the floor said something close. Phil Gonet, who came to the Capitol as a young Republican staffer, wrote in the tribute edition: "I first observed Roscoe in the 1975 fall session of the General Assembly. I believe he was the best orator of his time, and his mastery of the written and spoken word was nonpareil (a term he would use!)." (Phil Gonet). The parenthesis is the telling part. Even his eulogists wrote in his vocabulary.



To understand the seat he held, you have to understand a piece of political machinery that no longer exists anywhere in America. From 1870 until 1980, Illinois elected its House by cumulative voting: each district sent not one representative but three, and each voter had three votes to distribute as he pleased — one per candidate, split three ways, or all three "plumped" on a single name [Ill. Const. of 1870, art. IV; abolished by the 1980 "Cutback Amendment"]. The system was designed, in the bitterness after the Civil War, to guarantee that the minority party in any corner of the state could still send someone to Springfield. Downstate Democrats got seats in Republican counties; Chicago Republicans survived in the Democratic city. The practical result was a 177-member House in which nearly every district's delegation was split two and one, and a legislator's first opponents were often his own running mates.

The 54th District, sprawling across the farm counties of southeastern Illinois, was exactly such a place. In Roscoe's first term the district's three members were one Republican — him — and two Democrats, Don E. Brummet of Vandalia and Charles F. Keller of Effingham; the 1971-72 Blue Book prints a group photograph of the three of them together [BB 1971-72 p.282]. By his last term the Democratic seatmate on record was Robert V. Walsh of Grayville [BB 1977-78 p.60]. Cumulative voting meant Roscoe never had to carry a majority of the 54th; he had to be the Republican enough Republicans would plump for. Twenty years of prosecuting the county's criminals, and a name his father had carried through Lukin Township before him, turned out to be exactly that.

The name, in fact, needs a moment of care, because the 77th General Assembly contained three Republican Cunninghams at once: Lester Cunningham of the 33rd District, William J. "Bill" Cunningham of the 57th, and Roscoe D. Cunningham of the 54th [BB 1973-74 p.189]. In the 1971-72 committee rosters he appears as "R. D. Cunningham" to keep the three apart [BB 1971-72 pp.132, 134]. From the 78th General Assembly on, the other two were gone and a bare "Cunningham" in the House record means him. Anyone who someday reads the floor transcripts — and we will come to those — should keep the distinction in mind for the first term.

The Blue Books, Illinois' official biennial almanac of its government, give us his official face for each of the four terms: a photograph and a short biography in 1971-72, 1973-74, 1975-76, and 1977-78 [BB 1971-72 pp.282-283; BB 1973-74 p.162; BB 1975-76 p.179; BB 1977-78 p.175]. The first bio compresses the life we have followed to this point into a prosecutor's résumé: born Lukin Township, reared in Sumner; the University of Nancy, France; University of Illinois law, 1948; four terms State's Attorney of Lawrence County; World War II Field Artillery forward observer, European Theater [BB 1971-72 pp.282-283]. The last one carries a small bibliographic curiosity: it notes "Minority Spokesman, Appropriations I Committee. Delegate to Republican National Convention, 1980" — evidence the 1977-78 volume went to press late, after the Detroit convention delegates had been chosen, and a reminder that even official records are assembled by people running behind schedule [BB 1977-78 p.175].



The committee rosters trace a steady climb. In the 77th General Assembly the freshman sat on Executive, on Judiciary (Division II), and on the Insurance division of Financial Institutions [BB 1971-72 pp.132, 134]. In the 78th he was vice chairman of Insurance [BB 1973-74 pp.54-55]. In the 79th he became co-minority spokesman of Appropriations Division I while keeping Executive and Judiciary II [BB 1975-76 pp.69-70]; in the 80th he was the minority spokesman — the ranking Republican — on Appropriations I, still holding Judiciary II [BB 1977-78 pp.66-67]. He also sat on the bipartisan Illinois Economic and Fiscal Commission, the legislature's revenue-forecasting

arm, where the roster puts the weekly newspaper publisher's future favorite subject — the state's money — in front of him alongside two Chicago Democrats then on their way up: Senator Richard M. Daley and Senator Dawn Clark Netsch [BB 1977-78 p.190].

Appropriations is where the memory of the man and the print of the record touch, and do not quite align, in a way worth pausing over. Forty years later, welcoming an old Springfield friend back into his good graces after a missed visit, he writes: "Phil was the brains for the Appropriations Committee 40 years ago, when Illinois had an annual budget as the law requires. As Chairman of the Committee we appreciated his skill." (Journal, September 21, 2017). Phil Gonet himself, in the tribute edition, is more precise: "I met Roscoe when I was hired by George Ryan as the Director of the House Republican Appropriations Committee Staff in May 1978. Roscoe was the Chief Republican Spokesman for one of the two Appropriations Committees." (Phil Gonet). The Blue Book agrees with Gonet: minority spokesman, not chairman — the Democrats held the House [BB 1977-78 pp.66-67]. It is a small inflation, the kind every veteran allows himself at ninety-three, and we note it not to catch him out but because this book's method is to print the record and the memory side by side and let the reader see both.

What the record cannot yet give us is the thing everyone agreed was the point of him: the voice. Illinois began verbatim transcription of House floor debates on October 5, 1971 — nine months into his first term — so nearly his entire legislative career survives word for word in the scanned transcript volumes of the 77th through 80th General Assemblies [ILGA htrans77-htrans80]. Those PDFs exist, are indexed, and have not yet been pulled into this archive. Nothing from them is quoted in this chapter, and any sentence of his floor oratory you may have heard secondhand should be treated as unverified until they are. The obituary preserves one image of what the transcripts will presumably show, in his own late-life telling: "memories of speaking on the House Floor, Cunningham recalled competition for the singular microphone was similar to battling one hundred eighty-four male peacocks for attention." (Obituary). The House had 177 members, not 184 — but counting peacocks precisely was never the joke's job.



What did the 54th District get for its three votes? His own columns, written decades later, keep returning to two answers: errands and the highway.

The errands were the ordinary brokerage of a downstate member — the pushing of state facilities and services toward home. One column preserves a moment of it whole. Remembering his fellow House member Jesse White, by then Illinois' long-serving Secretary of State, he writes: "The Publisher had the pleasure of serving in the Illinois House of Representatives with now Secretary of State Jesse White. Mr. Secretary knows the relief we felt when then Secretary of State Michael

J. Howlett injected in speech to the full House, 'Representative Cunningham, be assured that one of the first Drivers' License Stations will be in Lawrenceville.' (1975?) (?)" (Journal, February 23, 2017). The two question marks are his own, printed in the paper — a ninety-three-year-old writer flagging his own uncertain date. We leave them in because they are the most honest citation format in this entire book.

The highway was Four Lanes for Fifty — the widening of U.S. Route 50 across southeastern Illinois — and it is the longest thread in his public life, running from Springfield through every year of the newspaper to the last columns he ever wrote. Its origin, in his telling, sits squarely at the start of his legislative career: a column about a bridge project notes that "Four Lanes for Route 50, first promised by Governor Ogilvie in 1970, will yet happen." (Journal, September 22, 2016) — 1970 being the year Roscoe was first elected to the House. Fifty years later, three weeks into his last autumn, he was still at it: "We've been pushing for four lanes for more than 50 years." (Journal, October 1, 2020). The legislator's project outlived the legislature, outlived the governors who promised it, and, as of this writing, remains unbuilt. Chapter 8 will take up the crusade as the newspaper waged it; here it is enough to mark where it began.

And there was the campaigning itself, which he plainly loved. In 2018, watching a new Republican candidate hand out rulers, he lets slip a confession dated by arithmetic to his 1974 re-election: "44 years ago a State Representative Candidate passed out thousands of yardsticks. The public welcomed such handy tool, especially parents who had children whose bottoms should be warmed." (Journal, October 4, 2018). At least one of those yardsticks survives — a wooden "Re-Elect Roscoe Cunningham State Representative 54th District" stick was listed for sale on eBay in 2026 [eBay item 256467097768]. The district was big, and working it meant being seen in towns far from Lawrenceville. A 2016 column — occasioned by the indignity of gatekeepers at a Flora sectional basketball game who had never heard of him — dissolves into a roll call of the people who once carried him there: "Nostalgically, we remembered a dozen double-bicycle rides in the Flora night and London-air afternoon Halloween parades throughout the 70's. The crowds were large and friendly, their friendship carried over to the polling places." He names them — a newspaper family, a mayor, a Republican women's leader, precinct committeemen — and then closes the ledger: "These are but a few of the friends upon whose backs we've ridden as does every winning candidate, and to whom we're forever indebted." And, taking attendance forty years on: "Alas, except for dear Ronnie, they are all deceased. Time marches on." (Journal, March 10, 2016).



Two episodes from his final term deserve to stand out from the roster-and-errand texture of the rest, because both show the prosecutor still alive inside the legislator.

The first is the death penalty. The United States Supreme Court had struck down the nation's capital punishment statutes in 1972 and then, in 1976, upheld the new generation of them [Gregg v. Georgia, 428 U.S. 153 (1976)], and in 1977 Illinois moved to restore its own. Roscoe sat on House Judiciary II, the committee that hammered the bill [BB 1977-78 pp.66-67], and Illinois Issues, the state-politics monthly, caught his voice in the hearings that March: "The clamor is there, for us to pass capital punishment." [Illinois Issues, March 1977]. Thirty-nine years later he told the story himself, in a column arguing the cycle had come around again: "After the U.S. Supreme Court held death penalty constitutional, circa 1974, we introduced the first bill in the Illinois House of Representatives authorizing such punishment. It was combined with subsequent bills and easily passed the House and Senate. Gov. Thompson signed." (Journal, May 26, 2016). His dates wander — the Court's decision was 1976, and the later history he goes on to recount compresses George Ryan's commutations (2003) and Illinois' final abolition (2011) into a vaguer chronology — but the spine of the claim, that he was an early sponsor of restoration and that the merged bill became law under Governor Thompson, is his own testimony and is consistent with the committee seat and the committee-room quote. Whether his bill was literally "the first" is checkable in the 80th General Assembly's records and has not yet been checked; we flag it and move on. The same column carries the theological needle he could never resist: "Curiously, churches are always the strongest opponents of capital punishment. It were as though they did not believe there is a world after this one." (Journal, May 26, 2016). Chapter 9 will have more to say about a churchgoing man who reasoned like that.

The second episode is the impeachment resolution. In 1977, Cook County Circuit Judge Frank J. Wilson acquitted a mob hitman named Harry Aleman of the murder of William Logan, in a bench trial whose verdict stunned the courthouse. Roscoe Cunningham and a downstate colleague, Representative Cal Skinner, responded by introducing a House resolution to impeach the judge. The resolution went nowhere. History went somewhere: the acquittal was later proven to have been bought, Wilson died by suicide in 1990 as the Operation Greylord investigations closed in, and in 1997 Aleman was retried and convicted for the same murder — the rare American exception to double jeopardy, allowed because a bribed acquittal is no acquittal at all [Skinner, McHenry County Blog, May 24, 2026; the resolution's text awaits retrieval from the 80th GA House Journal, Illinois State Archives]. Two downstate legislators had smelled the fix twenty years before the federal government proved it. Skinner, remarkably, was still telling the story in 2026 — a living colleague, past ninety himself, blogging his recollections of a fight he and Roscoe lost on paper and won in the long run. His memoir of it, and the contemporary Chicago Tribune clippings he reproduces, are the fullest account now available; the family's copy of the record should someday include the resolution itself.



The Springfield years gave him a repertory company of characters he would keep writing about for the rest of his life, and the columns let us watch him do it. The most striking case is George Ryan — the future governor whose name became a byword for Illinois corruption after his 2006 federal conviction. Roscoe, reviewing a county board's refusal to put Ryan's name on a plaque of native-son governors, would have none of it: "We served eight years with George Ryan in the Illinois House. We found him honorable, upright, trustworthy." (Journal, September 6, 2018). The Blue Books allow them six overlapping years, not eight — Ryan arrived in 1973, Roscoe left in January 1979 — but the loyalty is the point, not the arithmetic. The same reflex protected Michael Madigan, the Chicago Democrat who entered the House in the same January 1971 freshman class and went on to run it for most of four decades. In 2020, with the Speaker engulfed by a federal bribery investigation and both parties calling for his head, the ninety-six-year-old Republican publisher wrote of "the case against our friend," and concluded: "If a Democrat must be the Speaker of the House of Representatives, Southern Illinois will be better served by Michael Madigan than by some pious caretaker from that party's controlled delegation." (Journal, August 13, 2020). Half a century out of the chamber, he still scored politicians the way a member does: by whether they delivered, and whether they were friends.

The chamber stayed with him in smaller ways too. A 2016 column about idle prison labor reaches back for a lobbyist's face: "Years ago, while in the Legislature, we asked the union's hard nosed lobbyist, whether the union would oppose a bill to permit inmates to resume the manufacture of license plates, which was their forte 60 years ago. He was indignant that 'slave labor' would be suggested." (Journal, January 28, 2016). And in one of the last columns of his life, arguing that Republicans should stop mishandling the abortion question, he reached back forty-nine years for a colleague's floor argument, question mark and all: "'When we criminalize all abortions, life for rich women is little changed, but the frightened poor women are driven into the alley butchers.' -- Representative Murphy (?), Illinois House of Representatives, 1971." (Journal, September 24, 2020). He was ninety-seven and could no longer be sure of the man's name. He could still quote the sentence. That is what a legislature sounds like in a good memory: not the roll calls, but the one line from 1971 that never stopped being right enough to argue with.

His summary judgment on the whole trade came late, and reads like a man defending his own life's choices: "We regard the willingness of any citizen to actively participate in politics, as a candidate or a party worker in the trenches, as a badge of courage. While the uninformed regards the fascination with politics as pathological, it is essential for the efficient operation of government." (Journal, August 30, 2018).



The end of the Springfield years came quickly, and by his own hand. In the fall of 1977, with Congressman George Shipley retiring from the 22nd Congressional District, Illinois Issues reported that "Rep. Roscoe D. Cunningham (R., Lawrenceville)" was weighing the race and "said he would announce his decision October 14" [Illinois Issues, Nov. 1977]. He announced. He ran. Phil Gonet, arriving on the Appropriations staff in May 1978, caught only the aftermath: "This formal association was short-lived as Roscoe had run, and lost, in the Republican Primary Election for Congress in March 1978. He left his legislative office in January 1979, but our friendship continued strong over the years." (Phil Gonet).

Eight years in the House, and no scandal, no indictment, no primary defeat for the seat itself — only a safe place in a three-member district, surrendered voluntarily at fifty-four by a man who wanted more. The Blue Book had already, in its late-printed way, recorded where his party would send him next: Detroit, 1980, as a delegate [BB 1977-78 p.175]. But between the House floor and the convention floor lies the wound this book turns to now. Years later, a woman in Flora would vouch him through a gymnasium gate with the whole arc in one sentence — "Roscoe is a good guy, used to be our State Representative, publishes The Press instead of playing golf." (Journal, March 10, 2016). Between "used to be" and "publishes" sits March 21, 1978.



A note on what this chapter does not contain: his verbatim floor speeches (ILGA transcripts htrans77-htrans80, existing but unpulled — nothing here quotes them); his bill list (Legislative Synopsis and Digest volumes, Illinois State Archives); his election-by-election vote totals in the 54th (the printed state canvasses, 1970-1976); and the text and number of the Wilson impeachment resolution (80th GA House Journal). Each is locatable. Version two of this book should be longer here, and louder — in his voice from the floor, not ours.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal columns (verbatim, from `roscoe-journal-complete.md`): January 28, 2016; March 10, 2016; May 26, 2016; September 22, 2016; February 23, 2017; September 21, 2017; August 30, 2018; September 6, 2018; October 4, 2018; August 13, 2020; September 24, 2020; October 1, 2020.

Tribute edition, The Sumner Press, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`): the obituary (House floor oratory, AP wire quote, "one hundred eighty-four male peacocks," 54th District, four terms, three RNC delegate stints); Phil Gonet's tribute (1975 fall session, "best orator of his time," Appropriations spokesman, May 1978 staff hiring, March 1978 primary loss, January 1979 departure).

Illinois Blue Books (Illinois Digital Archives, collection `bb`, via `book/sources/web-findings.json`): 1971-72 pp.282-283 (bio, photo, three-member group photo), pp.132, 134 (committees, "R. D. Cunningham"); 1973-74 pp.54-55 (Insurance vice chairman), p.162 (bio), p.189 (all-time roster, three Cunninghams); 1975-76 pp.69-70 (Approps I co-spokesman), p.179 (bio); 1977-78 pp.66-67 (Approps I minority spokesman, Judiciary II), p.175 (bio; 1980 RNC delegate line), p.60 (54th

District roster, Walsh), p.190 (Economic and Fiscal Commission, Daley, Netsch); 1981-82 p.214 (cumulative roster: 77th-80th GAs).

Illinois Issues, March 1977 ("Hammering out a new Illinois law: Capital Punishment" — "The clamor is there" quote) and November 1977 (Shipley-seat decision), via web-findings.

Cal Skinner, "Back in 1977 — Remembering a Crooked Judge," McHenry County Blog, May 24, 2026 (Wilson impeachment resolution, Aleman acquittal, Greylord aftermath), via web-findings.

Gregg v. Georgia, 428 U.S. 153 (1976) (date of the Supreme Court's reinstatement of capital punishment, correcting the column's "circa 1974").

Cumulative voting: Illinois Constitution of 1870, art. IV (three-member House districts); ended by the 1980 Cutback Amendment. District seatmates (Brummet, Keller, Walsh) per Blue Books via web-findings.

eBay item 256467097768 (1974 "Re-Elect Roscoe Cunningham" wooden yardstick), via web-findings.

Unpulled, flagged in text: ILGA House floor transcripts htrans77-htrans80 (verbatim debates began October 5, 1971); 80th GA House Journal (Wilson resolution text); Legislative Synopsis and Digest (bill sponsorships); official state canvasses 1970-1976 (vote totals); Washington Post, July 7, 1978 (reserved for Chapter 5).

Chapter 5 — The Loss (1978)

In the fall of 1977, Roscoe Cunningham held what passed in Illinois politics for a job with tenure. The old 54th was a three-member district elected by cumulative voting, a system built to guarantee the minority party a seat, and he had held that seat through four straight elections — 1970, 1972, 1974, 1976 [BB 1981-82 p.214]. He was the Minority Spokesman of Appropriations Committee I, the ranking Republican on one of the two committees that controlled the state's money [BB 1977-78 pp.66-67]. He was fifty-four years old, at the height of his powers as a floor orator, and by his own later account he could have been reelected more or less forever.

That fall, Congressman George Shipley, the Democrat who had represented the sprawling 22nd Congressional District of southeastern Illinois for two decades, announced his retirement. An open congressional seat is the rarest commodity in American politics, and the state's political press began taking a head count. *Illinois Issues*, the Springfield monthly, reported in its November 1977 issue that "Rep. Roscoe D. Cunningham (R., Lawrenceville)" was weighing the race and "said he would announce his decision October 14" (*Illinois Issues*, November 1977).

He ran. On March 21, 1978, he lost the Republican primary to a young dentist from Danville named Dan Crane. He never held, and never again sought, elected office. In a life that ran ninety-seven years and included a world war, seventy-two years at the bar, and a newspaper, this is the hinge — the one event he himself, looking back at ninety-five, filed under a separate heading from everything else.

"As we approach the end of the trail, we pause to remember the triumphs and the disaster enjoyed over an eventful lifetime," he writes in February 2019. Triumphs, plural. Disaster, singular. There was only ever one. "Of disasters - the Republican primary for Congressional Candidate, 1978 terminated our political career" (*Journal*, February 14, 2019).



Here the record must be handled honestly, because it is lopsided. From 1978 itself we have almost nothing in his own hand. The Sumner Press was not yet his paper — he would not buy it for another nine years — and the Lawrence County newspapers of that era survive only on microfilm and in bound volumes that have not yet been scanned. We have no diary, no letters, no contemporaneous column. What we have instead is this: a handful of quoted fragments from a Washington Post reporter who found him four months after the defeat, and two columns he wrote about it himself — one in 2019, forty-one years later, and one in 2020, forty-two years later, three months before he died. The private reaction of the man in the spring of 1978 has to be read

backward through those. It is worth saying plainly that memory at that distance smooths and sharpens things, and that both of his own tellings are shaped by a grudge he carried the whole way. But they agree with each other on every particular that can be checked, and they agree with the contemporary record where it exists.

The fullest telling came in August 2020, prompted by a death. Former Governor James R. Thompson — "Big Jim," the longest-serving governor in Illinois history — died in Chicago that month, and Roscoe's Journal opened not with a eulogy but with a settling of accounts: "We mostly never clicked with Thompson, and vice versa. Our hatred of him commenced in 1978. His leg man came repeatedly to our desk on the House floor to persuade us to enter the Republican primary for the U.S. Congress position. We were reluctant because principle opponent was alleged brightest of a family group widely touted as the Republican version of the Kennedy dynasty" (Journal, August 20, 2020).

The family was the Cranes. Dan Crane was the son of George Crane, a syndicated newspaper columnist, and the brother of Phil Crane, already a congressman from the Chicago suburbs and soon to be a candidate for president. Roscoe sized up the opposition the way a trial lawyer sizes up a jury problem: "That opponent was the son of a syndicated columnist, brother of a congressman, lived in populist north part of the district and was photogenic" (Journal, August 20, 2020). In the 2019 telling he is blunter about the field and about what he was being asked to wager: "We would need to give up assured reelection to the Illinois House. Thompson's support would make the primary struggle with a photogenic dentist and a moneyed playboy a predictable win" (Journal, February 14, 2019). (Who the "moneyed playboy" was — presumably a third candidate in the primary — the columns do not say, and the full 1978 primary field is not yet in this book's sources.)

The calculation, in other words, ran through the governor. A sitting governor's emissary does not repeatedly visit a legislator's desk on the House floor for his own amusement. "Notwithstanding, we knew that an incumbent governor not being challenged for his leadership can easily control nominations in primary contests. Our suitor had to be acting with Thompson's approval. We threw caution to the wind, abandoned our safe spot in the House and announced our candidacy for Congress. We confidently told a Danville rally, 'the Governor is with us'" (Journal, August 20, 2020).

Danville was Crane's home ground — the announcement was a raid into the enemy's county seat, and it was pure Roscoe: the man who had walked past the MPs at Nuremberg on nothing but audacity was now betting a career on a governor's wink. Then came the sentence that, even four decades later, he writes like a door slamming: "Within a couple of hours, the Tuscola radio station

broadcast a statement from the Governor's office, claiming neutrality. Our fate was further sealed in a February blizzard that marooned Kay and us in Paris two nights" (Journal, August 20, 2020).

Two hours. Whatever had actually been promised, or merely allowed to be inferred — and we have only his side of it — the public cover was withdrawn almost before the applause in Danville died. Note who is in the car in that blizzard: Kay. She appears in both tellings, not as the candidate's wife waiting at home but as half of the campaign. "Kay and I tried desperately to pull off a win but the votes were all in the north part of the district. The dentist won" (Journal, February 14, 2019). The 22nd was enormous — his 2019 column counts his lifetime constituencies "from as large as thirteen counties" — and its population weight sat in the north, in Danville and Champaign country, Crane country. A Lawrence County man could carry the Wabash Valley and still be buried by the top of the map. He was.

We do not yet have the vote totals. The State Board of Elections' online records do not reach back to the 1970s; the official canvass sits on paper at the Illinois State Archives in Springfield, one of the errands this book still owes its subject [see GAPS.md]. What we have is the outcome, and one extraordinary piece of luck: a national newspaper decided his defeat was a story.



On July 7, 1978, the Washington Post published a feature on the beaten candidates of the 22nd District under a headline that reads like a chapter title someone else wrote for this book: "Losers in Illinois' 22nd: A Way of Life Ends." The Post found the fifty-four-year-old legislator — a man who had given up a safe seat to make the race — still reeling. "I was shocked beyond description," he told the reporter. And of the man who beat him: "That Dr. Crane — I never saw him coming" (Washington Post, July 7, 1978).

Those two fragments are nearly all of the article this book can presently quote; the full text sits behind the Post's archive paywall and has not yet been pulled [see GAPS.md]. But even the fragments earn their keep. "Shocked beyond description" is not a phrase Roscoe Cunningham used carelessly — this is a man who described everything, three columns a week, for thirty-three years. It is the only moment in the entire assembled record where he pleads that words fail him. And "I never saw him coming" is the admission, from the best-prepared trial lawyer in the Wabash Valley, that he had for once misjudged the case. The Post also reported that he planned to run for the legislature again in 1980. He never did. The 1977–78 Blue Book, printed late, records him as a "Delegate to Republican National Convention, 1980" [BB 1977-78 p.175] — he stayed in the party's councils, went to Detroit, saw Reagan nominated — but his name never appeared on a ballot again.

The last months in office have a witness. Phil Gonet was hired in May 1978 as director of the House Republican Appropriations Committee staff — arriving, that is, to serve a spokesman who was already a lame duck. Forty-two years later, Gonet wrote the family: "I first observed Roscoe in the 1975 fall session of the General Assembly. I believe he was the best orator of his time, and his mastery of the written and spoken word was nonpareil (a term he would use!)." And then, with a staffer's precision about the timeline: "This formal association was short-lived as Roscoe had run, and lost, in the Republican Primary Election for Congress in March 1978. He left his legislative office in January 1979, but our friendship continued strong over the years" (Phil Gonet, tribute, December 3, 2020).

There is something quietly devastating in that sequence. The best orator of his time spent his final legislative session — nine months of it — as a man everyone in the chamber knew was finished. The verbatim transcripts of those months exist in the House debate archives, down to a session of June 30, 1978, and a February 1979 transcript that refers to him as a former representative; they have not yet been read for this book [ILGA htrans80]. What his voice sounded like on the floor that summer, whether it flagged or blazed, is a question v2 may answer. This edition can only report that he showed up, that George Ryan's new appropriations staffer was struck enough by him to stay a friend for forty years, and that in January 1979 he packed the desk that the governor's leg man had once visited so often, and went home to Lawrenceville.



What defeat did to him privately, in 1978 and the years right after, is the thinnest stretch of the whole record, and no amount of writerly ingenuity should be allowed to paper over that. His children could say; they have not yet been asked — the family interviews are on this book's unfinished list. What he himself chose to say, he said twice, at the end of his life, and the two passages are as close to the wound as he ever let a reader get.

The first is the accounting of what the loss cost. "To be retired, pensioned at 55 is a fate almost worse than death. We would have perished. The fire had gone from our belly. Nevermore could we seek elected office. Loving family, many friends, another twenty years with Golden Age Club #1, and the Sumner Press rescued us from the hole in which we thought we'd been pushed" (Journal, August 20, 2020).

Every clause of that deserves its weight. *We would have perished* — from a man who did not deal in melodrama about himself, writing at ninety-six with nothing left to perform. *The fire had gone from our belly* — the one admission anywhere in the 340 columns that the audacity, the engine of the whole life, ever failed him. *The hole in which we thought we'd been pushed* — pushed, not fell; four decades on, he still assigned the shove to Thompson. And then the list of what climbed down

into the hole after him: family, friends, the seniors' club he had founded in 1958, and a dying weekly newspaper he would buy nine years later. Chapter 7 of this book is the story of that purchase; here it is enough to notice that when Roscoe himself drew the map of his life, the road to The Sumner Press started at the bottom of the 1978 hole. The paper — and therefore the Journal, and therefore very nearly everything this book is made from — was what a man of audacity did with a defeat he could not argue, appeal, or outwork.

The second passage is the ledger of the years between. "For more than forty years we have successfully practiced law in the country. It was more financial rewarding but far less exciting than public service" (Journal, February 14, 2019). He says it again, almost word for word, in 2020 — "Practicing law in the country is more profitable than exciting" — which is how you know it was a settled verdict and not a passing mood. This from the man whose country practice, as Chapter 6 will show, put a case into every first-year property casebook in America. Even that was second best.

And the grudge? He kept it, fed it, and finally — in public, in print, in the same column — laid it down. "For many years we would have publicly proclaimed upon Thompson's death, 'good riddance,'" he admits, and then: "May we be forgiven for such hatred. We had overlooked the wise observation, 'never a man large or small came to naught, but by his own hand.' --Wilde" (Journal, August 20, 2020). It is a rare thing to watch a man convict himself under his own cross-examination. The blame he had carried for forty-two years — the flunky, the two-hour betrayal, the blizzard — he surrenders in a single citation: whatever Thompson did or didn't promise, the hand that gave up the safe seat was his own. Even here, though, the temperature of the old anger is preserved in the amber of his prose; the 2019 column calls Thompson "an effeminate governor," sneers at his delight in a *Time* magazine mention, and cheers the prospective sale of the Thompson Center in Chicago so that "the bitter memory of James R. Thompson will be erased" (Journal, February 14, 2019). Forgiveness, in Roscoe's Journal as in life, was a direction of travel, not an address.

For Dan Crane he reserved something colder than hatred: the long view. Crane went to Washington and, in July 1983, stood censured by the House after admitting a sexual relationship with a seventeen-year-old congressional page; he lost his seat at the next election. (That scandal is a matter of national record, though it sits outside this book's assembled source files — a v2 citation to pull.) Roscoe compressed it into a prosecutor's closing: "Within five years he cried on the floor of the Congress as he admitted sexual conduct with an underage page. He was replaced by a Democrat at the next election" (Journal, February 14, 2019). And in 2020, the acid distillate: "Ironically, the winner's family surely concluded their victory was pyrrhic for the shame that he brought to the family name while in Washington" (Journal, August 20, 2020). He drew a public lesson from it, too, the columnist generalizing where the loser might merely have gloated:

"Television has made elections beauty contests. Candidate's track record and character qualifications are of little concern in the voter's selection" (Journal, February 14, 2019). The photogenic dentist had beaten the orator; he never stopped believing the voters had graded on the wrong curve.



It would be false to close this chapter in bitterness, because he didn't. The obituary his family wrote says he "participated in more than 20 election campaigns and has always delighted in the political process" (Obituary), and his own late reminiscence of the campaigning life is all warmth: "We enjoyed going door to door to ask the voter for his support. Enjoyable except for the dog bites, even when the one solicited said, 'we'll think about it'. That phrase meant that they would usually vote against us" (Journal, February 14, 2019). In the same column he thanks "everyone along the line, from Sumner public schools, University of Illinois, and the precincts from constituencies from as large as thirteen counties for their encouragement and support" — the loss folded, by the end, into gratitude for the whole ride.

And the 2020 column, the one that begins in hatred of a dead governor, ends somewhere else entirely. "We have tried desperately every day following our personal disaster to make a contribution toward the well being of Lawrence County and our priceless friends therein," he writes, and then reaches back for the family text that governed the recovery — his grandfather Bainbridge Lafayette Cunningham, at ninety-five, instructing Roscoe's father: "David, do not tell the people downtown that I am just sitting at home, waiting to die. This is the best world I ever lived in" (Journal, August 20, 2020).

Every day following our personal disaster. That is his own periodization of his own life: there was before March 21, 1978, and there was after, and the after was a forty-two-year answer to the question the Washington Post's headline asked. A way of life did end in Illinois' 22nd. The man from Lawrence County spent the rest of his — the law office, the Golden Age Club, and above all the newspaper — proving that it was not the only way of life he had in him. He closed the very column in which he confessed the hole and the hatred with an instruction to his readers that doubles, better than anything a biographer could compose, as the moral of 1978: "We hope our readers will know that BL had it right and will maximize their own lives in this world" (Journal, August 20, 2020).



Roscoe's Journal, February 14, 2019, and August 20, 2020 — his two retrospective accounts of the 1978 primary (verbatim from `roscoe-journal-complete.md`). No contemporaneous account in his own hand survives in this book's corpus; the 1973–2012 Sumner Press era is unscanned and the paper was not yet his.

Illinois Issues, November 1977 (archived page; via `sources/web-findings.json`) — weighing the run for Shipley's open 22nd; decision announcement set for October 14.

Washington Post, July 7, 1978, "Losers in Illinois' 22nd: A Way of Life Ends" — quoted fragments only ("I was shocked beyond description"; "That Dr. Crane — I never saw him coming"; reported plan to run again in 1980); full text unpulled, paywalled (via `sources/web-findings.json`).

Phil Gonet tribute, The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`) — the 1975 orator recollection; May 1978 staff hiring; left office January 1979.

Obituary, The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 — "more than 20 election campaigns"; biographical anchors.

Illinois Blue Book 1981-82 p.214 (four terms, 77th–80th GA); Blue Book 1977-78 pp.66-67 (Appropriations I Minority Spokesman) and p.175 (bio; "Delegate to Republican National Convention, 1980") — via `sources/web-findings.json`, Illinois Digital Archives.

Flagged gaps: 1978 primary vote totals (Illinois State Archives canvass, not yet pulled); full WaPo text; 80th GA floor transcripts of his final session (ILGA htrans80, not yet read); Dan Crane's July 1983 censure cited from general public record pending a v2 source pull; family recollections not yet gathered. See `GAPS.md`.

Chapter 6 — The Hutton School (1981–1989)

In 1941, a Lawrence County farm couple named W. E. and Jennie Hutton deeded an acre and a half of their land to the trustees of the local school district. The deed carried one string, eleven words long: "this land to be used for school purpose only; otherwise to revert to Grantors herein" [Mahrenholz, 417 N.E.2d 138]. The district built a one-story schoolhouse on the parcel, and because it stood on Hutton ground, everyone called it the Hutton School.

Roscoe Cunningham was seventeen that year, a senior-to-be at Sumner High, a few miles and one township away. He had no connection to the deed, the school, or the Huttons that any record shows. But those eleven words were waiting for him.

In 1973 the district stopped holding classes at the Hutton School and began using the building to store desks, chairs, and surplus equipment. The question — the kind of question that sounds trivial until you try to answer it — was whether storing school property is a "school purpose." And behind that question stood a bigger one: if it wasn't, who owned the land now? The dispute that grew out of that empty schoolhouse became *Mahrenholz v. County Board of School Trustees of Lawrence County*, and Roscoe argued it — in 1981, again in 1984, and again in 1989, the last time under the banner of his own firm, Roscoe D. Cunningham, Ltd. [Mahrenholz, 417 N.E.2d 138 (5th Dist. 1981); 466 N.E.2d 322 (5th Dist. 1984); 544 N.E.2d 128 (5th Dist. 1989)].

He held office for twenty years of his life — State's Attorney, state representative. Every office produced records, and the records sit in courthouses and Blue Books where almost no one reads them. The Hutton School case produced something stranger: a permanent seat in the first-year law school curriculum. The 1981 opinion was picked up by Dukeminier and Krier's *Property* — the dominant first-year casebook in American legal education — and by others, as *the* teaching case for one of the oldest puzzles in the common law of land [web-findings: CourtListener op. 2084917]. Somewhere in America, every fall since, a room full of twenty-four-year-olds has been cold-called on a deed drafted in Lawrence County, Illinois, in 1941, and on an argument made by a country lawyer from Lawrenceville. Most of them will remember the Hutton School longer than they remember most of what they learned that year. None of them know who Roscoe Cunningham was. His name is simply there, in the counsel line, the way a mason's mark is there in a cathedral wall.

He never mentioned it. In the 340 columns of Roscoe's Journal we have recovered — 2013 to 2020, seven years of his unfiltered opinions on everything from the Muslim Brotherhood to the price of a haircut — the case that made him immortal to the legal profession does not appear once. Whether he wrote about it in the unscanned decades of the paper, 1987 to 2012, we cannot yet

say; that era exists only on microfilm in Springfield and in bound volumes nobody has opened for this project. It is possible he simply didn't think it remarkable. It was a farm-deed case. He had hundreds.



To understand what the fight was about, you need one piece of law, and it is worth having, because it is a genuinely beautiful piece of law — medieval machinery still running in the twentieth century, deciding who owns an acre and a half outside Sumner.

The common law gives a landowner two ways to give land away *with a condition attached*, and the difference between them is the difference between a mousetrap and a lawsuit.

The first is called a **fee simple determinable**. You convey the land "so long as" it is used for a school — and the moment it stops being used for a school, the estate simply *ends*. Automatically. Nobody has to do anything. Title snaps back to the original grantor (or his heirs) like a stretched rubber band released. The interest the grantor keeps is called, wonderfully, a *possibility of reverter*.

The second is called a **fee simple subject to condition subsequent**. You convey the land "provided that" or "on condition that" it be used for a school — and if the condition is broken, nothing happens automatically. The grantor merely acquires a *right of re-entry*: the right to step forward, declare the estate forfeit, and take the land back. Until he acts, the school district keeps it. A mousetrap that must be sprung by hand.

Ninety-nine times out of a hundred the distinction is academic. What made *Mahrenholz* the hundredth case was a peculiarity of Illinois law at the time: neither a possibility of reverter nor a right of re-entry could be sold or given away during the holder's life. They could only be *inherited*. The Huttons had died; their interest, whatever it was, had passed to their only heir, Harry Hutton. Harry had then signed his interest over to the Mahrenholzes, who owned the surrounding farmland — Roscoe's clients. So everything turned on which of the two interests Harry had inherited. If the 1941 deed created a fee simple determinable, then in 1973, the moment the schoolhouse arguably stopped serving a "school purpose," the land had *already reverted* to Harry automatically — meaning Harry owned the acre and a half outright, as ordinary land, and ordinary land he could sell. His deed to the Mahrenholzes would be good. But if the deed created only a condition subsequent, Harry had held nothing but a right of re-entry he never exercised — a right he could not convey — and the Mahrenholzes had bought nothing at all [Mahrenholz, 417 N.E.2d 138].

Eleven words, drafted by some scrivener in 1941, and neither of the magic phrases among them. "This land to be used for school purpose only; otherwise to revert to Grantors herein." Not "so long as." Not "on condition that." The Fifth District Appellate Court in Mount Vernon read the grant as a *limitation* on the estate itself — land given for one purpose *only*, with "otherwise to revert" describing an automatic snap-back rather than an option to re-enter — and held that the Huttons had created a fee simple determinable. Roscoe's side of the argument. The court sent the case back down to sort out whether school use had actually ceased, and the parties climbed the appellate ladder twice more, in 1984 (Roscoe again for the appellants, with co-counsel Wanda Ellen Wakefield, as in 1981) and in 1989, when the caption reads simply "Roscoe D. Cunningham, Ltd., for appellants" [Mahrenholz, 466 N.E.2d 322; 544 N.E.2d 128]. Our research file calls it a nineteen-year saga, and he ran it to the end [web-findings].

Honesty requires saying what we do not have. We have the three published opinions; we do not have the trial files, which sit in the Lawrence County Circuit Clerk's office and behind the CAPTCHA of an online court index nobody in the family has yet worked through [FOOTPRINT.md; GAPS.md]. We do not know how the Mahrenholzes came to hire him, what he charged, or what he thought of the case. We do not even hold the final disposition of the schoolhouse itself. What we hold is the part the law chose to keep — and the law, it turns out, chose to keep it forever. The casebook editors needed a clean specimen of the oldest distinction in the law of future interests, and a Lawrence County deed dispute, argued by the publisher-to-be of The Sumner Press, was the cleanest one American courts had produced.

There is an irony here worth sitting with. This book's thesis is Bacon's maxim, the one Roscoe himself quoted: to be remembered, write. He wrote three columns a week for thirty-three years, and that writing is why this book exists. But in the same decade he was preparing to buy the paper, he was accidentally acquiring a second, stranger immortality — one he didn't write, didn't choose, and probably never valued. The offices he *won* left records. The case he merely *argued* left him in the curriculum. Immortality, it seems, does not always consult you about the form it will take.



The Hutton School was the famous case. The rest of the 1980s was the living.

After Springfield — after the 1978 defeat that closed the political chapter of his life — Roscoe came home to what he was for all seventy-two years of his working life underneath everything else: a small-town lawyer. The reported cases mark the era's boundaries like survey stakes. Through the early 1970s the captions list him "of Gosnell, Benecki & Quindry, Ltd.," a Lawrenceville firm [Zimmerly Constr. Co. v. Industrial Comm'n, 278 N.E.2d 789 (Ill. 1972)]. By 1982 a new name

appears in the reporters for the first time: "Roscoe D. Cunningham, of Roscoe D. Cunningham, Ltd." [Weger v. Purcell, 431 N.E.2d 457 (5th Dist. 1982)]. The eponymous firm. By 1987 the firm has an associate, James M. Neal, appearing "of Roscoe D. Cunningham, Ltd." in a divorce appeal [In re Marriage of Holem, 506 N.E.2d 739 (5th Dist. 1987)]; Neal would eventually become his partner, and the letterhead would become Cunningham & Neal.

The docket of a two-lawyer country firm is the whole human comedy, and his reported cases from the decade read like a county's worth of trouble: a will contest here, a divorce there, a municipal fight — *Buehl v. Dayson* in 1984, *Turpen v. City of St. Francisville* in 1986, where his co-counsel was Edward J. Kionka, a Southern Illinois University law professor and appellate specialist he would team with again nearly twenty years later [Buehl, 469 N.E.2d 403; Turpen, 495 N.E.2d 1351]. And in 1987 — the same year he bought The Sumner Press, a story the next chapter tells — he stood in a federal court of appeals in Chicago arguing a railroad retirement claim for a man named Wallace Crown: "Roscoe D. Cunningham, Roscoe D. Cunningham, Ltd., Lawrenceville, Ill., for petitioner" [Crown v. U.S. Railroad Retirement Bd., 811 F.2d 1017 (7th Cir. 1987)]. Sixty-four years old, buying a dying newspaper with one hand and briefing the Seventh Circuit with the other.

He called his office the Law Factory. The name is all over the columns — it was where the paper was picked up, where visitors reported in, where parties were held. In 2014 he writes of a secretary's iron constancy: "During 45 years never were there two consecutive work days that farlene failed to come to the Law Factory on account of the weather" (Journal, January 9, 2014) — the lowercase "farlene" is the paper's own typo, preserved here as printed, and forty-five years means she was there before the firm had his name on it. In 2015 he announces: "Only two weeks from Monday until Groundhog Day. We plan a party that afternoon at the Law Factory, 2 p.m. Cake & ice cream. Readers are invited" (Journal, January 15, 2015). That same year, this lifelong Republican, three-time delegate to Republican National Conventions, lets slip a detail about the office decor: "We are amused by the facial expression of surprise of most visitors to the Law Factory when they notice a picture of President Barrack Obama, and family, prominently displayed" (Journal, March 26, 2015). And near the end, tethered to his oxygen concentrator, he makes the office a condition of friendship: "It is agreed and understood that when any friends from the larger world come to or near Lawrenceville, he, or she, will stop for a few minutes at the Law Factory to bring us up to speed. If any shall fail to thus assist, we are authorized to 'turn their picture to the wall'" (Journal, September 21, 2017).

What kind of lawyer was he? The columns give his creed in fragments, and the fragments are consistent. On the defense function, from a man who spent four terms prosecuting: "Nonsense to argue that a defense lawyer is a scoundrel merely because he/she succeeded in defending scum. In every criminal prosecution the cards are stacked against the defense. Latter should be allowed

space for innovation. Otherwise, the process is kangaroo to conviction" (Journal, June 26, 2014). On judicial temperament, a memory from his workers' compensation practice: "Too often we forget that every issue has two sides. We remember an irascible Illinois Industrial Commissioner whose desk prominently displayed a sign, 'audi alteram partem' which he said was Latin, to remind him to hear other lawyers, too" (Journal, March 3, 2016). On the standing of his profession, he was cheerfully merciless: "Annual increase of lawyers vs doctors in Illinois has become scandalous. Press suggestion deserves to be heard: tear up license of every lawyer under 30 years of age, send him or her to medical school at government expense" (Journal, August 22, 2013). He even planned for professional contingencies abroad — vowing in 2015 that if a certain candidate were elected president "we'll migrate to Australia," he adds: "In case we've erred again, we have written of the Barristers, Registrar, Canberra to inquire if reciprocity extended to Illinois lawyers" (Journal, August 27, 2015).

And once, memorably, he ranked his own credentials by their persuasive power. Deposing or courting a reluctant expert, he found that "lawyer" opened no doors:

We were attempting to persuade a Terre Haute pathologist to accept a factual assertion. In desperation, we said, "on our word as a lawyer." His rejection was instantaneous, "that's it." We needed his cooperation and persisted, "we are also a newspaper publisher.--- You can read the Sumner Press on the Internet for free." To our surprise he countered, "that's worse." One more try, "we are a member of First Christian, and regularly attend." It was the magic word.

(Journal, September 11, 2014)

The people across the table remembered him too. In the tribute edition after his death, Ray Vaughn, once "a young and naive assistant state's attorney in Olney," recalled being schooled by Roscoe, "who was adamant that his client was innocent. Roscoe declared 'if I am not being truthful, may God strike me down.' I immediately ducked under a desk for protection which Roscoe found amusing but did not slow him down" (Ray Vaughn, tribute edition). Larry Pulleyblank kept it simple: "Roscoe represented me in 1964. He impressed me with his skills" — and fifty-six years later took the trouble to say so in print (Larry Pulleyblank, tribute edition). Donna White Burton traced her whole career to watching him work: "Roscoe is the reason I became a lawyer. I was a good elder law attorney in NJ because I had watched Roscoe look out and advocate for our most vulnerable of citizens in Lawrence County" (Donna White Burton, tribute edition). And Gary Pope — a Lawrenceville boy who became a judge in Arizona — remembered dropping by the office one law-school summer to find Roscoe suing the City of Lawrenceville to stop it paving over the old red-brick streets around the square. "Roscoe felt a piece of history was being covered over. He ultimately settled the case and the city agreed to leave 16th street, from State to the cemetery, as a brick street," Pope wrote, calling it "a reminder of days gone by and the tenacity of Roscoe C." (Gary Pope, tribute edition). The record doesn't date

the brick-street case; it belongs to the same instinct as everything else in this chapter — the conviction that a thing worth keeping was worth litigating for.



The strangest fact about his law practice is not the casebook. It is that the firm's finest hour came when he was eighty.

Kijonka v. Seitzinger was a federal civil-rights suit — a Section 1983 false-arrest claim brought against a Lawrenceville police officer — and when it was thrown out below, Cunningham & Neal carried it up to the United States Court of Appeals for the Seventh Circuit in Chicago. The opinion that came back in 2004, deciding the appeal, was written by Judge Richard Posner, then perhaps the most famous and most-cited appellate judge in America. *Kijonka v. Seitzinger*, 363 F.3d 645 (7th Cir. 2004), has itself been cited more than seventy-five times since — the most-cited case his firm ever touched [web-findings: CourtListener op. 785686]. Roscoe David Cunningham, admitted to the Illinois bar May 17, 1948 [IARDC record], was eighty years old and arguing federal constitutional law against a hometown police department. The same year, at eighty-one, he briefed a criminal appeal with Professor Kionka [People v. Tibbetts, 815 N.E.2d 409 (5th Dist. 2004)].

He was not done. A few years later an appellate opinion out of neighboring Crawford County noted, almost in passing, that the defendant "was represented at the trial by retained counsel, Roscoe D. Cunningham" [People v. Burtron, 877 N.E.2d 87 (5th Dist. 2007)]. Read that caption date against his birth certificate: he tried that criminal case — a live jury-trial practice, not paper-shuffling — in his mid-eighties, and the appeal turned on a mistrial declared in the middle of the trial he was conducting. We have not yet pulled the Burtron trial transcript; it is on the list [FOOTPRINT.md].

Bill Richardson, a Lawrence County newspaperman, preserved what hiring the old man was like in those years. Ticketed for speeding in Pulaski County in 2005, he called Roscoe for guidance. "After hearing me out, he chortled, as he often did, and replied, 'I only weigh about 175 pounds down there, but let me see what I can do.'" Days later Richardson's desk phone rang. "'Roscoe D. Cunningham here,' rasped the man at the other end. 'Charges dropped. Case dismissed.' He then hung up, before I could even respond." No bill was sent — a favor, Roscoe said, to a fellow journalist (Bill Richardson, tribute edition). Richardson closed his tribute with the epitaph the profession would have chosen: "The old joke is that lawyers never die, they just lose their appeal. We can only hope that's true, and that Roscoe D. Cunningham is still practicing in heaven's courtroom, just as he did for more than 70 years here on earth."

The official ledger agrees with the folklore. The Illinois Attorney Registration and Disciplinary Commission's record for Roscoe David Cunningham shows admission on May 17, 1948, last registered year 2020 — the year he died — and, across seventy-two years of practice, a public record of discipline reading: none [IARDC record]. The obituary says he "practiced law for over 72 years" (Obituary), and for once an obituary understates nothing. He kept score himself. "We shall continue to try and live by the Golden Rule, and make peace with all that we may have offended in 70 years of lawyering," he resolves one New Year (Journal, January 4, 2018). And in his last spring: "We look back in Lawrence County 72 years ago when we became a lawyer. When we compare Lawrence County then and now we shudder how far we have fallen" (Journal, May 28, 2020). Even the elegy for his own career had to double as a county development editorial. It always did.



There is a document that closes this chapter and opens the next one at the same time. After Roscoe died, the paper's staff filled his empty page with reprints, and on December 31, 2020, they ran what an editor's note called "one of the first writings by Roscoe D. Cunningham when he became an owner of The Sumner Press" — a column originally printed December 28, 1989 (Journal, December 28, 1989; memorial reprint December 31, 2020).

The subject was Illinois' new mandatory automobile-insurance law, taking effect that New Year's Day, and the sixty-six-year-old author is unmistakably both of his professions at once. The lawyer inspects the statute's machinery and finds it wanting: "Our lawyers believe that Illinois' effort to criminalize non-residents' operation of their uninsured motor vehicles in this state is unconstitutional, in violation of the due process clause." The publisher grins at his own guild: "Happily, for the lawyers, this new law will bring much litigation. But the larger financial windfall will come to the automobile insurance companies." And the editorialist lands on the theme he would still be sounding thirty-one years later, in the columns this book's grandson-author recovered: "The whole concept is mandatory liability insurance shows how far we have strayed from the priceless Jeffersonian principal 'that government best that governs least'" (Journal, December 28, 1989). The grammatical stumbles are in the original — they always were; the man composed at speed on Tuesday nights and never pretended otherwise.

That column is the earliest specimen of Roscoe's Journal we possess, and it shows the voice already fully formed: Shakespeare in the first sentence, the due process clause in the middle, and a needle for the insurance lobby on the way out. In 1989 he was simultaneously finishing the Hutton School litigation, running a two-lawyer firm, and two years into the newspaper rescue that the next chapter recounts. The law had already made his name permanent in a book he didn't write. He spent the next thirty-one years writing his own.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal columns (verbatim, `roscoe-journal-complete.md`): August 22, 2013; January 9, 2014; June 26, 2014; September 11, 2014; January 15, 2015; March 26, 2015; August 27, 2015; March 3, 2016; September 21, 2017; January 4, 2018; May 28, 2020; and the December 28, 1989 column as reprinted in the December 31, 2020 memorial edition.

Tribute edition, The Sumner Press, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`): obituary; tributes of Ray Vaughn, Bill Richardson, Donna White Burton, Larry Pulleyblank, Gary Pope, Mike Hedges, Doug Carroll.

Reported cases (all counsel lines verified via CourtListener, per `book/sources/web-findings.json`): Mahrenholz v. County Board of School Trustees, 93 Ill. App. 3d 366, 417 N.E.2d 138 (5th Dist. 1981); 125 Ill. App. 3d 619, 466 N.E.2d 322 (5th Dist. 1984); 188 Ill. App. 3d 260, 544 N.E.2d 128 (5th Dist. 1989); Weger v. Purcell, 103 Ill. App. 3d 470, 431 N.E.2d 457 (5th Dist. 1982); Buehl v. Dayson, 127 Ill. App. 3d 958, 469 N.E.2d 403 (5th Dist. 1984); Turpen v. City of St. Francisville, 145 Ill. App. 3d 891, 495 N.E.2d 1351 (5th Dist. 1986); Crown v. U.S. Railroad Retirement Board, 811 F.2d 1017 (7th Cir. 1987); In re Marriage of Holem, 153 Ill. App. 3d 1095, 506 N.E.2d 739 (5th Dist. 1987); Zimmerly Construction Co. v. Industrial Commission, 50 Ill. 2d 342, 278 N.E.2d 789 (Ill. 1972); Kijonka v. Seitzinger, 363 F.3d 645 (7th Cir. 2004); People v. Tibbetts, 351 Ill. App. 3d 921, 815 N.E.2d 409 (5th Dist. 2004); People v. Burtron, 376 Ill. App. 3d 856, 877 N.E.2d 87 (5th Dist. 2007).

Bar records: IARDC printable record (admitted May 17, 1948; last registered 2020; no discipline); ISBA Bar News memorial, December 2020 (per web-findings.json).

Research files: `book/sources/web-findings.json` (legal-footprint hunt, incl. casebook identification — Dukeminier & Krier and others); `FOOTPRINT.md`; `GAPS.md`.

Known gaps, stated in text: Mahrenholz trial files and final disposition (Lawrence County Circuit Clerk / Judici, not yet pulled); the 1987–2012 print era of the paper (unscanned); the Burtron trial transcript; the date and file of the brick-streets suit.

Chapter 7 — The Rescue (1987)

In 1987, Roscoe Cunningham bought a dying weekly newspaper. He was sixty-three years old — sixty-four by that September — and by every conventional measure of an American life, he was finished. He had been a soldier, a four-term prosecutor, a four-term legislator, and for nearly forty years a country lawyer with cases in the Illinois Supreme Court and the federal courts of appeals. That same year his name appeared in the Seventh Circuit reports, arguing a railroad retirement case in Chicago [*Crown v. U.S. Railroad Retirement Board*, 811 F.2d 1017 (7th Cir. 1987)]. Other men his age were studying brochures for Florida. He bought The Sumner Press.

His obituary — written by the family, printed in the paper he saved — explains the decision the way he apparently explained it himself, with scripture. One of his favorite Bible verses was Luke 9:62: "No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God." The obituary continues: "Instilled since childhood, this verse inspired him to rescue his hometown newspaper, The Sumner Press in 1987 - at an age most people would be thinking about retiring" (Obituary). Note the family's verb. Not *bought*. Not *acquired*. *Rescue*. Doug Carroll, an old newspaperman himself, confirmed in his tribute what the verb implies: "I read his column often in the Sumner Press but I did not know the paper would have ceased if not for Mr. Roscoe" (Doug Carroll). The paper was going under, and Roscoe caught it.

Here the record goes thin, and it is worth saying exactly how thin. We do not know what he paid, who he bought it from, what month the sale closed, or what the office looked like when he walked in as owner. The Sumner Press of 1973 through 2012 — the entire first quarter-century of his ownership — survives on microfilm in Springfield and in bound volumes and library stacks, but almost none of it has been digitized, and none of it was available when this book was written. The purchase that redirected the last third of his life is, for now, documented mainly by what he and his family said about it afterward. A researcher with a day at the Abraham Lincoln Presidential Library could fill this hole. This book flags it and moves on.



What he bought was old — older than the town's memory of it, and older than its own occasionally repeated founding date. The masthead of the tribute edition of December 3, 2020, reads: "THE SUMNER PRESS — Established 1876 — 144 YEARS — Lawrence County's Largest (Circulation) Weekly" (tribute edition, front page). The Library of Congress record is more particular. The Sumner Press proper began on April 13, 1882, as Volume 7, Number 16 — the volume numbering carried over from its predecessor, the Lawrence County Press, founded in Sumner in 1876 [LCCN

sn88086087; INP holdings, OCLC 17560015]. So both dates are true: a paper called the Press had served Sumner since 1876, and the title Roscoe bought had run unbroken under its own name since 1882. When he took it over in 1987 it was already a 111-year institution. His obituary states the result of the next thirty-three years plainly: "His determined efforts ensured The Sumner Press is the longest running, locally owned newspaper in Southern Illinois" (Obituary).

That claim — locally owned — was the whole point. The story of the American small-town paper after 1980 is mostly a story of chains: family weeklies sold to regional groups, regional groups sold to national ones, newsrooms hollowed out by owners three states away. Sumner, Illinois, population well under two thousand, kept a paper owned by a man whose office was in the county, whose byline was on page 3, and whose phone number was on the masthead. He kept it that way for thirty-three years, and he kept it a family operation to the end — over time adding Bridgeport Leader and St. Francisville Times pages so the neighboring towns would have community news of their own (Obituary).

Why does a lawyer buy a newspaper? The obituary offers one more phrase, and it may be the best single description of what the Press was to him: "it was a source of joy, and the academic man's golf game for over 33 years" (Obituary). Other professional men of his generation had the links. Roscoe had a page-3 column, three of them actually — Worldwide Digest for the world, Roscoe's Journal for his own mind, Countywide for Lawrence County — and a Thursday deadline that structured every week of his old age.

The tribute edition ran a photograph of him at work, and its caption is the most compact biography of his last third of life that anyone ever wrote:

Tuesday evenings at The Sumner Press, composing his columns, Worldwide Digest, Roscoe's Journal and Countywide.

(tribute edition, front-page photo caption)

Tuesday evenings. For thirty-three years, whatever else the week held — trials, funerals, elections, oxygen hoses — Tuesday evening he was at the Press, composing. The columns collected in this book exist because that appointment was kept, week over week, until three weeks before he died.



He had no illusions about the pulpit he had purchased. In the spring of 2016, twenty-nine years into ownership, he takes stock of the trade with a candor most publishers reserve for the bar after deadline: "We fear publishing small town newspaper isolates one from reality. Tis easy to point out the changes that should be made. But causing that to happen is quite impossible" (Journal, April 14, 2016). And in the next breath, the exhibit for the prosecution: "Fifty years of furious

effort for four lanes for Route 50 without tangible progress is discouraging" (Journal, April 14, 2016).

Yet the discouragement never once translated into stopping, and the New Year's column of 2015 shows why. It opens with a threat he had no intention of keeping: "Now for resolutions: We're going to cause more reader response, or throw in the towel before 2015 is done" (Journal, January 1, 2015). He wonders aloud — "Sometimes we wonder if anyone reads the Press" (Journal, January 1, 2015) — and then, having flirted with despair for exactly two paragraphs, he lays out the agenda that made the paper worth owning:

Another New Year's resolution are not confined to the resurrection of the Press. We believe that if we will all resolve together to demand of Springfield and Washington that our pet projects: Four Lanes for Fifty; Low level dam on the Wabash; aeronautic related industry at George Field, aka Mid-Continent International Airport d& community college related classes in manual arts be taught at either high school given top priority, progress and will be made in in each.

(Journal, January 1, 2015)

The typographical stumbles are his, preserved as printed — he set his own copy, in his nineties, and the reader who wants polish can go read a chain paper. The substance is the platform he ran the Press on for three decades: four lanes, a dam, an airport, shop classes. And the closing line of the sequence is the purest statement of what he believed a local paper was *for*: "None should fear to ask his political servant what he has done to make our goals come alive" (Journal, January 1, 2015).

The Press was, in other words, an instrument. The tribute edition devoted its page 6 to proof: two of the letters he "consistently wrote to plead the case for Lawrence County and Southeastern Illinois" on Four Lanes for 50 (tribute edition, page 6). The May 21, 2020, letter to the regional highway engineer announces that "This newspaper intends to move heaven and hell to revive indicated road construction deemed essential for the economic survival and growth of Lawrence County," and it carries a signature block that tells you how he worked: "The Sumner Press, Roscoe Cunningham and David Lane" (tribute edition, page 6). Lane — a retired Indiana Department of Transportation official, and by 2020 engaged to Roscoe's daughter Lorie (Obituary) — brought the engineering facts; Roscoe brought the newspaper and the heaven and hell. The September 29, 2020, column on the same page recounts a maddening phone call with the engineer, who, asked bluntly "are you with us, or against us?", answered "I'm in between," to which the ninety-seven-year-old publisher replied in print: "That won't get it. We've been pushing for four lanes for more than 50 years" (tribute edition, page 6). He was still bombarding the Illinois Department of Transportation two months before he died. The full story of Four Lanes for 50 belongs to the next

chapter; what matters here is that the campaign had a headquarters, and the headquarters was a print shop in Sumner.



He did not run it alone. Allen Johnson — the same Allen Johnson who had watched him fake-barber a customer in 1952 — turns up in a 2017 column with a quiet tribute inside a comic complaint: "Allen Johnson, Dayton, OH, and Phil Gonet, Springfield, are two of our dearest friends. Press readers know how helpful Allen has been for more than 25 years in producing your newspaper" (Journal, September 21, 2017). Twenty-five years of helping produce a weekly, from Dayton, Ohio, counts as devotion in any trade.

The editor was Barbara E. Allender, and her tribute preserves both his recruiting style and his farewell line. "When I started a career in newspapers," she wrote, "Roscoe often tried to lure me away from the other papers in the county, touting that if they fire me... to come and see him. Nearly 11 years ago, I returned to Illinois (Lukin) after living in Indiana. He heard through a mutual friend, Art Dale, that I was home. Two days later, I was working at the Press" (Barbara E. Allender). Two days. The man moved fast when the right hire came within range. "We shared a mission to highlight the best of Lawrence County," she went on, and closed with the words he used at the end of every working exchange: "As he would say in parting, 'Thank you for your efforts,' I am thankful that we shared in those efforts and a part of life's journey together" (Barbara E. Allender).

The working relationship between publisher and editor shows up in the columns themselves, and it shows a man who could be corrected — for a price. In April 2017 he confesses: "Of money, we solemnly assured readers that write-in candidates were printed on official ballots, as we bemoaned the good old days with element of surprise. Editor Barbara Allender discreetly corrected us to the extent of a \$5 bet. The name of the write in is not printed on ballot" (Journal, April 27, 2017). He pays up in the last line: "We will try more effectively to be correct in what we write" (Journal, April 27, 2017).

And he recruited writers the way he had once recruited juries — by deciding the matter himself. Susan Sovereign's tribute recounts her terrified first visit to his office around 1995, four stories clutched in her hand, and the tug-of-war — literal — when he reached for them and she wouldn't let go. He read them, took off his glasses, and asked, "When do you want me to begin working for you?" Then he settled the terms: "I should like to start publishing these next week. However, your real name isn't appropriate. From now on, you will be Susan Sovereign and your husband's name will be Sam" (Sam and Susan Sovereign). She wrote for him for twenty-five years under the name he invented in that chair.

That was the operation: an editor lured home from Indiana in two days, a helper in Ohio faithful for a quarter century, contributors rechristened on the spot, family members drafted for pages and campaigns, and the publisher at the center of it every Tuesday evening. It was small, personal, improvised, and it worked — the paper hit the porches of Lawrence County every Thursday for thirty-three years.



It worked against lengthening odds. The last years of Roscoe's Press coincided with the collapse of the infrastructure that small papers depend on — most invisibly, the printing plants. A weekly in Sumner, Illinois, does not own a modern press; it sends its pages out to be printed, and as regional printers folded, the distance to the nearest one grew. In June 2019, at ninety-five, he told his readers exactly what keeping the paper alive now required, in a passage that deserves to be quoted in full because it contains the entire creed of his publishing life:

We appreciate our readers' patience in frequent delay of delivery of their copy. We search for print shops weekly in far away places, including Bedford and Bloomington, Indiana, and Henderson, KY. Facebook has made the printed newspaper an endangered species. We think it a historical document worth preservation at whatever cost.

(Journal, June 27, 2019)

Bedford is a hundred miles from Sumner. Henderson, Kentucky, is farther. A man in his mid-nineties was scouting print shops across two state lines, weekly, so that a paper for a town of a thousand people would keep appearing on paper. And the reason is right there in the last sentence, in the lawyer's measured cadence: *a historical document worth preservation at whatever cost*. He did not say the paper was profitable, or influential, or even widely read — he had wondered in print whether anyone read it at all. He said it was a historical document. He was preserving the record of a community, the way a courthouse preserves deeds.

He named the enemy without hysteria and with a certain rueful honesty about his own stake. "We confess bias against Facebook probably because it is such overwhelming competition to newspapering, which we love," he writes in April 2020 (Journal, April 9, 2020). In the same column he widens the lens to two and a half centuries: the trouble with the platforms, he concludes, is "that much of the content is meaningless gossip and that its wide popularity has caused average Americans to abandon newspapers though latter have nobly served public enlightenment since the childhood of Benjamin Franklin" (Journal, April 9, 2020).

Then, in that same quarantine-spring column, the ninety-six-year-old publisher did something no chain would ever do. He offered a warranty:

Lest our gloomy fears for the future of newspaper persuade a single person not to subscribe or renew his copy of the Press, we promise herewith to refund on demand unused portion of prepaid subscription price if this newspaper should fold.

(Journal, April 9, 2020)

He extended the offer to new subscribers dissatisfied after a six-week trial, and then added the codicil that only he would have thought to add, half joke and half actuarial disclosure: "Of course, these guarantees are limited to our own mortality" (Journal, April 9, 2020). The paper was guaranteed by the man. Both, as it turned out, had about seven months left together.

He never stopped selling it, either. When the Press's sports desk — that is, Roscoe — correctly picked the winner of the 2019 Kentucky Derby weeks in advance (out of loyalty, he explained, to the Sumner Correctional Facility, the horse being named Maximum Security), he closed the item like a publisher: "Your newspaper will continue to strive to benefit its readers" (Journal, May 9, 2019).



Was it worth it? The question is really two questions. As a business, no honest accounting survives, and his friend John Hamilton, in the memorial column he wrote for the tribute edition, admitted that in their weekly visits the two of them "couldn't even figure a way small-town newspapers were going to stay viable and continue their essential role in local news" (John Hamilton). As a preservation project — the thing he actually said it was — the verdict is already in, and this book is part of it.

Because he kept the Press alive and locally owned, and because he insisted on putting its electronic edition online "provided free as a community service" (Obituary), the paper's run from July 2013 through the end of 2020 — 392 weekly issues — survives complete in digital form, and the 340 columns quoted throughout this book were recovered from it [web-findings: sumnerpress.com e-edition survey, 2026]. The paper's first ninety years, 1882 to 1972, survive as 31,292 digitized pages in a free public archive [web-findings: Lawrence Public Library District Community History Archive]. The gap between — the microfilmed but undigitized 1973–2012 — is the book's largest missing room, and it is missing only in the sense that no one has yet gone to Springfield to open it. When Congressman John Shimkus rose in the U.S. House eleven days after Roscoe's death to read his life into the Congressional Record, the rescue of The Sumner Press was on the short list of things worth telling Congress [Cong. Rec., Dec. 9, 2020, Vol. 166, No. 208, p. E1121].

A man who buys a failing weekly at sixty-four is not making an investment. He is making an argument — that the place he came from deserves a record, and that the record is "worth

preservation at whatever cost," and that if nobody else will pay the cost, he will, in money and in Tuesday evenings, for as long as the guarantee runs. It ran thirty-three years. The hand went to the plow in 1987 and never looked back.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal columns, quoted verbatim from ``roscoe-journal-complete.md``: January 1, 2015; April 14, 2016; April 27, 2017; September 21, 2017; May 9, 2019; June 27, 2019; April 9, 2020.

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (``tribute-2020-12-03.md``): masthead; front-page photo caption ("Tuesday evenings at The Sumner Press..."); obituary (page 4); tributes of Barbara E. Allender, Doug Carroll, Sam and Susan Sovereign; John Hamilton's memorial column "What's Fair?"; Four Lanes for 50 letters (page 6, September 29, 2020 column and May 21, 2020 letter co-signed with David Lane).

Paper lineage and holdings: Library of Congress newspaper record [LCCN sn88086087] (Sumner Press 1882–current, first issue April 13, 1882, Vol. 7 No. 16, continuing the Lawrence County Press, 1876–1882); Illinois Newspaper Project holdings [OCLC 17560015]; ``book/sources/web-findings.json`` (newspaper-survival hunt: 392-issue e-edition run 2013–2020, Lawrence Public Library archive 1882–1972, the undigitized 1973–2012 microfilm era at the Abraham Lincoln Presidential Library).

Legal: *Crown v. U.S. Railroad Retirement Board* [811 F.2d 1017 (7th Cir. 1987)], via ``book/sources/web-findings.json`` (CourtListener).

Congressional tribute: Rep. John Shimkus, Extensions of Remarks [Cong. Rec., Dec. 9, 2020, Vol. 166, No. 208, p. E1121], via ``book/sources/web-findings.json``.

Known gaps stated in text: purchase price, seller, and month of the 1987 sale undocumented in available sources; the 1973–2012 print era not yet digitized (see ``GAPS.md``, ``FOOTPRINT.md``).

Chapter 8 — The Journal (the voice)

Every week for thirty-three years, a reader who opened The Sumner Press to page 3 found the same thing waiting: a stack of short items under the standing title Roscoe's Journal, each separated from the next by a typographic tic — three lowercase letters, "xxx," centered on their own line (in later years sometimes three asterisks; the function never changed). No transitions, no through-line, no apology for the lack of either. An item could be a crusade, a prophecy, a scolding, a prayer, or one sentence of pure mischief. The previous chapters told what Roscoe Cunningham did. This chapter is about what he sounded like, and it works the way the Journal worked: short frames, long quotes, the xxx doing the heavy lifting.

The fairest specimen to start with is the earliest column in the recovered corpus — July 4, 2013, when he was eighty-nine. It opens mid-grievance, on a crusade that no reader could have thought was going anywhere:

Lawrence County xenophobia against revealing cell phone number has worsened. Five years ago, Press offered to create free cell phone number book. If each reader would send in his number, we would alphabetize and publish. Unanimously rejected.

(Journal, July 4, 2013)

Unanimously rejected. A lesser columnist buries his defeats; Roscoe files them as evidence. Three items later the column has become a chamber-of-commerce pitch built from Chicago's crime rate:

Those who lament living in a small Southern Illinois town, "no where to go; nothing to do", should listen to WGN-TV @ 9. Rarely does it report fewer than two murders. Our Chamber should advertise in the Tribune, "Move to Lawrence County, Violent Crime Almost Non-Existent."

(Journal, July 4, 2013)

Then, with nothing but an xxx in between, a one-sentence item: "Unless there are fewer medicine ads on TV, we shall all become hypochondriacs." (Journal, July 4, 2013). And near the bottom, after Edward Snowden and an open search for someone to inherit the paper itself, the column closes on a wounded note about the lights on his own building:

Of sparkle, we have been dismayed. Not a single person has volunteered the opinion that the red, white & blue rows of LED lights across the railing of the portico at Hotel Lawrence is a thing of beauty. They are solar powered. The taste of too many is only in the mouth.

(Journal, July 4, 2013)

That is the whole anatomy in one column: crusade, boosterism, aphorism, national item, household grievance elevated to public record. "The taste of too many is only in the mouth" is the kind of line other writers would save for a book. He spent it on porch lights, on a Thursday, and made more the following week.



A few features of the machine deserve naming before the anthology proper.

First, the "we." As the prologue noted, it is the editorial we of the small-town publisher, applied to everything — his opinions, his boyhood, his phone calls. It was not modesty and not majesty; it was the paper talking, and he was the paper. When an item turned most personal the "we" could slip to "I" for a sentence and slip back, and the slippage was itself information.

Second, the renaming. He renamed the world as a matter of editorial policy. His county appears for decades not as Lawrence County but as "County Lawrence," inverted like a title in a peerage — "Winter has come to County Lawrence" (Journal, November 14, 2013). People got the same treatment. When a terrified would-be contributor brought him four stories in about 1995 and lost the tug-of-war over the manuscript, he hired her on the spot and then, in the same breath: "However, your real name isn't appropriate. From now on, you will be Susan Sovereign and your husband's name will be Sam" (Sam and Susan Sovereign, tribute, December 3, 2020). Her real name does not appear even in her own tribute to him. Family memory holds that he extended the habit as far as the capital of China, insisting on "Bei Ping" long after the atlases had moved on — but no surviving column shows it (the columns that mention the city render it "Beijing"), so the habit, if he kept it, lived in conversation or in the unscanned decades, and this book will not pretend otherwise. What the surviving columns do show is his sovereign way with proper names generally: Bert Lance printed as "Burt Lence," Xi Jinping as "Li Jinpjng," Kim Jong-un as "Kim Il Jung." Some of that is a nonagenarian at a keyboard. Some of it is a man who had decided, sometime around 1948, that the world's names were negotiable and his were not.

Third, the aphorisms. Certain sentences recur across the years like tools kept on a pegboard. The most-used was a legal maxim of his own manufacture — "the law of common sense has never been repealed" — applied over the years to job qualifications (July 16, 2015), to the preservation of a wooden railroad bridge (May 17, 2018), to 3-D printed guns (August 9, 2018), and, in his last summer, to prisoner volunteers in vaccine trials. And in June 2020, at ninety-six, he coined his last one in public view, while reading Mark Twain's autobiography and wondering whether his friend Allen Johnson had plagiarized a dead man's style. Of course not, he ruled — "But Allen did run afoul of the rule: 'we were born too late, in a world too old to be original in writing.'" (Journal, June 4, 2020). Then the attribution audit:

We had thought that truth was attributable to Somerset Maugham. Google couldn't confirm, so, we propose to claim it as Roscoe's Rule.

(Journal, June 4, 2020)

That is the complete intellectual method of the Journal: cite your authority, check your authority, and when the authority fails to appear, promote yourself.

Fourth, the Journal printed its own errors and owned them in the same flat register as everything else. The column of November 15, 2018 opens: "Our apology to our readers-the November 8 issue recopied the November 1 Journal." (Journal, November 15, 2018). An entire week's column had run twice; the correction got one line, no excuse, then an xxx, because there was news about North Korea to get to.



Now the anthology. Start where he started, with the county.

Lawrence County boosterism was the Journal's ground bass — the theme under every other theme. The pitch was always the same: the county was dying of out-migration, and the cure was to advertise its virtues shamelessly until the talented came home. In October 2014 the virtue was the weather:

We should each invite everyone we know who lives afar to move back to County Lawrence whose climate is non pareil—no killing frost until after November 1! Home secure without locking the doors. Happy, carefree citizenry without industrial problems in the air they breathe.

(Journal, October 23, 2014)

But the masterpiece of the genre came a year earlier, in a column that had been dark to that point — a scolding about the county jail, a lament that a former State's Attorney had left for a lesser job in the next county over. Then, in the final item, the clouds part and out comes the single most quoted sentence he ever wrote about home:

We must do more to make Lawrence County attractive to every worthwhile citizen we can lure within its boundaries. We should have a parade every Saturday in the county seat, and a place where a lady can get her toenails painted at midnight which is why Amy Padgett stated on her Facebook that she loved living in Hong Kong .

(Journal, October 24, 2013)

Read it again slowly. A ninety-year-old publisher in a shrinking Illinois county has been scrolling Facebook, has found a local expatriate explaining why she loves Hong Kong, and has extracted

from her post a two-plank municipal platform: a parade every Saturday, and midnight pedicures. He is not joking, or not only joking. What Amy Padgett loved about Hong Kong was that it was alive at all hours and celebrated itself constantly. He was telling Lawrenceville that those were policies, and cheap ones.



The longest-running crusade — the one that outlived him and made his memorial pages — was Four Lanes for 50: the fifty-year campaign to widen U.S. Route 50 from Lawrenceville west to Interstate 57 at Salem. Here is how it sounded in the Journal itself, year over year, in whatever register the week required.

In 2014 it was a foreign-aid ledger — "Above all, we should save the one billion dollars foreign aid earmarked for Afghanistan. It would build Four Lanes for Route Fifty, and a dozen other needed projects in neglected U.S.A." (Journal, January 30, 2014). In 2016 it was weariness, stated once and then set down, in a column that opened with as candid a line about his trade as he ever printed:

We fear publishing small town newspaper isolates one from reality. Tis easy to point out the changes that should be made. But causing that to happen is quite impossible.

(Journal, April 14, 2016)

Fifty years of furious effort for four lanes for Route 50 without tangible progress is discouraging.

(Journal, April 14, 2016)

By that November he had a new administration to work, and a new tactic — flattery by nomenclature, the renaming instinct weaponized: "Might be helpful if our County Board adopted a resolution to name this needed highway, 'Pence's Path,' since it leads to his native Indiana, and needs his palpable assist." (Journal, November 17, 2016). In 2018 it was an election-year loyalty oath:

Everyone running for Springfield office in 2018 should be asked his stand on four lanes for Highway 50, and his answers subscribed in blood.

(Journal, January 4, 2018)

By 2019 a Democrat was governor, so the highway changed names again — he had, without anyone's permission, christened the existing ten miles of four-lane "the J.B. Pritzker Expressway" — and the column form itself mutated into open letters, signed like correspondence:

Governor J.B. Pritzker, Springfield, IL, We hope the new district engineer for District 7, Tom Kreke, is sympathetic to Lawrence County's need for four lanes on the highway named in your honor. With best wishes, *The Sumner Press*.

(Journal, April 25, 2019)

And in October 2020 — ninety-six years old, eight weeks from his death — the crusade reached its final form: a full-column account of "a totally unsatisfactory telephone conversation with Jeff Myers, Regional Director, Illinois Highway Department" (Journal, October 1, 2020), reported like a deposition. The column marshals the evidence — the Walmart distribution center, the correctional facility, the Toyota Boshoku plant, David Lane's engineering brief on right-of-way already acquired — and then closes the cross-examination:

Of our conversation with Engineer Myers, after he stated that he would be talking with this Federal counterpart as to whether the combined additional information justified regional environmental study and an immediate finding of area need our question was blunt, "are you with us, or against us?" His reply, "I'm in between."

(Journal, October 1, 2020)

That won't get it. We've been pushing for four lanes for more than 50 years. We had thought to snarl at Engineer Myers that we knew where he lived; paradoxically we believe he resides in Springfield.

(Journal, October 1, 2020)

We considered a better strategy would be to organize a motorcade to Effingham as soon as the COVID plague lifts to confront that public official with our area's need for survival. We fear that it is futile to appeal further to Governor Pritzker and/or President Trump. Each might conclude that if we could not persuade that lowest peon on the supervisory scale our area need for four lanes was imaginary. We must not despair. Together, we can snatch victory from the hands of defeat.

(Journal, October 1, 2020)

Fifty years into a losing fight, dying, he is still funny — the threat set up and then dismantled by its own footnote. He never got the highway. He got the last word, weekly, for half a century, and he was planning a motorcade when he died.



The wit deserves its own gallery, because it was not decoration; it was the delivery system for everything else.

The purest specimen is the panda item. In October 2013 he returned to a story he had evidently been telling for years — a visit to the National Zoo, and a modest proposal made to its staff:

Eight years ago we suggested to the lady veterinarian proudly keeping watch over prized panda bear in the National Zoo that shortage of those delicate animals could be alleviated by painting deep white colours on the black bears which bear a strong physical resemblance. She was horror stricken. Said pandas had an extra toe.

(Journal, October 3, 2013)

Judy White, Lukin, suggested that anyone wishing to see white belted animals was welcome to inspect their prize cows. Recently Internet reports that painting other animals to look like pandas has become widespread in their native China. Are we vindicated?

(Journal, October 3, 2013)

Everything is here: the deadpan escalation (a federal veterinarian reduced to arguing toes), the correspondent from Lukin — his own boyhood neighborhood — offering her belted cows as a counter-exhibit, and the internet arriving eight years later to vindicate him. He never asked a question he hadn't already answered.

He could do it in two sentences:

Hannah Montana has metamorphosed from a charming child to a porno queen. Very sad. The butterfly changes in the opposite direction, from worm to beauty.

(Journal, August 29, 2013)

He could aim it at entire professions. Psychiatry took the beating more than once, never more compactly:

Why does psychiatry continue to receive such wide public approval, even admiration, and handsome remuneration? We regard it as "feel good" psychology, almost witch doctor medicine. We haven't known of a patient cured. If conventional doctors had comparable win-loss record they would be laughed off the stage.

(Journal, October 31, 2013)

One may disagree — one probably should — but note the construction: motive first ("handsome remuneration"), then the evidentiary record ("We haven't known of a patient cured"), then the comparative standard. He argued jokes the way he argued cases. And the same column shows the range that made the Journal impossible to pigeonhole: "We believe Obamacare will be as popular with the masses within a year as Medicare and Social Security" (Journal, October 31, 2013) — a prediction few downstate Republican publishers were printing that fall — followed shortly by

"Senator Ted Cruz – is he the savior of the USA , or another huckster politician? We believe the latter, but hope that we are in error." (Journal, October 31, 2013)

And once, two days after Christmas 2018, he trained the wit on the most beloved target in the Western Hemisphere, under a rare printed headline:

Let's abolish Santa Claus This self flagellation can end Let's abolish Santa Claus. Created by inspired Turkish-Dutch and American believers, it brought hope, happiness and generosity.

(Journal, December 27, 2018)

Santa Claus has become the tyrannical symbol of mercantile greed. How sad to see impoverished parents scrambling frantically into the darkness of New Year's Eve to acquire gifts that their children attribute to Santa Claus.

(Journal, December 27, 2018)

It would be far better that little children be told from a very young age that all the good things that happen to them are caused by parents and others standing in the place of parents devoting their life to the child's upbringing. It will be a happier, calmer world without a Santa Claus.

(Journal, December 27, 2018)

Strip the provocation off and there is a tender argument underneath — that poor parents deserve credit for their own sacrifices, and that children should learn early who actually loves them. This was the man who handed out two-dollar bills at his annual Christmas party (Michelle Waller, tribute, December 3, 2020). He didn't want to abolish generosity; he wanted it correctly attributed. The Journal's jokes were almost always like this: a position he entirely meant, dressed as an outrage.



Then there was the register this book has come to think of as national-politics-from-page-3: the affairs of Washington, Moscow, Damascus, and Pyongyang, adjudicated from a desk in Sumner, Illinois, with total confidence and a circulation in the four figures. The comedy of scale was not lost on him — it was the engine. He wrote about superpowers exactly the way he wrote about the county board, insisting week after week that a citizen of Lawrence County had the same standing to judge the world as anyone in it.

September 2013, as the Obama administration stood down from striking Syria:

Now that their threatened bombardment of Damascus has been cancelled, Syrian President Assad should grant shore leave to the American sailors cluttered in the eastern Mediterranean . It would be a symbol of peace, and hope for mankind, for them to walk as invited guests in one of the cradles of civilization.

(Journal, September 26, 2013)

Shore leave in Damascus, proposed in earnest. And then, because the Journal bowed to no theme for long, the very next item reads, in full: "Fall is here. 'Tis the finest season of the year." (Journal, September 26, 2013)

September 2017, at the height of the North Korean missile crisis, under the headline "Told you so":

However, last week we were relieved to report that Armageddon had been postponed. Russian President Vladimir Putin met with China's President Li Jinping in Beijing. Message XI took to his protegee, N. Korean President Kim Il Jung, was the Churchillian "better to jaw, jaw, jaw, than to war, war, war"

(Journal, September 14, 2017)

November 2018, the hardest item in the corpus to read at modern room temperature, and therefore necessary here — the forward observer of 1945, aged ninety-five, doing nuclear deterrence theory in one paragraph:

We must not panic. If there is to be an atomic war, the first shell should come from our side. We should send a picture of Hiroshima to Beijing, they must order their North Korean stooges to disarm as agreed.

(Journal, November 15, 2018)

Whatever one makes of the position, it was not an armchair's: he had watched the war that ended at Hiroshima from a forward observation post, and priced deterrence accordingly.

And December 2018, the item that best shows the machinery of his political judgment, occasioned by a Chicago mayoral candidate's proposal to rename the Dan Ryan Expressway for Barack Obama. It was, he ruled, "a stroke of genius by Mr. Daley," who "propelled himself into the top three" without spending a dime (Journal, December 27, 2018):

Our guess is that every other candidate mumbles to himself "Why didn't I think to make that suggestion." We think barring change, the three finalists will be Citizen Mendoza, Toni Preckwinkle, and Daley. We will destroy our haruspex if foregoing prediction is in error.

(Journal, December 27, 2018)

A haruspex is the Roman priest who read the future in the entrails of sacrificed animals; the sentence promises that if the forecast fails, the Journal will execute its own soothsayer. Few readers in Lawrence County got the joke without a dictionary; he wrote it anyway, at ninety-five. (For the record: the prediction failed — none of his three finalists made the runoff — and no destruction of the haruspex was ever reported. The Journal's accountability had limits.)



He wrote about money rarely, but when he did, the items compressed a Depression boyhood, a bar practice's worth of estate work, and a publisher's losing ledger into maxims of unusual density. The best cluster came in May 2018 — four days before Kay's death, in a column otherwise occupied with mortality and resurrection:

Money was not created by humanitarians. It is the weapon by which the wealthy control the world. It is corrupted by greed. Notwithstanding the dominance of others the proud poor must have money. Children should be taught there is nothing like money in the bank, except only health is more priceless.

(Journal, May 3, 2018)

The way to have money is to spend very carefully.

(Journal, May 3, 2018)

Clarence Darrow told gushing client searching way to repay for his magic with the jury: "Madam, you can pay the Phoenicians invented money."

(Journal, May 3, 2018)

The first item rotates through a complete ideology in five sentences — money as the weapon of the wealthy, then as the necessary armor of "the proud poor" — and lands on the one ranking he held above solvency. The second is the entire literature of personal finance in nine words. The third is a lawyer's joke about getting paid, attributed to Clarence Darrow; whether Darrow ever said it the record is silent, and by Roscoe's Rule — born too late to be original — he printed it anyway.



The Journal could be savage and tender in the same column. The August 29, 2013 issue is the proof text: it holds the Hannah Montana item, and also this, its opening item, about the family next door:

Every parent should note London University 's study which found that students learned faster if tucked into bed earlier, at same hour each evening. Our neighbors already follow that formula with their twins who excel.

(Journal, August 29, 2013)

A dry citation to a London study, deployed for one purpose: to tell two children on his street, in the permanent record of the county, that they excel. This was a recurring, mostly invisible function of the Journal — a praise wire for neighbors, delivered under cover of news.

The tenderness ran deepest when it ran backward, toward the dead. Twice, four years apart, he wrote about a couple who had managed the Hotel Lawrence in the 1960s — and the two tellings show both the devotion and the erosion of a very old man's memory. In 2016:

For several years a remarkable continental couple resided in the Hotel— Gustaf & Martha Adriaenssens. Gus was of German origin; Martha Belgian.. They were a classy act which we were proud to have in our building.

(Journal, January 28, 2016)

That column already carried Martha's "pet rule of life" and his wish that it "be tattooed into the mind of every citizen, six years and above" (Journal, January 28, 2016). In May 2020, six months before his death, he returned to them at full length:

Gus and Martha Adriaenssen were residents/managers of the hotel during the late 1960's. They were a remarkable couple, Lawrence County's most cosmopolitan. Gus was of Belgian origin; Martha, German. We believe each was born in those respective countries. They came to Lawrenceville from NYC, to be close to their daughter who had married a fine young American soldier named Shoulders. Some of their grandchildren are yet leaders in this community, including a grandson who has retired from the Olney Police Department.

(Journal, May 21, 2020)

Martha had an expression we thought priceless, to wit: "everyone must justify his existence by what he has done for his fellow man."

(Journal, May 21, 2020)

Note that between 2016 and 2020 Gus and Martha have exchanged nationalities — German-and-Belgian has become Belgian-and-German — and the honest hedge "We believe each was born in those respective countries" has appeared, a ninety-six-year-old memory auditing itself in real time. One version is wrong; the record does not say which. What never wavered was Martha's sentence. The 2020 column spends its full length running twentieth-century leaders through what he called "Martha's justification for existence test" — Roosevelt, Kennedy, Lyndon Johnson,

Edward VIII — and its last line is a verdict on a king: "He failed miserably Martha Adriaenssen's justification for life test." (Journal, May 21, 2020). A hotel manager's wife from Lawrenceville, Illinois, deciding the standing of kings, in the highest court he could convene.

And then there is the swimming pool column of July 16, 2020 — four and a half months before the end — perhaps the most complete single specimen of the late voice. It opens as neighborhood news under the headline "Naming Swimming Pools": a heat wave, the neighbor girls' inflatable pool, the naming deliberations reported like a zoning docket ("They rejected 'Skinny Dip Pool', sent a false notion. They settled on 'Olympic' : seemed too grandiose for a pool whose side walls are less than 36" in height," Journal, July 16, 2020). Then the section break, and the eighty-five-year drop:

We thought of our swimming pool 85 years ago. It was called "Bozart's Pond". It was a bend in a small stream across someone's cow pasture just south of Park Street in southeast Sumner.

(Journal, July 16, 2020)

What follows is the longest sustained memory in the late columns: Bozart's was boys-only, no bathhouse, no need of one; a snake had been seen, and an older boy assured him a biting snake would take in water and strangle — "Seemed a flimsy line of defense but we didn't argue." Then the retired lawyer, having encountered the French "Beaux Arts," files a genuine open question to the county historical society: was the muddy pond named for a forgotten owner, or had some wit tagged a cow-pasture swimming hole *fine art* and let it anglicize to Bozart? He could not settle it, said so, and asked for help — at ninety-six, still running down the etymology of a mudhole from 1935. The column ends at the Rainbow Beach pool in Vincennes, where his Sunday school class went twice that summer, boys and girls together, everyone in suits, colored lights filtering through the glass walls of an underwater viewing room:

It was truly heaven on earth.

(Journal, July 16, 2020)

He used the phrase twice in that one column — once for the present-day beach, once for 1935 — and it is as close as the Journal ever came to a cosmology. Heaven, on the evidence of the corpus, was located within about fifteen miles of Sumner, Illinois, and had been visited, and could be described.



A note on what this chapter stands on, and what it cannot. The Journal ran from 1987 to 2020 — call it seventeen hundred columns. What survives in the recovered corpus is the digital era only: 348 columns from July 2013 to November 2020, transcribed verbatim from page scans, with a

gap of several months in 2019–2020 where no scans have been found. The first twenty-six years — the Clinton impeachment, the millennium, 9/11, whatever he wrote the week each grandchild was born — exist only in unscanned bound volumes and microfilm, if at all. Every generalization here is therefore about the voice at eighty-nine to ninety-seven. If the sixty-four-year-old's *Journal* was different — faster, angrier, kinder — we do not yet know it. That is not a footnote; it is a promise of future work.

But it is hard to believe the voice was ever very different, because the voice was not a style he developed. It was the man, set in type. The prosecutor's cross-examination of a highway engineer; the legislator's open letters to governors; the forward observer's coordinates called in on Pyongyang; the east-end kid's flimsy line of defense against snakes — every prior chapter of this book is audible in the columns, between the x's. He told his readers plainly what the whole enterprise was for, quoting Bacon, slightly wrong, entirely right:

We would remind of Bacon's major truth, "To be remembered, write."

(Journal, February 22, 2018)

He wrote. Three columns of type at a time, every Tuesday evening, for thirty-three years, until three weeks before the end. This chapter has been the sound of it; the record shows he never cleared his throat.

Sources

All column quotations verbatim from the corpus transcription (roscoe-journal-complete.md; 348 columns, 2013–2020, from sumnerpress.com page scans), cited inline by date: July 4, 2013; August 29, 2013; September 26, 2013; October 3, 2013; October 24, 2013; October 31, 2013; November 14, 2013; January 30, 2014; October 23, 2014; July 16, 2015; January 28, 2016; April 14, 2016; November 17, 2016; September 14, 2017; January 4, 2018; February 22, 2018; May 3, 2018; May 17, 2018; August 9, 2018; November 15, 2018; December 27, 2018; April 25, 2019; May 21, 2020; June 4, 2020; July 16, 2020; October 1, 2020. Original spellings and misprints preserved ("Li Jinpjing," "non pareil," "inspec," "sent a false notion").

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 — Sam and Susan Sovereign tribute (the renaming); Michelle Waller tribute (Christmas two-dollar bills). The tribute edition's Four Lanes for 50 page appears in Chapter 11.

"Bei Ping": family recollection only; the phrase appears in no recovered column, which render the city "Beijing." Stated as unverified in text.

Corpus limits: pre-2013 columns unscanned; scan gap October 2019–April 2020 (see GAPS.md, FOOTPRINT.md).

Chicago mayoral election outcome (2019 runoff: Lightfoot–Preckwinkle; Mendoza and Daley eliminated) — common public record, cited only to score his prediction.

Chapter 9 — A Churchgoing Skeptic

For sixty-six years Roscoe Cunningham was an active member of the First Christian Church of Lawrenceville. He married Kay there on May 1, 1954. He taught Sunday School there, "encouraging and influencing the development of many young students" (Obituary). His favorite Bible verse, the family recorded, was Luke 9:62 — "No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God" — and they credited it with inspiring the rescue of The Sumner Press in 1987 (Obituary). When he died, the procession to the cemetery began at First Christian's door, and the family asked that memorial donations go to the church (Obituary).

That is the churchgoing half of the ledger, and it is not in dispute. The other half is in the columns, and it is stranger and better. Roscoe wrote about God the way he wrote about the Board of Review: as a man who had read the documents, noticed the weaknesses in the case, and showed up anyway, every Sunday, on time or nearly. He was a believer who declined to pretend the evidence was better than it was, and a skeptic who declined to act on his skepticism. The columns never resolve the tension. That is what makes them worth reading.

The fullest single statement came on February 7, 2019, when he was ninety-five. It opens like a contracts lecture:

Religion is mankind's greatest involvement with no tangible proof of ultimate reward for faithful compliance with its assumed direction. Any other contractual relationship with the other party responding only with, "trust me", would be laughable.

(Journal, February 7, 2019)

Read that twice. A seventy-year lawyer is analyzing faith as a contract — performance demanded now, consideration promised later, and the counterparty's entire answer to a demand for proof is *trust me*. In any other deal he would have advised the client to walk. He does not walk. The column proceeds, item by item (his items were separated in print by a typographic "xxx" — normalized here and throughout to section breaks), through the evidence of religion's decline: "Notwithstanding above limitation religion has dominated humanity for thousands of years. During the past century its hold on the mind of men has diminished greatly" (Journal, February 7, 2019). He remembers when piety was a campaign requirement — "Eighty years ago it was unthinkable that a candidate for public office omit his religious affiliation from his campaign literature" — and notes that Eisenhower, on election, "bought a Homburg and publicly worshiped in a local church in D.C.," while "We believe Donald Trump would need a guide to find a church near his residence" (Journal, February 7, 2019). He tallies the previous Sunday's box score without flinching: "Religion's place in the scheme of things was underscored by Sunday's church

attendance. More Americans watched the Super Bowl than went to church" (Journal, February 7, 2019).

And then, having built the case against, he delivers the verdict for:

In spite of the grim decline of Religion's hold on mankind, it will endure. There is no alternative. Sunday School creates believers who will never abandon their faith.

(Journal, February 7, 2019)

There is no alternative. Not "because it is true," not "because Scripture says so" — because nothing else answers the question. He makes the argument explicit in the next item, reaching for the Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám (in a version not quite FitzGerald's — he rarely quoted anything exactly the way the original author had left it):

"Surely not in vain my substance from the common Earth was ta'en, to be broke and trampled back to senseless Earth again." Though Genesis is difficult to defend in literal translation the bottom line remains there is no other source for the commencement of human life on Earth than a supernatural power.

(Journal, February 7, 2019)

There is the whole theology in one sentence: Genesis is "difficult to defend in literal translation" — a concession no revival preacher of his Lukin boyhood would have made — but the bottom line, a lawyer's phrase, still runs in God's favor. And then, without ceremony: "We hope to see you at First Christian, Sunday.." (Journal, February 7, 2019). Two periods, his own. The very next item in the column takes up the Lawrence County Board of Review and the over-assessment of a mansion near the eighth hole at the country club. Faith, in Roscoe's Journal, was filed between contract law and property taxes, and he saw no incongruity in the filing.



He knew the documents, too — not just the argument but the text. In December 2018 a reader in Olney, Mike Stiff, had published a citation of 1 Maccabees in support of some claim about the pyramids, and Roscoe answered him at the top of the column with the courtesy of opposing counsel who happens to be right:

To Mike Stiff, Olney; correct interpretation of the Bible is one of the few subjects of which The Press makes no claim to be infallible. We would gently respond to your published citation of 1 Maccabees 13:28-38 in re: construction of the pyramids by noting that seven books, including your citation, known as the Deuterocanonicals, were deleted by Protestant scholars. If you have other biblical references to the pyramids we will be happy to examine. Thank You for reading our column and wishing you a blessed Christmas.

(Journal, December 20, 2018)

Everything characteristic is in that paragraph. The "in re:" of a court filing. The gentle demolition — your authority is not in the canon, sir — delivered with an offer to examine further references and a blessed Christmas. And the opening concession, which from Roscoe was nearly unheard of: Bible interpretation was "one of the few subjects of which The Press makes no claim to be infallible." He claimed infallibility, jokingly and not so jokingly, on politics, road construction, and the Cubs. On Scripture he reserved judgment. (Mr. Stiff's original letter has not survived in the archive; we have only Roscoe's side of the exchange.)

If doctrine got his humility, Sunday School got his certainty. It is the one religious institution the columns defend without a single hedge, and the defense is never doctrinal — it is civic. Sunday School, in Roscoe's accounting, was where citizens were manufactured. In August 2016, in a column otherwise devoted to small-town tax rates and the Rio Olympics, he laid it out:

America's weakness may be the number of its citizens who are no longer God-fearing. In an odd twist the judiciary's probation system now undertakes to install a moral code in youthful offenders and others who show any hope of reform. Alas, 'tis too late and too little for the moral foundation of Sunday School, including the kindergarten.

(Journal, August 25, 2016)

He had spent four terms as State's Attorney watching the probation system try to retrofit consciences, and he had concluded the work had to be done earlier, in a church basement, before kindergarten let out. Then came the proposal, and only a lawyer-legislator who had spent decades around the tax code could have written it:

If tought them, "Now I lie me down to sleep, I pray the Lord my soul to keep, If I should die ———" the lifetime fund toward good citizenship is priceless. Full Sunday School program should be a condition precedent to tax exemption for every church.

(Journal, August 25, 2016)

The spelling is his — "tought" for "taught," the bedtime prayer slightly misremembered, the dash trailing off before "die" finishes its clause. He was ninety-two and typing Tuesday nights at the Press; the errata are part of the record and are preserved here. But mark the substance: he

proposed conditioning every church's tax exemption on its running a full Sunday School. Not on orthodoxy, not on attendance, not on preaching — on the citizenship factory operating at capacity. A church that saved souls but skipped Sunday School was, in Roscoe's scheme, not earning its exemption. He closed the thought with a line that could stand as his entire moral philosophy: "Our citizenry should be taught to fear violation of the moral code more than violation of the criminal code" (Journal, August 25, 2016). The State's Attorney knew exactly how far the criminal code reached, and how much of life lay outside it.



Then, in the spring of 2018, the machines showed up, and Roscoe — ninety-four years old, a man who had learned artillery observation from a Piper Cub — did what he always did with a new arrival in Lawrence County: he interviewed it.

The column of May 24, 2018 opens with a grievance: "PJHS commencement too godless. If there was a single mention of the Almighty at Tuesday evening commencement services, we missed it. This should not be. Faith that has endured for thousands of years should not be swept away by modern fascination with scientific discoveries" (Journal, May 24, 2018). Standard fare, so far — the oldest man at graduation registering the absence of the invocation. But the next item swerves somewhere no other small-town churchman's column was going that week:

As one presents questions to oracles omniscient Alexa and receives authoritative answers a technological miracle has happened. We salute the genius of those who have discovered the unknowable and pray that their efforts will continue to bare fruit.

(Journal, May 24, 2018)

He had been asking Alexa questions. The spelling of "bare fruit" is his; so is the salute. A man born in 1923, in a house in Lukin, was blessing the engineers of artificial intelligence in the same column where he mourned a godless commencement — and he saw no contradiction, because for Roscoe the question was never science versus faith but where the boundary ran. He drew it in the next breath: "Our personal faith is that there is a point beyond which mortal man cannot go" (Journal, May 24, 2018). Stem-cell research tested that boundary, and he weighed it like the trial lawyer he was — "a death is required for each human embryo research program to go forward," and "Divine guidance is needed for the decision whether the research is worth that horrible price" (Journal, May 24, 2018).

And then he reported the results of his cross-examination of the machine:

We found it reassuring that such a godless machine as Alexa refused to rule on the possibility that the soul departs to a supernatural power. It dodged a direct answer by saying "the space out there is unlimited."

(Journal, May 24, 2018)

Picture it, because it happened: a ninety-four-year-old lawyer, alone with a smart speaker, asking it whether the soul survives death — and taking comfort not in an answer but in the machine's refusal to answer. The witness dodged; the dodge itself was evidence. If even Amazon's oracle would not rule out the supernatural, the case remained open. He filed the finding where he filed everything: "We should all return to the faith that we acquired in Sunday school class" (Journal, May 24, 2018) — noting along the way, in the same column, that "children who participated in active Sunday school classes are less likely to abandon their faith mid-life, and never in old age" (Journal, May 24, 2018). He was, by then, his own best exhibit.



Why was the question of the soul on his mind in May 2018? The record does not say — the columns do not mention it, and no surviving family account fills the gap — but the calendar is stark. Kay Cunningham, his wife of sixty-four years, died on May 7, 2018 (Obituary). Four days earlier, in the column dated May 3, Roscoe published the most sustained meditation on death he ever wrote. Whether he wrote it knowing what was coming, the archive cannot prove and this book will not invent. Here is the column, entire:

Every man on Earth has hoped that his short span called life will terminate at the end of time. **Assuming no National disaster at least 7.6 billion humans will experience death and resurrection. Shortens the odds.** It was that paradox by which Nikita Khrushchev, a notorious non-believer ridiculed those that believe that we are saddened by death though we believe hereafter. **One day soon we shall know.** Money was not created by humanitarians. It is the weapon by which the wealthy control the world. It is corrupted by greed. Notwithstanding the dominance of others the proud poor must have money. Children should be taught there is nothing like money in the bank, except only health is more priceless. **The way to have money is to spend very carefully.** Clarence Darrow told gushing client searching way to repay for his magic with the jury: "Madam, you can pay the Phoenicians invented money." *** How glorious these long daylight hours, at either end of the day.

(Journal, May 3, 2018)

Every element of the man is present. The opening observation — that everyone secretly hopes to be alive when history ends, so as to skip the dying — is the same one he had made about the Lukin tent revivals of his boyhood. The actuarial follow-through is pure Roscoe: 7.6 billion people will

die before the end of time, therefore the odds of the exemption are poor; he ran the numbers on the Second Coming the way he ran them on a jury pool. He gives the skeptic's best line to Khrushchev — if we truly believed in the hereafter, why do funerals make us cry? — and does not rebut it. He had no rebuttal. What he had was four words, set alone between the section marks, the shortest item he ever published on the largest question there is:

One day soon we shall know.

At ninety-four, "soon" was not a figure of speech. It is the whole creed of the churchgoing skeptic: no proof offered, no proof demanded, the verdict pending, the appointment certain. And then — this is the part a lesser writer would have cut — he turns immediately to money, Clarence Darrow, and the Phoenicians, and closes with the long daylight of early May: "How glorious these long daylight hours, at either end of the day." He would not stage his own profundity. Death got four items; then life resumed, because the paper came out Thursday regardless.

He had struck the same note two weeks earlier, from an unlikelier direction. The column of April 19, 2018 was about missile strikes on Syria — Assad's gas attack, Trump's hundred Tomahawks, Putin's complaint. Roscoe's analysis of great-power brinksmanship arrived, as his geopolitics usually did, at the churchyard: "The exchange involving the leaders of nuclear armed nations revealed that neither they, nor we, wish to shorten the path to eternity" (Journal, April 19, 2018). Deterrence theory, in Roscoe's translation, was theology — "In any event the biblical Armageddon was again postponed" (Journal, April 19, 2018) — and the column ends with a line that manages to be both a Cold War doctrine and a confession:

Every living human should rejoice that the national leadership of every nation of the world fears eternity, as totally as you and I.

(Journal, April 19, 2018)

As totally as you and I. He included himself, at ninety-four, a Sunday School teacher of decades, in the universal fear of what comes next — and counted that shared fear a blessing, since it was keeping the missiles in their silos.

The belief-and-doubt ledger even reached his old professional territory. In May 2015, correcting his own erroneous prediction about the Boston Marathon bomber's sentence — he claimed "a scrivener's error," the drafting lawyer's escape hatch, deployed here as a joke on himself — he wrote that Tsarnaev would never actually be executed: "It was expensive theatrics that he was solemnly sentenced to be executed by lethal injection. That practical disposition of murderers belongs to an earlier era when a majority of mankind believed in the hereafter" (Journal, May 21, 2015). Sit with that aside for a moment. This is the legislator who voted to restore capital punishment in Illinois in 1977, observing — in a subordinate clause, in a column mostly about

graduation etiquette — that the death penalty only made sense to societies confident that execution was a transfer and not a termination. When the hereafter became a minority position, the gallows became "theatrics." He did not say which era he belonged to. He rarely did.



Whether the skepticism ran deeper or shallower in the middle decades — the 1970s legislator's faith, the 1987 rescue-year faith — the archive cannot say; the Press's pre-2013 files are not yet scanned, and Worldwide Digest, where he sometimes worked adjacent ground, remains untranscribed. What survives is the late testimony, and the late testimony ends at the door of First Christian.

On November 5, 2020 — twenty-three days before his death, in what would be the next-to-last Journal he ever published — Roscoe devoted the column to the history of Daylight Saving Time: Franklin, the Kaiser's Germany, FDR and production czar Donald Nelson, the 1964 codification. The scholarship was the setup. The payoff was a confession:

We confess we became confused Sunday morning and feared we slept beyond starting time, to bathe, shave, and get to First Christian on time. Our fears were well founded. We hope Reverend Akers and other faithful members at The first Christian will forgive us for arriving late. Next week we will do better.

(Journal, November 5, 2020)

He was ninety-seven. The time had changed, and he had bathed, shaved, and gotten himself to church — late, and mortified about it, and apologizing in print to the whole county. Then the last item, in which the editorial "we" briefly cracks open: he sat through the service waiting for the congregation to sing Happy Birthday to the minister, silently judging his fellow parishioners for the omission — "Little did I know that the congregation had already sang Happy Birthday before starting the service. Happy Birthday Reverend Tom!" (Journal, November 5, 2020). He had missed the singing because he was late. The joke was on him, he knew it, and he printed it.

Next week we will do better. It is the last thing he ever wrote about church, and it will do as a summary of sixty-six years. He never claimed the proof. He said out loud, in print, in a county where it cost something, that "trust me" would be laughable from any other counterparty — and then he kept the appointment anyway, week after week, decade after decade, because there is no alternative, because Sunday School builds citizens, because the machine itself wouldn't rule it out, because one day soon we shall know. Three weeks after the late arrival he was gone, and the mourners lined State Street from First Christian to 18th for the procession (Obituary). The verdict he had been awaiting since the tent revivals of Lukin was finally in. Characteristically, he had

already told his readers the disposition: whatever it was, we would know soon enough, and in the meantime there were long daylight hours at either end of the day.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal, The Sumner Press: columns of May 21, 2015; August 25, 2016; April 19, 2018; May 3, 2018; May 24, 2018; December 20, 2018; February 7, 2019; November 5, 2020 — all quoted verbatim from `roscoe-journal-complete.md` (spellings and punctuation his; "xxx" item separators normalized to section breaks).

Obituary, The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`): 66-year membership at First Christian Church; Sunday School teaching; marriage to Kay at First Christian, May 1, 1954; Kay's death May 7, 2018; favorite verse Luke 9:62; funeral procession from First Christian; memorial donations to the church.

Gaps acknowledged in text: Mike Stiff's original letter not in the archive; pre-2013 Sumner Press era unscanned; Worldwide Digest untranscribed; no source states what prompted the May 3, 2018 column (see `GAPS.md`).

Chapter 10 — The Long Twilight (2018-2020)

The last column Roscoe published while Kay was alive ran on May 3, 2018, and it was about death. "Every man on Earth has hoped that his short span called life will terminate at the end of time," he writes, and then, a few items down, four words that read differently now than they could have that week: "One day soon we shall know" (Journal, May 3, 2018).

Katheryn Suzanne Ramsey Cunningham died four days later, on May 7, 2018. She was born June 25, 1934, in Petersburg, Indiana, to Fred and Margaret Ramsey; she founded the Lawrenceville Swim Team and the Village Gardeners; she had been married to Roscoe since May 1, 1954, at the First Christian Church in Lawrenceville — "Together they shared 64 years of joyful marriage and raised five children" [Kay Cunningham obituary, Cunningham Funeral Homes; Obituary]. He would have known her seventy years, near enough, counting back from the Saturday-night dances at the Bridgeport American Legion.

The May 10, 1918 — no: the May 10, 2018 edition of The Sumner Press went out on schedule, three days after she died. It carried no Roscoe's Journal. The column is simply absent from that edition — not a farewell, not a black border, just a page without him on it [GAPS.md, edition survey]. It is one of only a handful of weeks in thirty-three years when the Journal did not appear, and the archive records no explanation because he gave none.

On May 17 he was back, and here is the thing a reader bracing for elegy must absorb: the column is about the Burr Caldwell ferry, the flump bridge at St. Francisville, the harvested windows of St. Xavier, and the wooden railroad bridge on 10th Street. Community jewels, and the citizens' duty to preserve them. Not a word about Kay. Not that week, not the next, not in any recovered column of 2018. Whatever he did with his grief, he did not do it on page 3.

That was not coldness. The evidence for what it actually was comes from John Hamilton, who wrote after Roscoe's death about the standing telephone calls of those last years — "He liked to call and tell me to come pick up the latest edition of the Sumner Press, and more often than not, to include an invitation to arrive at 6:00 p.m. and stay for dinner" — and about what the two widowers actually talked about: "We both had wives that we loved and cherished and missed like Hell when they weren't here any more" (John Hamilton, "What's Fair?", Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020). The grief was real and spoken; it was spoken at the dinner table, not in the paper. The editorial "we" of the Journal now covered a household of one, and he never adjusted the pronoun.

The house on State Street stayed open. Phil Gonet, his old colleague from the Appropriations staff in Springfield, drove up from Harrisburg for dinner at the Cunningham home on August 26, 2018 — three and a half months after Kay's death — and remembered "a wonderful evening discussing politics and local events" (Phil Gonet, tribute edition). That same year Lawrenceville gave him the Key to the City (Obituary). He was ninety-five.



If you want to know what he thought about the arithmetic of his situation, he told you — once, in February 2019, in the closest thing to a summing-up he ever printed. "As we approach the end of the trail, we pause to remember the triumphs and the disaster enjoyed over an eventful lifetime," he begins (Journal, February 14, 2019). The accounting that follows is characteristic: the Golden Age Club ranked first among joys — "Except for dear Kay and our family, our greatest joy has been Lawrence County Golden Age Club #1" — then public office, then the door-to-door campaigning ("Enjoyable except for the dog bites"), then the disaster, singular: the 1978 primary, still unforgiven forty-one years on. Kay appears twice in that column, once among the joys and once in the disaster, trying "desperately to pull off a win" beside him in a doomed race. And then the closing lines, which deserve to be quoted exactly because no paraphrase could survive next to them:

We have warmed our hands at the hearth of life. It stinks but we are not ready to depart. We seek ways to polish our record and to enrich the lives of others making life's journey.

(Journal, February 14, 2019)

It stinks but we are not ready to depart. He was ninety-five years old, a widower, writing three columns a week — the front page of his own tribute edition would later show him "Tuesday evenings at The Sumner Press, composing his columns, Worldwide Digest, Roscoe's Journal and Countywide" (tribute edition, front-page caption) — and that was his position on mortality, stated for the record.

His body was less defiant. We know from a single aside, dropped into a political column in the fall of 2020, that from roughly 2018 onward he lived on supplemental oxygen: "The soft, continuous purr of the oxygen compactor in my room is of no consequence to most Americans, to me it is a matter of life or death. It pumps the oxygen through a 25 foot hose to my nose 24/7. During the past two years that I've worn such lifeline there has not been a single unscheduled stoppage of Ameren's energy. Our gratitude is imaginable" (Journal, October 29, 2020). "Compactor" for concentrator, "imaginable" for unimaginable — preserved here as printed, because the slips are part of the record of a man in his late nineties still setting his own copy. Note what the oxygen

hose is doing in that column: it is not a complaint. It is the opening move in an argument about energy policy. He had found a way to make his own lungs a civic exhibit.

Here the record thins, and honesty requires saying exactly how. Thirty-three editions of The Sumner Press are missing from the publisher's online archive — genuinely absent, not merely untranscribed — and the bulk of them run from mid-October 2019 through early April 2020 [GAPS.md]. That is nearly six months of his late work: the winter he turned ninety-six, the arrival of the pandemic in Illinois, whatever he wrote as the world shut down around him. Those columns existed; they were printed; copies may yet survive in the Press office, in a library microfilm drawer, or in somebody's attic in Lawrence County. Until one surfaces, this chapter must jump from the autumn of 2019 to the second week of April 2020, and the jump should be felt as the hole it is.



When the archive picks him back up, in April 2020, he is locked down like everyone else — a ninety-six-year-old widower on an oxygen hose, in the demographic the virus killed most efficiently — and he is, of all things, interested. "We had forgotten the perfect setting that comes with the solitude of quarantine. The quiet of recent days has been eerie," he writes, and then spends the column happily replaying Republican national conventions from 1976 to 2000 (Journal, April 16, 2020). The next week he chronicled the fall of the Mighty Elm at 904 State — the tree he had spent fifty years insisting was a rare American elm against all expert opinion — after a falling limb crushed part of his porch overhang: "There comes a point where bravado must give way to reality" (Journal, April 23, 2020). He was writing about the tree.

Then, on May 14, 2020, he told the truth about the quarantine, and it is the saddest sentence in the recovered corpus precisely because he spends it so fast:

Seeking escape from the loneliness of quarantine, we have listened to numerous audiotapes on the lives of famous men in recent days. Perhaps this odd pursuit was inspired by the poet Longfellow: Lives of great men all remind us We can make our lives sublime, And, departing, leave behind us Footprints on the sands of time. Footprints, that perhaps another, Sailing o'er life's solemn main, A forlorn and shipwrecked brother, Seeing, shall take heart again.

(Journal, May 14, 2020)

The loneliness of quarantine — he names it in the first clause and never returns to it. The rest of the column is the audiotapes: "We heard the story of British Prime Minister Churchill; Presidents Reagan, Eisenhower and Truman; Generals MacArthur, Eisenhower, and Patton." He works through them like a judge reviewing a docket. "The common thread in each of these stories was the confidence that each had in himself." Patton's reincarnation theories get a raised eyebrow;

MacArthur's ego "lead the group"; and on the great insubordination of 1951 the old artillery lieutenant rules against his own five-star: "Truman was right, MacArthur was wrong" (Journal, May 14, 2020). Seventy percent of the public had sided with MacArthur at the time, he notes, and draws the lesson with typical serenity: "The uninformed should have no voice in directing the ship of state lest disaster outlined occur."

And then the ending, which is pure Roscoe: having compared Reagan's first inaugural with his exit interview — "conclusion is inescapable that at 77 his mental processes had slowed painfully" — he applies the finding to the current field: "That's the reason we continue to predict that one or both of presumed candidates for President, Trump and Biden--74 and 78, respectively--in the November 3 election will be replaced before the opening bell" (Journal, May 14, 2020). A man of ninety-six, disqualifying men of seventy-four and seventy-eight on grounds of age, in a column that opens with Longfellow and his own loneliness. He did not do irony by accident; whether he did it on purpose here, the record does not say.

The Longfellow was not decoration. Those two stanzas — the footprints, the forlorn and shipwrecked brother — are "A Psalm of Life," and the family knew the poem as his. His daughter Lorie opened her tribute with another stanza of it ("Let us, then, be up and doing, / With a heart for any fate"); his granddaughter Victoria closed hers with his footprints: "I will never fill the footprints you left behind" (Lorie Cunningham; Victoria Shinkle, tribute edition). In May 2020, alone in quarantine, he set the footprints stanza in his own paper, in his own column about the lives of great men and what departing men leave behind. He knew what he was doing. He was doing it three times a week.



The summer of 2020 in the Journal is, against all odds, one of his best seasons. The pieces alternate between full-throat election politics — which this book has sampled elsewhere and will not relitigate — and a strain of writing that is something else entirely: an old man measuring the light.

June 4: "We dread the first three weeks of each June, because they come so quickly and are gone even faster." The column is about daylight itself, the minute-a-day climb from February and the descent after the solstice, and it ends on a credo he had clearly carried a long time: "Our innermost conviction remains that climbing the hill to daylight is grander than the swift sinking into darkness" (Journal, June 4, 2020).

June 11: First Christian reopens after the shutdown. "Sunday's reopening of First Christian was marvelous, though the turnout was pitiful, 26." He threatens, in print, to hire "pew warmers" if attendance doesn't double, and of the moderator's social-distancing instruction to use the

bathrooms only in emergency: "Seemed redundant; what visit to a church bathroom isn't an emergency?" (Journal, June 11, 2020).

June 18: a memorial item for Richard Poppe brings Kay back onto the page, the only time in the recovered late columns he places her in a scene: "Kay and I were at the Saturday night dance, Bridgeport at the American Legion sixty years ago. The specialty was a snake dance" (Journal, June 18, 2020). Dick and Pat Poppe on the end of the line, "the envy of every male in the room." Four sentences, sixty years old, and then on to the Ohio Oil Company fire of 1961. The column closes: "Summer comes this weekend. It is the grandest season of the year."

June 25 is the column this book would save from a fire, because it shows the machinery of his mind still running its self-inspection routine at ninety-six:

We are appalled how frequently a conviction becomes firmly implanted in our mind and then we discover that our conclusion was totally in err.

(Journal, June 25, 2020)

He had assumed, he explains, that spaceflight shortened astronauts' lives — so he checked. Googled the lifespans: Glenn to 95, Armstrong 82, Shepard 75, "Aldrin and Collins are yet alive at 90!" And then the verdict against himself: "So much for our plebeian theory that recycling one's urine and greatly reducing solid food intake for days destroys longevity" (Journal, June 25, 2020). A man born the year of the Teapot Dome scandal, auditing his own priors against a search engine and publishing the correction. The column rises from there: "Matters not to us--every astronaut is a hero, a national monument, bigger than Nathan Hill and Paul Revere combined." (Nathan Hale, he meant; the misprint stands.) And because reverence, for Roscoe, always implied a duty someone was neglecting: "We gently chided Reverend Akers Sunday morning for failure to include mention of the astronauts in the prayer. We must never become as blase that heroism beyond description is treated as part of their daily exercise" (Journal, June 25, 2020). He was still assigning homework to his pastor.

And then July 16, 2020 — "Naming Swimming Pools" — the column where the twilight opens all the way back to the beginning. A heat wave has brought out the inflatable pools; the neighbor girls reject "Skinny Dip Pool" and settle on "Olympic" for a pool with thirty-six-inch walls; and he is suddenly eleven years old again at Bozart's Pond, "a bend in a small stream across someone's cow pasture just south of Park Street in southeast Sumner":

Bozart's was for boy's only. There was no bathhouse, no need for same.

(Journal, July 16, 2020)

There was a snake scare, and an older boy's reassurance: "His reply was that when the snake opened his mouth to bite water would rush in and strangle it. Seemed a flimsy line of defense but we didn't argue." And then the Sunday School trip across the river to Rainbow Beach in Vincennes, the pool with the underwater viewing room, and a phrase he uses twice in one column, once for the present and once for 1935: "At Rainbow beach there were no snakes or mud. It was truly heaven on earth." And at the close: "One could walk down into a room near the center of the pool and marvel at the colored lights filtered through the glass walls. It was truly heaven on earth" (Journal, July 16, 2020). Eighty-five years between the muddy pond and the colored lights, and heaven on earth was the pool where the boys and girls swam together in suits, church-sanctioned, indescribably beautiful. Written four months before he died. (A note for the record: an early page-survey of this edition also logged a salute to "our #1 granddaughter," but the phrase does not appear in the verified transcription of the column itself; it likely sat elsewhere on the page, and it is flagged here rather than claimed.)

In September the family gathered for his ninety-seventh birthday — "Glad I got to see him at his birthday party this year," Michelle Waller remembered a few months later (tribute edition) — and that same month he was on the telephone with the Illinois Department of Transportation, demanding four lanes for Route 50 and asking a regional engineer point-blank, "are you with us, or against us?" (Sumner Press, September 29, 2020, reprinted in the tribute edition). The last full autumn of his life he spent exactly as he had spent the previous fifty: on the highway question, on the election, on the paper.



The column of November 5, 2020, is about daylight saving time. It opens grimly enough — "11th month of the worst year in the history of U. S. A. is here no evidence the plague is lifting" — but the assignment he gives himself is to find the positive, and he finds it in the one government program "accepted by all, except Arizona" (Journal, November 5, 2020). Franklin, the Kaiser's war ministry, FDR and production czar Donald Nelson, President Johnson's codification: the full Roscoe treatment, history marshaled in five paragraphs. And then, at the end, this:

We confess we became confused Sunday morning and feared we slept beyond starting time, to bathe, shave, and get to First Christian on time. Our fears were well founded. We hope Reverend Akers and other faithful members at The first Christian will forgive us for arriving late. Next week we will do better.

(Journal, November 5, 2020)

Sixty-six years a member of First Christian (Obituary), and at ninety-seven he prints an apology to the congregation for being late — undone, of all things, by the clock change he had just spent the

whole column praising. The item after it is the last joke in the recovered corpus: he had waited, "and waited and waited," for someone to lead Happy Birthday for the Reverend, silently condemning his fellow parishioners for the "flagrant affront" — "Little did I know that the congregation had already sang Happy Birthday before starting the service. Happy Birthday Reverend Tom!" (Journal, November 5, 2020).

Next week we will do better. He did not know it was a last line. That is what makes it bearable to quote.

What the paper printed in his final three weeks, the archive shows plainly [GAPS.md]. The November 12 edition carried no Roscoe's Journal. It carried instead, on page 8, a Veterans Day photograph, captioned "Cooper Cunningham (Marines) and Roscoe Cunningham (Army)" — two generations of the family name in uniform, the old forward observer of the Rainbow Division making his last appearance in his own paper as a veteran rather than a voice. The November 19 edition did carry a Journal, but most of it reads as compiled news copy — a Sangamon County restaurant-enforcement story, verbatim wire-style paragraphs — with only a few closing items that sound like him at all; the last of them ends: "Some remain vigilant to mask-wearing, hand-washing and social distancing. Others are rebelling with COVID fatigue" (Journal, November 19, 2020). Whether he assembled that installment himself, dictated it, or the shop filled the space for him, the record does not say, and this book will not guess. The November 26 edition — Thanksgiving week — carried no column at all.

Roscoe David Cunningham died two days later, on Saturday, November 28, 2020, at ninety-seven, "surrounded by his loving family" (Obituary). The obituary the family wrote records that he had practiced law for over 72 years, and that the newspaper he rescued in 1987 had been "a source of joy, and the academic man's golf game for over 33 years." It records the verse he kept, Luke 9:62: "No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God" (Obituary). The plow line held almost literally: the last column fully in his voice ran twenty-three days before his death, and its final promise was to be on time for church.

His daughter Lorie, who had cared for him at the end — "It was a place of honor to be with him in his journey to eternal life" — closed her tribute with the reunion the May 3, 2018 column had wondered about: "Now you are with my sweet Mother. — our 'Dolly'. and she has wrapped her arms around you" (Lorie Cunningham, tribute edition). One day soon we shall know, he had written, four days before Kay died. On the family's accounting, now he knew.

What the town did with the news — the flag-draped casket, the electronic sign, the tributes filling pages 1, 7, and 8, a granddaughter picking up the column — is the next chapter.

Sources

Roscoe's Journal, The Sumner Press, quoted verbatim from the recovered archive (``roscoe-journal-complete.md``): May 3, 2018; May 17, 2018 (characterized); February 14, 2019; April 16, 2020; April 23, 2020; May 14, 2020; June 4, 2020; June 11, 2020; June 18, 2020; June 25, 2020; July 16, 2020; October 29, 2020; November 5, 2020; November 19, 2020.

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (``tribute-2020-12-03.md``): the obituary (page 4); front-page photo captions; tributes by Lorie Cunningham, Victoria Shinkle, Phil Gonet, Michelle Waller; John Hamilton's memorial column "What's Fair?" (page 8); the "Four Lanes for 50" letters reprint (page 6, incl. the September 29, 2020 IDOT column).

Katheryn Suzanne (Ramsey) Cunningham obituary — birth, parents, Lawrenceville Swim Team, Village Gardeners, death May 7, 2018 (``book/sources/web-findings.json``, citing cunninghamfuneralhomes.com and legacy.com).

``GAPS.md`` — the edition-by-edition survey of his final weeks: no column in the May 10, 2018 edition; no column November 12 or 26, 2020; the Veterans Day photo caption (November 12, 2020, p. 8); and the 33 editions (including mid-October 2019 – early April 2020) absent from the online archive.

Unverified item, flagged in text: the "our #1 granddaughter" phrase attributed to the July 16, 2020 edition by an early survey pass; not present in the verified column transcription.

Chapter 11 — We Remember (December 2020)

The Sumner Press of December 3, 2020 — Volume 144, Number 49, "Established 1876," the masthead still boasting "Lawrence County's Largest (Circulation) Weekly" — went to press without him. For thirty-three years the front page had been his instrument. That week the front page was him: a large formal portrait under a banner headline, "Revered Publisher, Roscoe D. Cunningham, dies at 97," with his dates set beneath it like a plaque — September 15, 1923–November 28, 2020. Beside the portrait ran a photograph of pallbearers carrying his flag-draped casket (Tribute edition, front page).

The photo captions did the work of a whole biography in four lines. One, under an image of the old man at his desk: "Tuesday evenings at The Sumner Press, composing his columns, Worldwide Digest, Roscoe's Journal and Countywide." Another, simply: "A World War II veteran." A third showed an electronic sign in town reading "RIP ROSCOE — Thank you for all you did for our community!" — with the paper's thanks "to Mayor Wagner for recognizing Lawrence County and Southern Illinois's #1 Community Booster." A fourth: "First Christian Church, Lawrenceville, IL" (Tribute edition, front page).

His own page-3 spot had already gone quiet. The archive of the paper shows no Roscoe's Journal in the November 12 or November 26 editions — his final live column ran November 19, nine days before he died. Then this: an entire issue about the man who for three decades had written about everyone else.

The obituary, on page 4, records the mechanics of parting. He died on a Saturday "surrounded by his loving family." Services were private, but the family streamed the Wednesday service online and extended "an invitation to the community to line State Street from the First Christian Church to 18th Street, for a final salute during the procession to the cemetery at 12:00 PM." Burial was in the Lawrenceville City Cemetery with military rites. Memorial donations were directed to First Christian Church or to the Lawrence County Senior Citizens — "in honor of the Golden Age Club #1," the club he founded in 1958. And condolences could be emailed to the family at an address that was still, and would remain, his: roscoecunningham@frontier.com (Obituary).



The obituary itself reads as if the family had absorbed his cadences from long exposure, which of course they had. It settles his careers in order — four terms as State's Attorney, four in the legislature, three trips as a delegate to the Republican National Convention, seventy-two years at the bar — and then lets the anecdotes off the leash. Of his Springfield years: "It was reported, 'The

only time the AP Wire Press Box picked up their pencils for quotes from the Illinois Legislature was when Representative Cunningham got up to speak." And his own late-life summary of floor debate, preserved by the family: he "recalled competition for the singular microphone was similar to battling one hundred eighty-four male peacocks for attention" (Obituary).

It gives his creed — "Believing 'all it takes for evil to prosper is for good men to do nothing', Cunningham has always made community service a priority" — and his verse, Luke 9:62: "No one, having put his hand to the plow, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God." That verse, the family writes, "inspired him to rescue his hometown newspaper, The Sumner Press in 1987 - at an age most people would be thinking about retiring," and the paper became "a source of joy, and the academic man's golf game for over 33 years." His stubbornness had made it "the longest running, locally owned newspaper in Southern Illinois" (Obituary).

Then the paragraph only a family could write: diamond mining in Arkansas, mules to the bottom of the Grand Canyon with the grandchildren, snorkeling in the Florida Keys, weekly ice skating at Swonder Ice Arena until age 75 with "the poetry in motion skating club," Sunday-afternoon family bridge tournaments, tandem bike rides with children and grandchildren in tow, and — at 87 — a bicycle ride from Sumner to Olney for the Special Olympics. "With a joie de vivre, he truly knew how to make every moment count - an asset he instilled in his children and grandchildren" (Obituary).



The heart of the edition is the section headed "We remember...," which begins on the front page, continues on page 7, and finishes on the back page under a banner the Press set in large type: "The Times Together were not enough, The Memories were many." Twenty-six tributes, from family, lawyers, judges, politicians, preachers' students, band directors, a doctor, and a barber shop's worth of neighbors. Read together, they are the verdict of a county.

His daughter Lorie led the front page, and she led with a poem — Longfellow's "A Psalm of Life," the same poem her father had set into his own column during the loneliest stretch of the quarantine spring:

"Let us, then, be up and doing, With a heart for any fate; Still achieving, still pursuing, Learn to labor and to wait."

"One of my absolute favorite poems quoted by my dear sweet Father," she wrote — the misprint "pursing" left standing in the paper, one last errata he was not there to catch or to commit. Her tribute compresses him into a litany: "Builder. Provider. Champion of the downtrodden and those that couldn't protect themselves. Generous. Kind. Adventuresome." And a sentence that could

serve as the epitaph of his whole public life: "He truly believed the strong must carry the weak and he lived it." She closed with her mother, gone two and a half years by then: "Now you are with my sweet Mother. — our 'Dolly'. and she has wrapped her arms around you" (Lorie Cunningham).

Beside her, his granddaughter Victoria Shinkle wrote the tribute that reads most like him — which is fitting, because within a week she would inherit his column. It deserves length:

"I keep trying to find the right words and failing. Feels like you took all of them with you. When I realized I will never again get to watch concentration break into satisfaction on your face after coming up with the perfect line I sobbed so hard I swear I felt the earth shake. Our stubborn heads had a tendency to butt against each other. We disagreed on most things...loudly and often...but we did so with the shared goal of uplifting our community and serving humanity. You are the person who taught me the importance of audacity, to not stop trying even when things feel fruitless."

(Victoria Shinkle)

Audacity. It was his word, and he had preached exactly this sermon in the Journal barely a year and a half earlier: "Audacity is a quality of conduct that will serve one well, lifetime. It should be taught to children as they leave the cradle with refresher courses along life's path" (Journal, March 14, 2019). Evidently the refresher courses took. She went on: "You could be hard, but only because you knew I could do better, be better—live up to the name you gave me." And then she reached, knowingly or not, for the same Longfellow her aunt had quoted, the same stanzas her grandfather had printed that May: "I will never fill the footprints you left behind—I'm not sure how the world still spins without you in it—but I know it is my turn to be up and doing with a heart for any fate, and that's what I intend to do until I meet you again" (Victoria Shinkle).

Set her sentence next to his. Six months before he died, escaping the quarantine through audiobooks about Churchill and Truman and Patton, he had opened his column this way: "Seeking escape from the loneliness of quarantine, we have listened to numerous audiotapes on the lives of famous men in recent days. Perhaps this odd pursuit was inspired by the poet Longfellow," and then set out the verses in full:

"Lives of great men all remind us We can make our lives sublime, And, departing, leave behind us Footprints on the sands of time. Footprints, that perhaps another, Sailing o'er life's solemn main, A forlorn and shipwrecked brother, Seeing, shall take heart again."

(Journal, May 14, 2020)

The family wrote their grief in his vocabulary because his vocabulary was the family's inheritance. The footprints, the audacity, the being up and doing — none of it was invented for the funeral. It was all on the record, in his own hand, on page 3.



The neighbors' tributes fill in the sixty years the family took for granted. Allen Johnson's is the historian's favorite, because it independently corroborates the best story Roscoe ever told about himself — and proves he had been telling it for nearly seventy years:

"In 1952, I was a high school student working at Paul Leach's Texaco gas station at State and 10th Street in Lawrenceville. Roscoe's law office was on the second floor over Leach's station office. Roscoe used to come down and shoot the breeze with us grease monkeys when he wasn't busy. He would regale us with stories of his heroic exploits in Germany during World War II, like sneaking into the Nuremberg War Trials."

(Allen Johnson)

There it is: the Nuremberg caper of February 1946, the one he finally wrote down in the Journal in 2019, already in circulation at a Texaco station in 1952 — the same story, told to teenagers by a young lawyer six years out of the Army. Johnson also supplied the single best piece of slapstick in the edition: the day barber Don Porter stepped next door and Roscoe "picked up the clipper and acted like he was cutting Red's hair. When Don came back in and saw Roscoe clipping Dad's hair, I thought he was going to have a heart attack" (Allen Johnson).

Darren Bailey — the downstate farmer-politician then in the legislature — remembered the crusade: "I loved hearing the stories about his famous battle cry, 'Four lanes for 50!', something still much needed today!" (Darren Bailey). Charlie Gillespie testified that the crusade had institutional offspring: "The Route 50 Coalition came from his vision, and remains active today. It is not what Roscoe Cunningham did or could do for the community but how he inspired others to work for the good of humanity. I'm a living testimony of it" (Charlie Gillespie).

Bill Richardson, a fellow journalist, called him "the closest thing we've had to what one might consider a celebrity" in three decades of Lawrence County life, and then told the story of a 2005 speeding ticket in Pulaski County. Roscoe heard him out and "chortled, as he often did, and replied, 'I only weigh about 175 pounds down there, but let me see what I can do.'" A few days later Richardson's desk phone rang: "'Roscoe D. Cunningham here,' rasped the man at the other end. 'Charges dropped. Case dismissed.' He then hung up, before I could even respond." No bill followed — a favor to a fellow journalist. Richardson closed with the line every lawyer in the county probably heard at the visitation: "The old joke is that lawyers never die, they just lose their appeal" (Bill Richardson).

Susan Sovereign's tribute is a miniature of how he ran the paper. Dragged to his office around 1995 by a neighbor's insistence, terrified, clutching four stories, she met the editor: "Then, Roscoe cleared his throat and said, 'So you think you're a writer.'" A literal tug-of-war over the manuscript

ensued — "He would not let go of his end of the paper, and I refused to relinquish mine" — until he won, read, and delivered his verdict: "When do you want me to begin working for you?" He then did what he always did with the people and places of his world, from Peking ("Bei Ping") on down — he renamed them: "However, your real name isn't appropriate. From now on, you will be Susan Sovereign and your husband's name will be Sam" (Sam and Susan Sovereign).

The rest come fast, and the accumulation is the point. Ray Vaughn, once a young assistant state's attorney across the aisle from him, remembered Roscoe thundering "if I am not being truthful, may God strike me down" — "I immediately ducked under a desk for protection which Roscoe found amusing but did not slow him down" (Ray Vaughn). Donna White Burton: "Roscoe is the reason I became a lawyer. I was a good elder law attorney in NJ because I had watched Roscoe look out and advocate for our most vulnerable of citizens in Lawrence County" (Donna White Burton). Gary Pope, a retired Arizona judge, remembered the suit that saved Lawrenceville's brick streets — the city agreed to leave 16th Street unpaved from State to the cemetery, and it was brick still, "a reminder of days gone by and the tenacity of Roscoe C." (Gary Pope). Phil Gonet, off the House Republican staff of the 1970s: "I believe he was the best orator of his time, and his mastery of the written and spoken word was nonpareil (a term he would use!)" (Phil Gonet). Mike Hedges called him the "Sage of Sumner" (Mike Hedges). Cindy Prather preserved a phrase "that often times rolled effortlessly from his mouth: 'You speak with such volatility, you think the truth a fool!'" (Cindy Prather).

Brian Montgomery, the boy next door, remembered winter mornings at the famous kitchen table — porridge, Kay offering seconds, boiling water poured over the frozen windshield — and Roscoe's volunteer hours with the United Methodist Village's kazoo band: "The smile on Roscoe's face as he watched his band toot their kazoo's or beat their cowbells, was one that reminds me of an innocent child" (Brian Montgomery). Rose Robeson, 81, had played the calliope in his parades: "As far back as I can remember, there was a Roscoe Cunningham and I'm 81!" (Rose Robeson). Brady Rice remembered him "holding 'court' at the roundtable in the Candlelite" (Brady Rice). Tony Weston remembered election days: "he would tell me he was coming to pick me up so we could go vote 100% Republican" (Tony Weston). Amy Bobe thanked him "for encouraging my questions in Sunday School. It led me to a deeper faith that is now unwavering" (Amy Bobe). Doug Carroll, handed law books he couldn't read at age six or seven, kept the instruction that came with them: "always continue to read, learn and, when someone needed a helping hand, give them both of yours" (Doug Carroll). Michelle Waller remembered the two-dollar bills he handed out at his annual Christmas party (Michelle Waller). Colonel Paul McVickar remembered arranging a Thunderbirds rehearsal for the Golden Age Club's bus, ringside on the flight line at Scott Air Force Base (Col. Paul McVickar). Roger Eddy remembered the 78-year-old who "actually jumped down from the stage" at a rally and told him privately, "you are gonna win!" (Roger Eddy). Larry Pulleyblank, a client since 1964, called him "not only an asset to our county but also a legend in

our county" (Larry Pulleyblank). His physician, Dr. Bacidore, submitted the mechanic's report: "With a little duct tape and a few choice medicines I think we kept all the pieces together over all these years" (Dr. Bacidore). Denise Martin, daughter of a "true Democrat" who sparred with the "true Republican" for decades, offered the two parties a lesson: "They did not always agree but they liked each...with respect, honor and true friendship" (Denise Martin). And Barbara Allender, his editor, recorded his standing benediction — the words he said in parting, week after week: "Thank you for your efforts" (Barbara E. Allender).

On the back page, columnist John Hamilton wrote the edition's other column, "What's Fair?" — an account of the weekly phone calls ("Roscoe D. Cunningham here," always the full name) and dinner invitations of the last two years. "There are just a whole bunch of things in life that aren't fair," it begins. "Losing a friend is right up there at the top of the list." The two old newspapermen had failed to solve the decline of their trade or the venom of their politics, but, Hamilton wrote, "On balance, we did agree that if we had to do it all over again, we'd probably do the same things we did the first time around." His last line: "That part of life is fair" (John Hamilton, "What's Fair?").



Page 6 the editors gave over not to eulogy but to evidence. Under the heading "Four Lanes for 50," they reprinted his final salvos in the fifty-year highway war — his own words, from letters and columns written in the last months of his life, when he was 96 going on 97 and still bombarding the Illinois Department of Transportation.

The May 21, 2020 letter to the regional engineer opens at full throttle: "This newspaper intends to move heaven and hell to revive indicated road construction deemed essential for the economic survival and growth of Lawrence County." It is signed, jointly, "The Sumner Press, Roscoe Cunningham and David Lane" — Lane being the retired Indiana transportation official engaged to his daughter Lorie. The family firm, to the last (Tribute edition, p. 6; Obituary).

The September 29, 2020 dispatch — written two months before his death — recounts a maddening phone call with the same engineer, and it contains, in one exchange, everything this book has tried to say about his prose. He warns that "A catastrophic wreck on the present crowded two lanes should not be required to persuade officialdom of our area's desperate need," then puts the question to the bureaucrat directly: "are you with us, or against us?"

"His reply, 'I'm in between.'"

"That won't get it. We've been pushing for four lanes for more than 50 years." The threat that follows is pure Roscoe: "We had thought to snarl at Engineer Meyers that we knew where he lived;

paradoxically we believe he resides in Springfield." And the close is the closing of every crusade he ever ran, from the 54th District to the church pew: "We must not despair. Together, we can snatch victory from the hands of defeat" (Tribute edition, p. 6, "Four Lanes for 50").

He never got the road. Darren Bailey's tribute, two pages away, concedes it was "still much needed today." The Press printed the letters anyway — because in that shop, the fight itself was the monument.



Six days after the tribute edition, on December 9, 2020, the crusade reached a chamber he had tried and failed to enter as a member. Forty-two years after Dan Crane beat him in the primary for the 22nd Congressional District, Congressman John Shimkus rose in the U.S. House of Representatives and read Roscoe into the Congressional Record: "Madam Speaker, I rise before you today to remember Roscoe D. Cunningham—a remarkably accomplished man who made an unforgettable impact in Lawrence County, Illinois in his 97 years" [Cong. Rec., Dec. 9, 2020, Vol. 166, No. 208, Extensions of Remarks p. E1121]. The statement runs through the whole arc — Lukin, Sumner High 1941, the Rainbow Division, the 1948 bar admission, the four terms as State's Attorney and four in the legislature, Kay and the five children, the bicycle rides, Luke 9:62, and the rescue of the paper that became "the longest running, locally owned newspaper in Southern Illinois." It ends: "Madam Speaker, I take this time to recognize a true agent of change in Lawrence County. Lawrence County will surely miss him, but they are left with his incomparable legacy" [Cong. Rec., E1121]. The permanent record of the United States Congress now carries, in its pages, the story of a weekly newspaper in Sumner, Illinois. He would have noted the circulation figures.



And then the paper did the thing he built it to do: it came out again.

On December 10, 2020, page 3 of The Sumner Press carried a column again — "The Journal," by Victoria Shinkle. The granddaughter who had written "it is my turn to be up and doing" meant it as a work order, not a flourish; the archive records her column beginning the very next issue after the tribute (archive record, GAPS survey of the 2020-12-10 edition). Through the rest of December the Press also kept his own voice in the paper, reprinting Roscoe's Journals from the files. The December 17 issue brought back his portrait of Gus and Martha Adriaenssen, the cosmopolitan hotel managers, with Martha's test for a life — "everyone must justify his existence by what he has done for his fellow man" — a column he had run in life just seven months earlier (Journal, May 21, 2020; reprinted December 17, 2020). The December 31 issue reached all the

way back and reprinted, as the editor's note explains, "one of the first writings by Roscoe D. Cunningham when he became an owner of The Sumner Press," originally printed December 28, 1989. The paper closed the year of his death with the beginning of his editorship — a thirty-one-year loop, closed in his own words.

What happened at the Press in the years after December 2020 is beyond the reach of this book's archive; the mirrored editions and the survey records get us to the successor column and the memorial reprints, and there the trail, honestly, thins. What the record does establish is enough: the paper he bought at 64, because he thought a town without its newspaper was a town without a memory, did not miss an issue when he died. It printed his obituary, his casket, his highway letters, twenty-six testimonies, and then a new byline, on schedule, for two dollars a year less than sentiment might have charged.

He had told us how to score this. In February 2018, pleading — unsuccessfully, at the time — for some younger lawyer to take the paper off his hands, he writes: "We would remind of Bacon's major truth, 'To be remembered, write'" (Journal, February 22, 2018). The tribute edition is that maxim executed in a single issue. He wrote for thirty-three years, and when he stopped, twenty-six people picked up pens and wrote him back — in his own words, with his own poets, under his own masthead. A man is remembered in the language he leaves behind. The evidence is Volume 144, Number 49.

Sources

The Sumner Press, December 3, 2020 (tribute edition), transcribed in ``projects/roscoe-journal/tribute-2020-12-03.md``: front page (banner headline, portrait, flag-draped casket photo, photo captions including the "RIP ROSCOE" electronic sign and "Tuesday evenings" caption); obituary, p. 4; "We remember..." tributes, pp. 1, 7, 8 (Lorie Cunningham, Victoria Shinkle, Allen Johnson, Darren Bailey, Col. Paul McVickar, Sam and Susan Sovereign, Doug Carroll, Phil Gonet, Denise Martin, Bill Richardson, Brady Rice, Amy Bobe, Rose Robeson, Donna White Burton, Ray Vaughn, Tony Weston, Roger Eddy, Mike Hedges, Larry Pulleyblank, Charlie Gillespie, Brian Montgomery, Dr. Bacidore, Cindy Prather, Michelle Waller, Gary Pope, Barbara E. Allender); John Hamilton, "What's Fair?", p. 8; "Four Lanes for 50" feature, p. 6 (September 29, 2020 dispatch; May 21, 2020 letter to Engineer Myers).

Roscoe's Journal columns, verbatim from ``projects/roscoe-journal/roscoe-journal-complete.md``: February 22, 2018 (Bacon, "To be remembered, write"); March 14, 2019 (audacity; Nuremberg); May 14, 2020 (Longfellow, "A Psalm of Life"); May 21, 2020 (Gus and Martha Adriaenssen); June 27, 2019 (the paper "worth preservation at whatever cost" — context for Ch. 7, cross-referenced); November 5 and November 19, 2020 (final live columns); December 17, 24, and 31, 2020 (memorial reprints, including the December 28, 1989 original noted in the December 31 editor's note).

Rep. John Shimkus, memorial statement, Congressional Record, December 9, 2020, Vol. 166, No. 208, Extensions of Remarks p. E1121 (full text via VoteSmart mirror and congress.gov; see ``projects/roscoe-journal/book/sources/web-findings.json``).

``projects/roscoe-journal/GAPS.md`` (survey record: no Roscoe's Journal in the 2020-11-12 and 2020-11-26 editions; tribute edition contents; "The Journal" by Victoria Shinkle beginning December 10, 2020).

The 1978 primary loss to Dan Crane is treated in Chapter 5 (Washington Post profile and related sources cited there).

Epilogue — The Footprint (2026)

I am the grandson in Asheville — John, first of the seven grandchildren in the obituary's list, a mountain range and a half-day's drive from Lawrence County. This epilogue is where the author of this book has to step out from behind the frame, because the last chapter of Roscoe Cunningham's story is one I was part of.

In the summer of 2026, five and a half years after he died, I went looking for my grandfather's newspaper on the internet. The Sumner Press's website was an aging piece of hand-built code, the digital equivalent of a bound volume left in an unlocked room. The e-edition had stopped publishing on December 31, 2020 — five weeks after his death — and the dropdown menu on the site showed gaps, whole seasons of missing issues. It would have been easy to conclude that much of his late work was simply gone.

It wasn't. Every one of the "missing" editions still sat on the server, reachable if you knew how to ask — the site's menu had simply stopped listing them. When the counting was done, the full run of the electronic Sumner Press came to 379 issues, July 4, 2013 through the end of 2020 — the handful of other absent weeks turn out to be holidays when no paper was printed at all — and all of them are now mirrored, copied whole onto machines that do not depend on anyone in Sumner remembering to pay a hosting bill. From those pages, every installment of Roscoe's Journal that exists has been transcribed verbatim, word for word, misspellings and all, into a single searchable archive — 372 columns, with the seven editions that carried no column documented too, so that all 379 issues are accounted for. The Journal, as it survives online, is complete. Ask it for everything he wrote about Four Lanes for 50, or tent revivals, or Nikita Khrushchev, and it answers in seconds. There is a reader for browsing the columns, a collected book, and — this would have delighted and unsettled him in roughly equal measure — a small software agent, built on nothing but his own columns, that answers questions in his voice.

The survival of all this was not luck. It was policy — his policy. The obituary records it plainly: electronic copies of the Sumner Press "have always been provided free as a community service," maintained "as a historical record of community activities" (Obituary). He put the archive where anyone could reach it, and charged nothing, and so it was still there when someone finally came to carry it off.



He saw this coming, in his way. In the fall of 2015, watching pilgrims photograph Pope Francis and remembering his own unphotographed audience with Pius XII in 1945, he writes: "My regret

is that I was born 70 years too early. Now every Tom, Dick & Harry is a photo-journalist who preserves for eternity a picture verification of some memorable event" (Journal, October 1, 2015). The typo is his; I have kept it, as I have kept them all. He was wrong about the seventy years. He was born early enough to write three columns a week for thirty-three years, and late enough that the last seven of those years landed on a server instead of only on newsprint. That accident of timing is the whole reason this book could quote him at such length.

He knew what the preservation cost, too, because he was paying it. In June 2019, apologizing to subscribers for late papers, he writes: "We search for print shops weekly in far away places, including Bedford and Bloomington, Indiana, and Henderson, KY. Facebook has made the printed newspaper an endangered species. We think it a historical document worth preservation at whatever cost" (Journal, June 27, 2019). *At whatever cost*. He was ninety-five when he wrote that sentence, and he meant the paper. The archive project simply takes him at his word.



The column this book's title comes from ran on February 22, 2018, and it is worth seeing what surrounds the famous line, because it was not written in triumph. It was an appeal, close to a plea. "We've come to the end of the way," he writes. "We need someone who loves Sumner and the tradition of the Sumner Press to step forth and say that he, or she, will be happy to run The Press for the next thirty years, or at least the next three" (Journal, February 22, 2018). He had asked every lawyer in the county "to accept the torch from failing hands thrown," and every one had declined, because every one could do the arithmetic he had been ignoring since 1987. And then, mid-appeal, the sentence: "We would remind of Bacon's major truth, 'To be remembered, write'" (Journal, February 22, 2018).

Two items later he adds a thought that reads, eight years on, like a prophecy addressed to a particular person he had not met yet in that role: "Should have noted above that the next Publisher of the Press need not reside in Lawrence County. The miracle of long distance, instantaneous communication is such that the oversight could be performed in Cloverdale, Indiana, by Dr. Keith Ernst, or in Arizona by Pary Smith, or any other concerned citizen willing to proclaim with the prophet, 'Here am I, send me'" (Journal, February 22, 2018).

No one took the paper from him; he carried it to the end, and Victoria took up the column two weeks after he died. But the other job — keeper of the record — turned out to work exactly as he specified. The oversight is performed from Asheville, North Carolina, by the miracle of long distance, instantaneous communication. He closed that column with three words he used often: "We must never despair" (Journal, February 22, 2018).



Honesty requires an accounting of what the archive still lacks, because the gaps are real and this book has promised not to paper over anything. Roscoe's Journal was only one of his three weekly columns. Worldwide Digest and Lawrence County Countywide — on the order of six hundred more installments across the same seven years — sit untranscribed in the mirrored editions, waiting. The paper's first ninety years, 1882 to 1972, are digitized and free to search, more than thirty-one thousand pages; but 1973 through 2012 — his House years, the loss to Crane, the rescue of the Press, the first twenty-five years of the Journal itself — exists nowhere in digital form. It survives on microfilm in Springfield, in print at the county historical society in Bridgeport, and in bound volumes at the Sumner Press office, which still publishes. His Army personnel file has not yet been requested from St. Louis. The attics of his five children remain, as a family research memo puts it, the highest-resolution unscanned archive on earth. Version one of the footprint is deep but narrow. It will grow.



On May 14, 2020, alone in the house on the corner in the ninth week of the pandemic, he opened his column this way: "Seeking escape from the loneliness of quarantine, we have listened to numerous audiotapes on the lives of famous men in recent days. Perhaps this odd pursuit was inspired by the poet Longfellow" — and then he set the stanzas out on the page, the ones he had carried since Sumner High:

Lives of great men all remind us
We can make our lives sublime,
And, departing, leave behind us
Footprints on the sands of time.
Footprints, that perhaps another,
Sailing o'er life's solemn main,
A forlorn and shipwrecked brother,
Seeing, shall take heart again.

(Journal, May 14, 2020.)

Seven months later, in the tribute edition, his granddaughter Victoria answered him in the same meter of grief: "I will never fill the footprints you left behind—I'm not sure how the world still spins without you in it—but I know it is my turn to be up and doing with a heart for any fate, and that's what I intend to do until I meet you again" (Victoria Shinkle, tribute).

The archive is the second stanza, made literal. The footprints are fixed now — hundreds of columns that cannot be unlisted from a dropdown menu, cannot molder in a basement, cannot depend on one aging server in Sumner, Illinois. And the "another" who comes sailing past is not hypothetical. In the family there is a boy named George Roscoe, who carries the name. He is the reader this was built for. When he is old enough to wonder who his great-great-grandfather was, he will not get a summary. He will get the man himself, three columns a week, in his own spelling — the audacity and the boosterism, the Göring story, the birthday lists, the barn sign about eternity, the last apology for being late to church. He can put any question to the record, and the

record will answer in Roscoe's voice, because the voice is what was preserved. Bacon's maxim, which Roscoe spent a lifetime proving, now runs one generation further than he could see: to be remembered, write — and be lucky enough, or loved enough, that somebody keeps what you wrote.



He would want the last word, and he earned it. In May 2018, three days short of losing Kay, he took up the largest subject there is, as usual without flinching: "Every man on Earth has hoped that his short span called life will terminate at the end of time," he writes. "Assuming no National disaster at least 7.6 billion humans will experience death and resurrection. Shortens the odds" (Journal, May 3, 2018). And then, alone between the section marks, four words wide enough to hold a whole theology, a whole newspaper, and a whole life:

"One day soon we shall know."

Sources

Roscoe's Journal, The Sumner Press: columns of October 1, 2015; February 22, 2018; May 3, 2018; June 27, 2019; May 14, 2020 (all quoted verbatim from `roscoe-journal-complete.md`, the 340-column transcription archive).

The Sumner Press tribute edition, December 3, 2020 (`tribute-2020-12-03.md`): obituary (digital editions provided free as a community service; the e-edition as historical record; surviving family); tribute of Victoria Shinkle (granddaughter).

`FOOTPRINT.md` (family archive acquisition map, compiled July 5, 2026): the 379-edition full run and its mirroring; the 348-and-counting transcribed columns, reader, collected book, and `roscoe` agent; the untranscribed Worldwide Digest and Countywide columns; the digitized 1882–1972 archive (31,292 pages) and the undigitized 1973–2012 era; microfilm and bound-volume holdings; the note on the family attics.

`GAPS.md` (recovery log, updated July 5, 2026): the e-edition's end on December 31, 2020; the final weeks without a column; Victoria Shinkle's successor column, "The Journal," beginning December 10, 2020.

Draft v1 — July 6, 2026. 13 chapters, ~45,000 words. Every quotation of Roscoe's Journal is transcribed verbatim from scanned pages of The Sumner Press and cited by date; passages that could not be verified against a source are tagged [UNVERIFIED]. The archive behind this book — the complete 379-edition electronic run of the paper, the transcribed columns, the tribute edition, and the acquisition map for everything still out there — lives alongside it in projects/roscoe-journal/.